Alberto Rotundo

ONE CHILD AND A HALF

A History of the demographic policies of the People's Republic of China, 1949-2022

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INTRODUCTION

In 1979, in the People's Republic of China, a birth control policy was inaugurated that would become highly controversial. It was called 独生子女政策 (in pinyin "Dúshēngzǐ nǚ zhèngcè," literally "one-child policy," hereafter OCP, from the English “One-Child Policy”). Outside the narrow field of scientific research directly connected to it, the OCP has been interpreted as a coherent yet complex system of rules and sanctions imposed by the highest levels of the Chinese state, which over the years has unnaturally accelerated the reduction of the country's birth rate. For example, the online Treccani Encyclopedia defines the OCP as follows:

> Birth control and planning project, with the objective of drastically curbing population growth, launched at the end of the 1970s in China under the direction of Deng Xiaoping. The measures adopted, and converted into law in September 2002, prohibit couples from having more than one child, with the exception of rural families, who can have two children if the first is a girl, and some ethnic minorities. It is the central authorities who determine the annual birth quota to be allocated to the local offices, and it is up to these local offices to enforce the directives issued from above through a system of financial penalties and discrimination against couples who violate the ban. The one-child policy has generated excesses, abuses, and violence: reports from dissidents and international humanitarian organizations speak of forced sterilizations, abortions imposed by authorities even in the last months of pregnancy, kidnappings, and murders of out-of-quota children. It is estimated that the obligation to have only one child, more easily accepted in cities than in the countryside, has prevented the birth of about 400 million children, curbing the explosive growth of the Chinese population and ensuring greater well-being for families and less expenditure for the state.[1]

The OCP is similarly described by Wikipedia:

[1] "Figlio unico, politica del", *Istituto della Enciclopedia Italiana fondata da Giovanni Treccani*, Lessico del XXI secolo, 2012, <https://www.treccani.it/enciclopedia/figlio-unico-politica-del_%28Lessico-del-XXI-Secolo%29/#:~:text=f%C3%ACglio%20%C3%B9nico%2C%20pol%C3%ACtica%20del.,la%20direzione%20di%20Deng%20Xiaoping.>, last consultation 06/03/2023.

> The one-child policy (Simplified Chinese: 一孩政策) was a population planning initiative in China implemented between 1979 and 2015 to curb the country's population growth by restricting many families to a single child. The program had wide-ranging social, cultural, economic, and demographic effects, although the contribution of one-child restrictions to the broader program has been the subject of controversy. Its efficacy in reducing birth rates and defensibility from a human rights perspective have been subjects of controversy.
>
> China's family planning policies began to be shaped by fears of overpopulation in the 1970s, and officials raised the age of marriage and called for fewer and more broadly spaced births. A near-universal one-child limit was imposed in 1980 and written into the country's constitution in 1982.[2]

As debatable as it may be to rely on definitions found on such online resources, these remain a fundamental starting point, as they determine the highest level of depth of knowledge on the issue that the vast majority of people will access. The work of the historian in this sense can therefore primarily help to refine and make more precise a narrative that will inevitably remain incomplete, but which—as will be seen—requires urgent corrections. A second contribution that the approach of historical sciences can provide to the study of issues such as the one in question is placing it in a broader context, not only in a purely event-based sense—by expanding the chronological framework—but also interdisciplinary, as the need to achieve a historical synthesis requires searching for correlations with phenomena and events that demographers may have overlooked because they appear unrelated to their field. When does the demographic history of contemporary China really "begins"? Which socio-cultural factors and changes have had a concrete impact on family planning practices, while not being directly related to them? And how can these additional elements alter the overall judgment on the country's demographic policies over the last seventy years?

A large body of studies has already been produced on the OCP, primarily by

[2] "one-child policy", *Wikipedia*, Wikimedia Foundation, <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/One-child_policy>, last consultation 10/06/2024.

demographic and political sciences, but also by economists, sociologists, and anthropologists. This body essentially divides into two large subsets: the first is oriented towards studying the phenomenon in its entirety, primarily based on demographic data provided by the censuses of the PRC; the second is focused on detailed studies of cases where the population sample is extremely small but allows for an in-depth examination of the policy's functioning at the local level, and its impact on the subjects involved. The synthesis on the issue is often the result of projecting data obtained from the small sample onto the entire Chinese population, proportioning it to the few available macro-data. Less attention has been given to historical analysis and the cross-referencing of purely demographic data with other relevant statistical trends that have marked the lives of the last three generations of Chinese women and men.

One of the works that can be considered milestones in the study of demographic policies in the PRC is that of Susan Greenhalgh, who has been working since 2011 as a Research Professor of Chinese Society in the Department of Anthropology at Harvard University, after holding the chair of Anthropology at the University of California, Irvine, and previously producing her most widely circulated research while employed as a researcher at the Population Council. Much of her work on the OCP is synthesized in two works: the first, written together with Edwin Winckler and titled *Governing China's Population: From Leninist to Neoliberal Biopolitics*, was published in 2005 and provides a sufficiently comprehensive overview of Chinese demographic policies from the end of the Cultural Revolution to the period of the book's publication, both on an institutional level and from a "bottom-up" perspective, that is, from the experience of the subjects.[3] The second work by Greenhalgh from which much of her research can be summarized is *Just One Child – Science and Policy in Deng's China*, published in 2008 and particularly focused on the conception and early implementations of the OCP from 1979 to 1983. Greenhalgh explicitly adopts a Foucauldian lens: Chinese policies are interpreted as a particular form of biopolitics emerging from a transition process from the Leninist system to the "neoliberal" one, which according to the author characterized post-Maoist China, with a fundamental role played by technicians from fields far removed from the

[3] Susan Greenhalg, Edwin Winckler, *Governing China's Population: From Leninist to Neoliberal Biopolitics*, Palo Alto?, Stanford University Press, 2005, p.19.

social sciences..[4]

Works that have instead attempted to broaden the chronological framework are *China's Longest Campaign: Birth Planning in the People's Republic, 1945-2005* by Tyrene White, and *Birth Control in China 1949–2000: Population Policy and Demographic Development* by Thomas Scharping, which present the policies of the Deng period, including the OCP, as only one part—albeit an important one—of a broader theme, namely the "demographic problem" in China since the founding of the PRC.[5] The works of Scharping and White indicate a desire to view Chinese demographic policies as a complex that goes beyond the "one-child policy" on which the discourse is often exclusively focused. However, they still remain very focused on the policy itself, particularly that of the German demographer.

Fundamental for several subsequent research studies, including those by Greenhalgh, White, and Scharping, is the study published in 1987 by Judith Banister, "China's Changing Population." It meticulously analyzes the results of the 1982 census, which, as we will see, holds paramount importance in demographic studies of China due to its scope and universally acknowledged high degree of precision. Banister draws interesting conclusions from these data regarding the role of the state in reducing fertility rates in China, especially in the period preceding the implementation of the One-Child Policy (OCP). This is a key aspect that will be further explored here.[6]

Much of the historical background to be presented below is covered in greater detail in these works. These will be cross-referenced with data and insights drawn from more specific research published over more than forty years by both Chinese and non-Chinese scholars. Furthermore, a crucial contribution will come from the work – now rare and not digitized – "A Study on China's Population" by Li Chengrui, an important party cadre tasked with directing the State Statistical Bureau during the

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4 Susan Greenhalg, *Just One Child – Science and Policy in Deng's China*, Berkeley (USA), University of California Press, 2008.

5 Tyrene White, *China's Longest Campaign. Birth Planning in the People's Republic, 1949-2005*, Ithaca (USA), Cornell University Press, 2006; Thomas Scharping, *Birth Control in China, 1949–2000: Population Policy and Demographic Development*, London (United Kingdom), Routledge, 2003.

6 Banister, Judith, *China's Changing Population*, Stanford (USA), Stanford University Press, 1987.

1982 census. The book was published in 1992 by the Foreign Languages Press in Beijing and provides essential information and reflections on the reliability of Chinese demographic data, the methodology followed for conducting censuses and sample surveys in the 1980s, and the results obtained from them.[7]

The main aim of this work is to contextualize and correct, where necessary, the commonly circulated narrative about the controversial contemporary Chinese demographic policy. Therefore, the primary contribution this work aspires to make is to highlight historical facts, whether well-known or less so, and attempt to draw new connections between them. Starting with Chapter 1, we will delve into a historical phase preceding the Maoist era, observing how the significant upheavals that China experienced since the second half of the 19th century intersected with the development of demographic sciences in the West and their importation into the country, which was traumatized by wars, famines, and epidemics. Only from the second chapter onward will we address population dynamics from the founding of the People's Republic of China until the death of Mao Zedong. Similar to the preceding chapter and those that follow, alongside a political and institutional history of the main events and structural changes China underwent during this period, we will incorporate a gender perspective, focusing on the history of women and attempting to highlight its connections with the radical demographic transition that occurred in the 1970s. In the second chapter, we will also trace the evolution of demographic sciences and policies in the West during those same years, aiming to provide a better understanding of the situation at the time when China reopened to exchanges in this field. The third chapter will then commence from this initial phase of post-Maoist transition, a pivotal moment during which a relatively heterogeneous set of guidelines, regulations, and sanctions emerged, summarized under the name "one-child policy." We will observe how Chinese society and women responded to the radical population control measures, the ambiguities within the governmental apparatus at all levels regarding the enforcement of these measures, and the international response to this policy. We will follow these parallel trajectories until the 1990s when the more coercive forms of birth reduction definitively waned. The fourth chapter will examine the social, economic, and demographic dynamics that

[7] Li Chengrui, *A Study of China's Population*, Beijing (PRC), Foreign Languages Press, 1992.

gradually rendered the "one-child policy" obsolete, leading to the transition that, between 2013 and 2020, saw China effectively abandon its birth reduction policy. Throughout this analysis, numerous questions will naturally arise regarding the relationships between historical events, data, and individuals. Some of these questions will be addressed directly within the four chapters we have just summarized:

- What historical factors influenced the demographic policies of the People's Republic since its inception?
- What enabled China to achieve one of the most remarkable demographic transitions in human history?
- What was the reality of the "one-child policy"?
- What role did international organizations, academia, and foreign government institutions play in conceiving and implementing this policy, which is often perceived in common discourse as entirely foreign to the West?

Finally, a separate chapter has been dedicated to the issue of the effectiveness of the "one-child policy," which in recent years has sparked heated debates. In summary, the main conclusions that this work will reach are as follows:

- The "one-child policy" was a response to the challenge of emancipating China from prolonged famines and epidemics – not simply a reaction to Mao Zedong's supposed "natalism." It was the result of the application by the post-Maoist reformist leadership of Malthusian theories imported in the early 1900s and a technocratic approach to development.

- The OCP is not an anomaly within the Reform and Opening Up program; rather, it is one of its key pillars. However, it is also characterized by structural fragilities and ambiguities that prevent its normalization.

- The OCP does not exemplify a supposed "otherness" of China compared to the rest of the global community; rather, it was initially introduced with the full consent of the West and subsequently regularly negotiated with

international political and academic institutions.

- The most significant and enduring changes in the reproductive behaviors of contemporary China are not determined solely by restrictive policies or simple economic development, but rather by the accumulation of social and cultural factors, particularly female education.

Having thus succinctly established our ideal *endpoint*, it is therefore necessary to begin the discussion by first addressing the *starting point*.

CHAPTER 1

CHINA'S DEMOGRAPHY DURING THE “CENTURY OF HUMILIATION”, 1839-1949

Tracing a history of contemporary Chinese demographic policies, as mentioned, first and foremost involves the challenge of identifying a "starting point," a specific chronological horizon that encompasses the initial events that had a decisive and direct impact on the population control choices of contemporary China. The above-mentioned works consistently place the Maoist period as the cornerstone of a hypothetical "beginning" of contemporary historiography on Chinese demographics, summarizing its relevant facts regarding the topic in two main stages: demographic disciplines are completely abandoned, if not actively suppressed as "bourgeois science," until around the mid-1970s when the Great Helmsman begins to rehabilitate them in response to the Chinese demographic explosion. With Mao's death and Deng's rise to power, the reaction to the demographic growth of the preceding period becomes extreme, leading to the development of the OCP.[8] A few lines can be devoted to a brief overview of the situation in China in 1949, but mainly they focus on the general condition of the country or Chinese women, without delving into the specific demographic dynamics that had marked the country's history up to that point.[9] For a historical analysis of the most radical choices of post-Maoist China, however, we believe it is necessary to broaden the chronological scope of contextualization to better understand the demographic past the country was confronting at the onset of the Reform and Opening Up era. Therefore, the first chapter of this work will focus on the period known in contemporary Chinese historiography as "the century of humiliations." Before delving into the specifics of historical events, however, it is necessary to consider some premises regarding the research method and the interpretation of data.

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8 See Greenhalg, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.19.

9 See Margery Wolf, *Revolution postponed : Women in contemporary China*, Stanford (USA), Stanford University Press, 1985 pp.1-18.

1.1- The sources for a history of political demography and their issues

In the development of contemporary historical sciences, two categories of critique have conventionally been defined around the use of historical sources: external critique, aimed at establishing the *authenticity* of the document, and internal critique, whose objective is to verify its *credibility*. However, these boundaries tend to dissolve in the study of contemporary history, especially in relation to "worlds" further removed from the West.[10] When consulting documents in the Chinese language, the foreign researcher must consider to what extent an interpreted and/or translated document remains authentic, given the profoundly ambiguous nature of many of the characters in this language. It is not surprising that some of the most famous works in the Chinese philosophical tradition are published in versions with two or more translations, which present substantial differences in meaning. This ambiguity lends itself to profound manipulations in Western academia. Given that the majority of readers rely on translations to understand documents from China and may only have access to the translated text and not the original, the issue of authenticity indeed arises, despite dealing with sources that are undoubtedly valid in their Chinese version.

Then, on the adherence of sources to factual reality, i.e., at an internal criticism level, numerous problems clearly arise. It is almost trivial to recall that interpretations of studies produced with the financial and moral support of the Chinese government on controversial issues that involve it directly should be read with a critical mindset. In the current widespread climate of great suspicion toward anything coming from China, the risk in this case will perhaps be *not taking such sources seriously enough*. Margery Wolf, an important American feminist anthropologist who dedicated much of her career to studying China, acknowledges this problem from the outset of her work "Revolution Postponed," a work to which we will refer several times:

> I knew when I went to China in 1980 that women's lives were not going to be a miracle of liberation, but I was not prepared for the frequency with which I would be told of this miracle in the very presence of women's continued

[10] See Stefano Vitali, *Passato digitale. Le fonti dello storico nell'era del computer*, Milano (Italia), Mondadori, 2004, pp.129-146.

> oppression. As a result, I was often inclined to dismiss as propaganda what turned out to be real improvements in at least the material quality of women's lives. I have tried to rectify both the omissions and the tone in my final draft of the book.[11]

On the contrary, during the research for this work, we observed a certain reluctance on the part of several authors to acknowledge how the *Western* perspective may have influenced their own interpretation or that of other researchers they cite. The conscious adoption of a viewpoint that Ernesto De Martino defined as "critical ethnocentrism" allows for introducing a level of balance impossible to achieve otherwise in the analysis of such complex issues. The same level of awareness as De Martino's cannot be found in Wolf or almost any other Western author, and this seems to be increasingly true as one moves away from historical sciences towards sociological or purely demographic studies, even more so when moving away from the dimension of testimonies and approaching the study of large numbers. This is only apparently a paradox: despite common prejudice, even data and statistics have a deeply rhetorical nature.

Among the resources that historians must draw upon for their work on population-related issues, demographic data over time apparently provides "neutral" information, allowing for a relatively objective perspective on the historical phenomenon under examination. However, this appearance conceals pitfalls. Lawrence Stone, in his famous article "History and the Social Sciences in the Twentieth Century," writes:

> There are at least three ways in which the social-science-oriented historians seem at the moment to be in particular danger of allowing their enthusiasm to outrun their judgment. The first is through an intemperate and injudicious use of quantification as a solution to all problems.[12]

Demographic data, or rather their representations, are also historical sources and as such should be treated using the critical tools of the discipline we discussed in

[11] Wolf, *Revolution postponed*, p.vii.
[12] Lawrence Stone, *The Past and The Present Revisited*, Milton Park (United Kingdom), Routledge, 1987, p.32.

previous pages. It is therefore always necessary to filter the collected data based on the reliability of the source: the UNESCO database will certainly be more credible than figures without a source reported on the website of an online newspaper. When it comes to contemporary China, demonstrating a good degree of precision and adherence to reality of the data is even more important, as the general discursive context in which one operates is characterized by *a priori* suspicion. For the present research, as mentioned earlier, much of the data is derived from Banister and subsequent literature for Western sources, and from Li Chengrui for comparison with official Chinese sources; these sources in turn rely directly on the results of sample surveys and censuses conducted in China, particularly those of 1982 and 1990. Li Chengrui dedicates two entire chapters of his work to the detailed description of the "Quality Control" processes applied to the 1982 census and the reliability of the collected data.[13] The use of terms borrowed from the world of industrial production is not just a rhetorical device:

> The quality control programme, which was most suitable to China's circumstances, was formulated in accordance with the principle of "everything must be tested". [...] This working method, consistently recommended in China, is quite similar to the principle of "planning – doing – checking – action" (PDCA), a circular process for quality control in modern industrial production.[14]

Li Chengrui goes on to detail the various phases of census implementation and data quality verification, which can be summarized as follows: 1) conducting a pilot census, 2) correcting procedures based on the analysis of identified errors, 3) conducting the main census, and 4) conducting an independent sample survey to verify the data. The pilot census alone was comparable to a full census of a medium-sized country, involving 503,600 enumerators collecting data from the 25,321,000 inhabitants of Wuxi County in Jiangsu province.[15] The main census officially began on July 1st, 1982, after recruiting 5.18 million enumerators and 1.09 million supervisors, who underwent training through a program of about one week. At the

[13] Li Chengrui, *A Study of China's Population*, pp.12-72.
[14] Ivi, p.13.
[15] *Ivi*, p.16.

end of the program, each participant had to pass an exam to be certified and participate in the endeavor. With such a massive mobilization, each enumerator was tasked with working on a small group of people from their own village or neighborhood, as each enumerator was expected to cover an average of about 200 individuals. This allowed for visits to each person's home, if necessary, rather than waiting for people to come to nearby offices regardless of their circumstances. Nonetheless, the census was accompanied by a massive publicity campaign targeting the population.[16] The process involved the participation of United Nations experts, whom the People's Republic of China had gradually welcomed since 1971. However, with Deng's new course of Reform and Opening Up, they had even more influence in advising and supervising state-building processes in China.[17] At the end of the entire process, the State Statistical Bureau could boast excellent results in terms of the census' margin of error. The overall population count was subject to a margin of error ranging from 0.071% more to 0.056% fewer people, with a gender ratio error rate of 0.003% and an age determination error rate of 0.615%. In 1987, a sample survey allowed for data updating with a reasonable level of precision, as it covered 1% of the entire population. The 1990 census followed the same procedures and met the same standards as those of 1982, with the addition of some requested information (particularly regarding internal migrations) and the introduction of even stricter counting and control criteria. This included the implementation of a door-to-door visit method for everyone and the temporary suspension of penalties for non-compliance with birth reduction policies to encourage full cooperation from families.[18] The data from these censuses have served as the basis for all projections in the major demographic studies produced both in China and in the West on this crucial historical phase. This ensures that reasonably indisputable numbers are available.

Once it is established that the data at our disposal are the most established and shared by the scientific community, the work of source critique is not yet finished. The apparent neutrality of data such as fertility per capita, illiteracy rate, various gender

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16 *Ivi*, p.18.

17 Chen Dingding, "China's Participation in the International Human Rights Regime", *Chinese Journal of International Politics*, Oxford (United Kingdom), Oxford University Press, Vol. 2, 2009, 401–402.

18 Li Chengrui, *A Study of China's Population*, p.75.

gaps and others, actually hides challenges that go beyond a first level of critique focused on the simple reliability of the data itself. Lawrence Stone continues:

> It would be less than helpful to repeat the hackneyed reactionary cliché of the baffled humanist that 'one can prove anything with figures,' since it is very much easier to prove anything with words, which are always put together for rhetorical effect as a means of subjective persuasion as much as for logical argument. But it must be admitted that there is also a rhetoric of figures, and especially a rhetoric of graphs. The whole aspect of a graph can be radically altered by changing the vertical or the horizontal scales; by using semi-logarithmic rather than arithmetical graph paper; by the judicious selection of a base index number designed to highlight or downplay a trend; by using moving averages rather than raw figures.[19]

To illustrate this "rhetoric of graphs," let's observe a first one depicting the fertility rate (i.e., the number of children per woman) of the People's Republic of China from 1979, the year of the introduction of the OCP, until the late 1990s, a period during which this rate stabilized at levels consistent with most countries in comparable conditions. During this time, the OCP began to be reformed towards its future abolition, which officially occurred only starting from 2013. The data are derived from the most reliable sources discussed earlier:

[19] Stone, *The Past and The Present Revisited*, p.35.

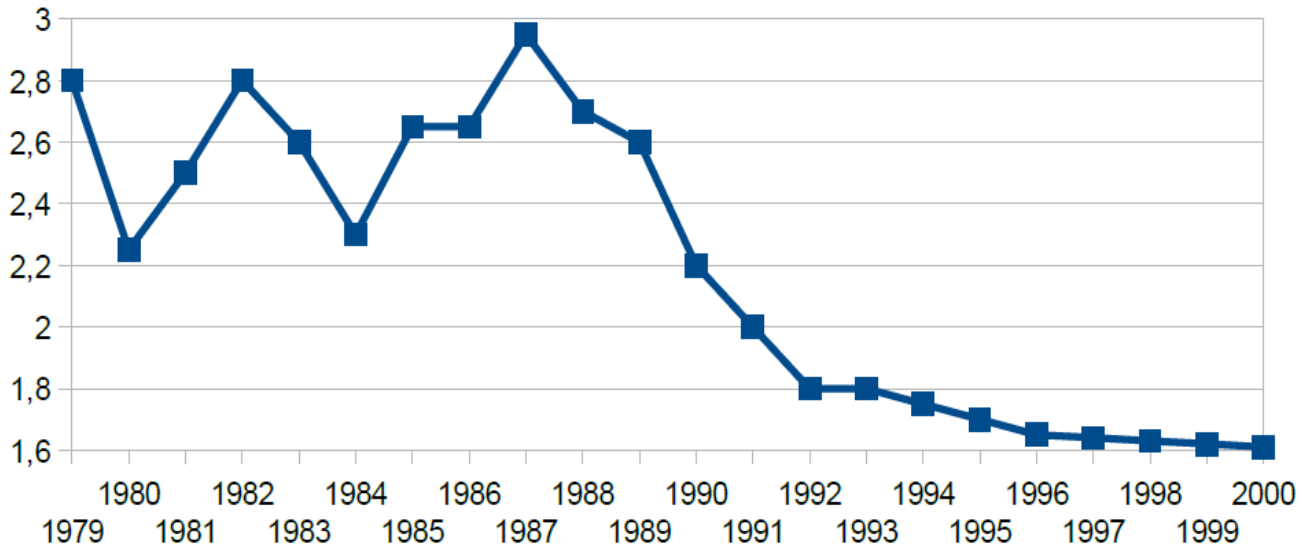

Fig.0.1 – Fertility Rate in China, 1979-2000; Demographic data derived from Banister, *China's changing population*, and from Daniel Goodkind, "The Astonishing Population Averted by China's Birth Restrictions: Estimates, Nightmares, and Reprogrammed Ambitions", *Demography,* Aug.2017; Vol. 54 No.4, Durham (USA), Duke University Press, 2017, p.1379

Based on such a graph, various narratives can be constructed to depict what the OCP meant. For example, the irregular trend of the fertility rate throughout the 1980s could portray a society in strong conflict with its own government, which attempts – and often succeeds – significant "sorties" against imposed rules. Alternatively, one could speak of a "trial and error" approach by the Chinese government to implement the measure, which only fully came into effect in the early 1990s. Furthermore, based on various documents of the time, the OCP could be interpreted as a generally inconsistent policy, serving as a basis for legitimizing more localized, short, but particularly harsh birth restriction campaigns.[20] All these hypotheses have a common apparent basis: the OCP, with all its dysfunctions, seems to have significantly contributed to the reduction of the fertility rate in China. However, simply expanding the chronological analysis boundary of the same data slightly reveals a much more complex picture:

[20] A complete analysis based on this hypothesis can be found in Greenhalg, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*; Greenhalg, *Just One Child* (cit.).

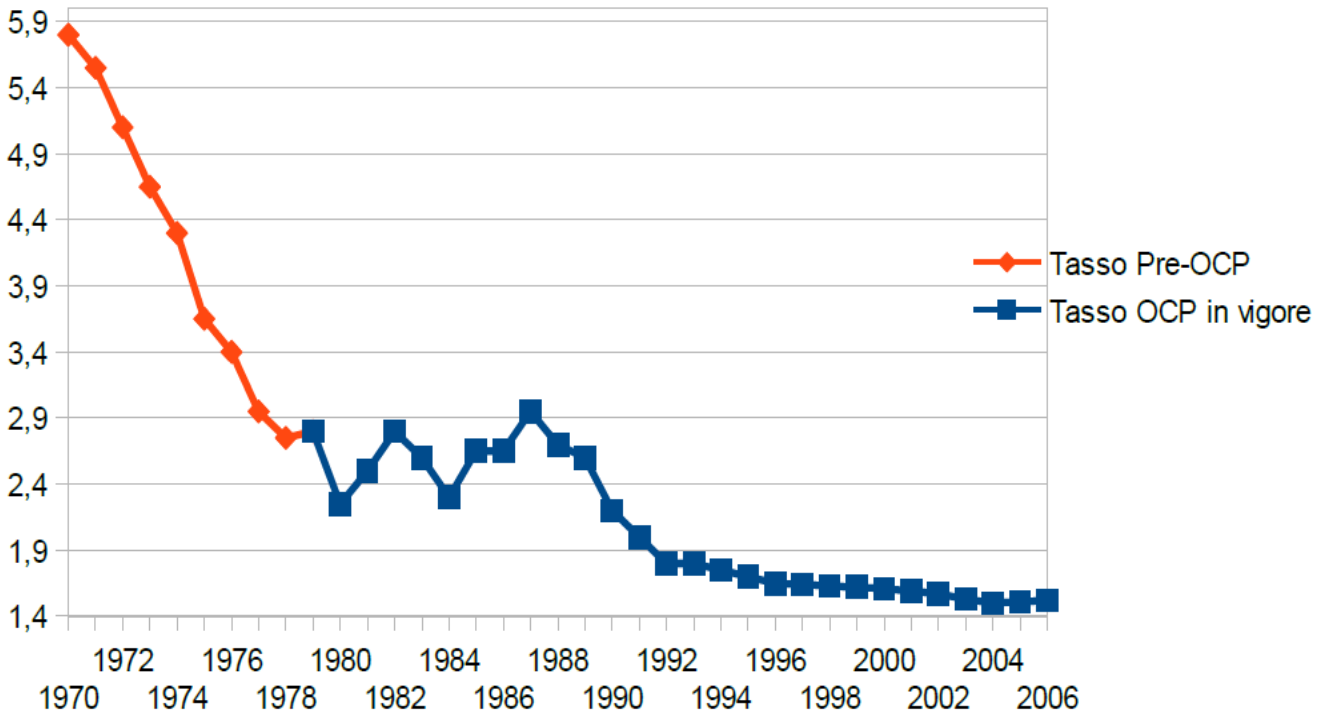

Fig.0.2 – Fertility Rate in China, 1970-2006; Demographic data derived from Banister 1987 and Goodkind 2017

From this second graph, one could draw very different conclusions about the demographic policies of the PRC compared to those suggested by the first. The OCP could be presented as a policy that is, in fact, ineffective on a large scale, or even paint a picture of such a strong reaction from the population to the OCP that it suspends a trend that would otherwise have led to even fewer children, thus depicting the OCP as not only ineffective but counterproductive. The very choice of the scale used (from 1.6 to 3 in the first graph, from 1.4 to 6 in the second) demonstrates how it can be bent towards a biased, non-neutral depiction. This serves as a clear example of how important it is for historians to remember that "there is also a rhetoric of numbers, and above all a rhetoric of graphs":

> One of the major problems of quantification in history is that while the average historian has been trained to scrutinize words with the greatest care and suspicion, he tends to take a graph or table on trust and not to know how to evaluate its reliability or to examine how it has been arrived at. He is not trained to be a professional critic of numerical data.[21]

[21] Stone, *The Past and The Present Revisited*, pp.35-36; Cfr. Vitali, *Passato digitale,* pp.23-24.

Even introducing the comparative element does not resolve the problems related to the malleability of demographic data as a source for historians. On the one hand, it certainly allows for better contextualization by adding a synchronic layer to the analysis; on the other hand, it raises numerous new questions: with which other historical realities can a phenomenon like the OCP really be compared? Which common criteria will be prioritized, and which will be more or less deliberately ignored? By cross-referencing various studies and data, it can be demonstrated how it is possible to reinforce very different narratives by comparing Chinese demographic policies – and their results – with those of countries similar in sheer size (India), culture (Taiwan, Japan, Korea), or with similar cases of particularly radical anti-natalist policies (Puerto Rico).[22]

The debate among demographers about how much the OCP actually impacted the fertility rate in China remains open, with positions still very distant and irreconcilable today. Regardless of past and present debates on the issue, a historian who wants to examine it through the methodologies and approaches specific to their discipline should take care to avoid an easy and superficial use of data and graphs that nevertheless reflect established realities.[23] Just like a text, a demographic datum and its representation also constitute a document for the analysis of which full "awareness is necessary that [it] is not a naive testimony of the past, but is 'primarily a disguise, a deceptive appearance, a montage'"[24].

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[22] About this theme, see Laura Briggs, *Reproducing Empire : Race, Sex, Science, and U.S. Imperialism in Puerto Rico*, Berkeley (USA), University of California Press, 2002, and Benedetta Calandra, *Il corpo del Caribe. Le politiche sulla riproduzione tra Puerto Rico e Stati Uniti (1898-1993)*, Verona (Italy), Ombre Corte, 2020.

[23] It must be emphasized, however, that a historiography of Chinese demographic policies should be cautious of relying exclusively on individual testimonies, ignoring or even just underestimating the large numbers and statistics: given the enormity and internal diversity of the individual experiences lived by a population of over a billion people, a history centered on testimonies can too easily become an ideological tool, usable by positions that are blindly opposed as well as those that are uncritically apologetic towards the contemporary Chinese political system.

[24] Jacques Le Goff mentioned in Vitali, *Passato digitale*, p.145.

1.2- The Chinese demographic disaster and the anti-Western response

It would be wrong to think that the expression 百年国耻 ("bainian guochi," or "century of humiliation") used by Chinese historiography to describe the period from 1839 to 1949 evokes only a sense of denied sovereignty and military defeat, as a narrative used to legitimize Chinese assertiveness in foreign policy in the eyes of public opinion. The term evokes the image of a particular historical trajectory, an unnatural "curve" experienced by a country that, starting from the Opium Wars, was violently deprived of the opportunity to modernize, remaining subjugated not only politically but also technically and morally. We will return to the rhetorical and ideological issues associated with the expression "century of humiliation" later: here, we want to first focus on the demographic phenomena associated with this period.

Kenneth Pomeranz compared the results of some studies on average life expectancy in various regions and countries, finding that "life expectancy at birth in England (probably the most prosperous part of Europe) was about thirty-two years in 1650 [...] and exceeded forty only after 1750."[25] In late 18th-century France (1770-1790), the figure is significantly lower, ranging between 27.5 and 30 years for the average lifespan of both sexes. In various parts of Germany, similar numbers are found throughout the first half of the 19th century. Pomeranz then moves on to the analysis of Chinese data:

> Chinese longevity is less impressive but still quite comparable to European longevity. Telford's study of genealogies from a relatively prosperous area suggests a mid eighteenth- century life expectancy of 39.6 at birth, though with a decline to 34.9 (still comparable to estimates for England) by the early nineteenth century. Lee and Campbell, working with unusually good data for a village in rural Manchuria in the years 1792–1867, arrive at an expectancy of 35.7 for one-year-old males and 29 for one-year-old females. These figures are a bit lower than Telford's numbers for the mid-eighteenth century, though for females they may be depressed by what seems to have been an unusually strong preference for sons in this population. At any rate, they are still comparable to those for prosperous parts of rural Europe. […]

[25] Kenneth Pomeranz, *The Great Divergence. China, Europe, and the Making of the Modern World*, Princeton (USA), Princeton University Press, 2000, p.36.

> That Chinese life expectancies were comparable to European ones can also be inferred from other demographic data. As we shall soon see, China's birthrates appear to have been lower than European ones, while its population growth rate was first higher (1550–1750) and then comparable (both China and Europe roughly doubled 1750–1850): this is only possible if Chinese death rates were also lower than European ones. (Europe had more emigration, but not enough to make an important difference until the end of this period.) Granted, further research may suggest higher birth- and death rates for China than those found so far (especially if we find good data for poorer parts of the country), but our European data are also drawn disproportionately from relatively prosperous areas.[26]

Even from an ecological standpoint, Pomeranz highlights how the conditions in China at the beginning of the 19th century are not particularly more concerning than those in Europe:

> Indeed, given China's high population densities, it is tempting to assume that [during late modern age] Chinese ecological problems were considerably worse than those in Europe; but that is not actually clear. Though China may have had less chance than Europe to expand construction and fuel-intensive industries, it probably did not face a much greater threat to its ability to reproduce its existing standard of living than a hypothetical Europe without the Americas would have faced; indeed, it may have been slightly better-off.[27]
>
> [...]
>
> An ecological bottleneck was at hand, which in retrospect (though only in retrospect) appears as a severe constraint on further population growth, per capita income growth, or movement out of agriculture. On the other hand, these figures do not suggest an imminent Malthusian crisis, even as late as 1853. Lingnan's situation seems more benign than that faced much earlier by France[28]

However, the trajectories of Europe and China undergo a radical divergence during

[26] Pomeranz, *The Great Divergence*, pp.36-38.
[27] Pomeranz, *The Great Divergence*, p.226.
[28] *Ivi*, p.234.

the 19th century. While Europe industrializes and gradually manages to overcome its "Malthusian brakes," China enters a phase of profound crisis, culminating in the latter part of the 19th century in devastating famines and epidemics. Comparing previous research by A.J. Broomhall, Paul Bohr, and Paul Cohen, Mike Davis estimates that the toll of these humanitarian disasters in China between 1876 and 1900 is to be evaluated at between 19.5 and 30 million deaths:

> [By 1877], three years of drought and famine in northern China - officially the "most terrible disaster in twenty-one dynasties of Chinese history" - had [...] killed somewhere between 8 million and 20 million people. […] In 1896-1902, the monsoons again repeatedly failed across the tropics and in northern China. Hugely destructive epidemics of malaria, bubonic plague, dysentery, smallpox and cholera culled millions of victims from the ranks of the famine weakened.[29]

We can better understand the extent of the disaster through direct testimonies, such as that of Reverend Timothy Richard of the Baptist Missionary Society, appointed by the wealthy community of Western expatriates in Shanghai to coordinate a humanitarian aid program during the famine of 1876-1879, who speaks of peasants literally forced by hunger to eat their own houses and to sell their children:

> In the summer ihe great cry of the mass of the people was for rain, rain. Now it is for very life. Having finished their corn, they eat grain-husks, potato stalks, and elm bark, buckwheat stalks, turnip leaves and grass seeds, which they gather in the fields and sieve the dust off. When these are exhausted, they pull down their houses, sell their timber, and it is reported everywhere that many eat the rotten kaoliang reeds (sorghum stalks from the roof), and the dried leaves of which thev usually burn for fuel ... [then] they sell their clothes and children.[30]

A disaster that, according to Davis, is a direct consequence of China's forced opening

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[29] Mike Davis, *Late Victorian Holocausts. El Nino Famines and the Making of the Third World*, London (United Kingdom) - New York (USA), Verso, 2001, p.5-6.

[30] Cit. in Paul Bohr, *Famine in China and the Missionary: Timothy Richard As Relief Administrator and Advocate of National Reform, 1876–1884,* Cambridge (USA), East Asian Research Center of Harvard University, 1972, p. 14.

following the Opium Wars, as the subordination of the Empire to Western policies causes the explosion of the trade deficit and the collapse of that complex system of irrigation and grain storage that until then had ensured the Chinese population access to sufficient food resources.[31] Droughts and floods also enter into a vicious cycle with violence: Chinese frustration over military and political oppression suffered since 1839 had already erupted in various forms throughout the rest of the century, but failed against the superior organization and technology of foreign forces. During the last months of the late-century famine, the so-called "Boxers" directly link natural disasters to occupation, often posting posters containing songs and rhyming slogans with messages like this:

> They proselytize their sect,
>
> And believe in only one God,
>
> The spirits and their own ancestors
>
> Are not even given a nod.
>
> Their men are all immoral;
>
> Their women truly vile.
>
> For the Devils it's mother-son sex
>
> That serves as the breeding style.
>
> And if you don't believe me,
>
> Then have a careful view:
>
> You'll see the Devils' eyes
>
> Are all a shining blue.

[31] Davis illustrates: "In the tumult of the nineteenth century, irrigation subsidies were more or less abandoned. The predictable consequences were a sharp decline in agricultural productivity and a concomitant increase in vulnerability to drought and flood. Murray points to Ching-yang, traditionally the richest county in the entire Wei Valley, where 'agriculture was crippled' by the late nineteenth century as a result of the deterioration of the irrigation system. 'A similarly depressing scene was revealed in the 1882 history of Hua-chou, located in the southeastern sector of the valley, where neglect of water control was also blamed for the decline of local agriculture. Not only had the irrigation ditches often become useless, but the natural waterways had silted up, and flooding along the riverbanks had destroyed much of the county's best farmland.' See Davis, *Late Victorian Holocausts*, pp.374-375.

> No rain comes from Heaven.
>
> The earth is parched and dry.
>
> And all because the churches
>
> Have bottled up the sky.[32]

So it is the "blue-eyed devils" who have "bottled up the sky" with the steeples of their churches, causing the drought that devastated the country. The anti-Christian and anti-colonial revolutionary attempt promoted from 1899 by the "Fists of Righteous Harmony" becomes, for the Alliance of Eight Nations (Austria-Hungary, France, Germany, Japan, Italy, United Kingdom, Russia, and the United States), the pretext for reaching the deepest stage in the process of colonial partition of the country, as they face a people physically weakened by 25 years of famine and epidemics:

> The European empires, together with Japan and the United States, rapaciously exploited the opportunity to wrest new colonies, expropriate communal lands, and tap novel sources of plantation and mine labor. What seemed from a metropolitan perspective the nineteenth century's final blaze of imperial glory was, from an Asian or African viewpoint, only the hideous light of a giant funeral pyre.[33]

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[32] Quote found in Joseph Esherick, *The Origins of the Boxer Uprising*, Berkeley (USA), University of California Press, 1987, p.299.

[33] Davis, *Late Victorian Holocausts,* op.cit., p.7.

Fig.1.1: Mother selling her children to buy bread*, Anonymous, copy from a woodcut, Qinkiang 1877*

By the year 1900, China is now devastated even on an ecological level, a disaster for which Pomeranz warns us against the "tendency to assume that this had been true for a long time," whereas it is essentially a new problem: despite its high population density, in 1800 the Chinese pressure on the country's natural and water resources "was not much worse than that in Europe (or in Japan)," and the most severe droughts contributing to the famines illustrated by Davis are part of a broader ecological crisis that appears to be "primarily a problem of the late nineteenth – and especially twentieth – century.".[34]

From the research of Pomeranz and Davis, we derive a history of contemporary China that – albeit cleansed of any distortions resulting from a mythical portrayal pre-1839 – remains characterized by a profoundly *traumatic* trajectory for the modernizing Chinese nation: an entire relatively advanced civilization collapsing, being subjected for over a century, albeit unwillingly, to the worst Malthusian checks such as famine and starvation. Vaclav Smil emphasizes this impact on Chinese

[34] Pomeranz, *The Great Divergence*, op.cit., p.237.

identity and "collective psyche" when he reports that

> John L. Buck's surveys done in the 1920s found that peasants recalled an average of three famines during their lifetime, that the hunger lasted on the average about ten months and forced a quarter of the affected population to eat bark and grasses.[35]

That same generation would then have experienced 'the famine that struck millions of Chinese in cities and countryside during the tumultuous years of the Japanese occupation and the civil war.'.[36] Davis observes that for some provinces - "decimated as if by a modern nuclear war" - it would take until the 1950s to return to the population numbers of 1875.[37] The direct link between the collapse of the imperial infrastructure, the Boxer Rebellion, and the subsequent generation's embrace of the revolutionary program is highlighted by Davis:

> Except in the Tianjin-Beijing region, which was now provisioned by sea, the ruin of the Grand Canal system grievously undermined food security in the north, especially in the event of drought-famines, which tended to be longer in duration and larger in area than Hood-famines. It also wrecked the economies of the famous canal towns and grain depots. From the jobless ranks of former boatmen and Canal laborers the Boxers recruited some of their most militant leaders and fighters; as did the Communist Party in the 1930s and 1940s from their descendants. NOTA

1.3- The rise of the Modernizers and the importation of Western social sciences

The visual and rhetorical emblem of the ruins of the Summer Palace destroyed by Anglo-French troops in 1860 mobilizes not only an anti-Western sentiment but also a sense of defeat and shame, not without strong elements of self-criticism.[38] The

[35] Vaclav Smil, "Who Will Feed China?", *The China Quarterly* , Vol.143 , September 1995, Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1995, p.801.

[36] *Ibidem;* Davis, *Late Victorian Holocausts*, p.372.

[37] Davis, *Late Victorian Holocausts,* op.cit., p.114.

[38] "To the story of a hundred years of humiliations corresponds a hundred years of revolutionary fervor. The revolutionaries called for reforms that would make China strong again and one day would force the Europeans to take them seriously. The revolutionaries, such as the young activists

"century of humiliation" is not just the sum of a series of tragedies but a single, complex "collective trauma" whose explanation – and therefore the prevention of its recurrence – lies within society and the nation. The complete failure of the Boxer Rebellion, traditionalist and anti-Western, strengthens the opposite message that several Chinese intellectuals promote in the subsequent years: by the end of the 1910s, many leading Chinese intellectuals are strongly characterized by a keen interest in social sciences produced in Europe and the United States. Among them, Liang Qichao, an important author and political activist, in the early 1900s publishes essays and poems about his travels in the USA, extolling its ability to learn from its mistakes, its "civilization," its "brilliance." Although not blind to its issues - "Having seen the slums of New York, I have to agree that a socialist revolution is indeed on its way!" - the North American country exerts an irresistible charm on Liang, and in its leaders and great entrepreneurs, the thinker finds what China lacks to solve its age-old problems: pragmatism, order, planning, and what Liang calls the "American Spirit," a deep sense of idealistic self-confidence, an optimism of the will that characterizes Americans and which, according to what can be termed a "Chinese Tocqueville" for various reasons, is the secret of their success.[39] Sun Yat-Sen himself, the first President of the Republic of China founded after the 1911 revolution, is a connoisseur and admirer of the United States:

> In his preparation for the republican revolution, Sun maintained close contact with the United States, especially Chinese-American communities in the U.S., which generously supported his revolutionary career. Compared to Liang's brief encounter with the United States, Sun's knowledge of America was more substantial. Additionally, as a revolutionary, Sun could better relate to the American experience, which he considered a natural example for the unfolding Chinese revolution. Once asked to define democracy, Sun responded: “The great U.S. President Lincoln put it the best: of the people, by the people, for the

associated with the May 4th Movement, wanted to “catch up” by “modernizing” everything from China’s political institutions and legal system to its social customs and the way people talked and dressed. In this way the Chinese came to continue, and accelerate, the process of creative destruction that the Europeans had initiated. As a result, China has since 1860 been a country at war with itself. All aspects of Chinese society have been scrutinized and most have been found wanting; in the eyes of the revolutionaries, China was never good enough and its people were always “reactionary” and “feudal.” Everything had to be destroyed and created anew." Erik Ringmar, *Liberal Barbarism. The European Destruction of the Palace of the Emperor of China*, New York (USA), Palgrave, 2013, p. 160.

[39] Li Jing, *China's America: the Chinese view the United States,* 1900-2000, Albany (USA), State University of New York Press, 2011, pp.11-19.

> people." After Lincoln, among other "American warriors for liberty and democracy," Sun admired George Washington the most, with whom he obviously identified personally. When trying to boost the morale of his revolutionary followers, Sun frequently referred to the humble beginnings of the American Revolution and the hardships that American Founding Fathers had to endure before their eventual triumph.[40]

An important means of spreading ideas and models from the West is the press. The most famous publication still associated with the imagery of social movements of this period is "新青年" (in pinyin "Xīn Qīngnián", literally "New Youth"), founded by the progressive and anti-Confucian philosopher Chen Duxiu. "Xīn Qīngnián" shows a double heading that includes the translation of its name into French, "La Jeunesse", and it is first published in 1915 with its first issue featuring the figure of the American industrialist Andrew Carnegie on the cover, one of the main supporters of eugenic studies for the quantitative and qualitative control of the population in the early 1900s. Crossed by a strong pro-Western, progressive, and anti-Confucian tension, around "La Jeunesse" gather Chinese political militants and intellectuals who promote not only an importation of political systems and technologies from the West but also a "new culture," a new way of thinking.[41] This "new culture" has a cornerstone at the center of its analysis: the importance of *science*, and particularly the science produced in the United States of America. The ideas promoted by "La Jeunesse" dictate the slogans of the May Fourth Movement, which shook Chinese society in 1919. Despite Chen Duxiu and Li Dazhao having already started their journey towards Marxism, in March 1920 "La Jeunesse" publishes a special issue dedicated to the demographic issue; in the first article, economist Gu Mengyu promotes the ideas of Thomas Malthus as "indisputable truths," and argues that "demography is the key to all social problems."[42]

Along the path of adopting modern Western standards in the study and policy-

[40] *Ivi*, p.20.

[41] Luo Zhitian, « Wholeness and individuality: Revisiting the New Culture Movement, as symbolized by May Fourth », *Chinese Studies in History*, vol. 52, 2 octobre 2019, Milton Park (United Kingdom), Routledge, 2019, p. 193-195.

[42] Wang Zhihe, Yang Ming, Zhang Jiaming, Chang Jiang, "Ending an Era of Population Control in China: Was the One-Child Policy Ever Needed?", *The American Journal of Economics and Sociology*, Vol. 75, No. 4 (September 2016), Hoboken (USA), Wiley, 2016, p.936.

making in demographic matters, a significant step is represented by the visits to China by Margaret Sanger, one of the most renowned figures of the twentieth-century birth control movement, founder in 1921 of the American Birth Control League, which gradually oriented itself towards making the decline in births an "end in itself," allying with "completely different social forces" from the feminist and socialist positions from which she started her intellectual and political trajectory. Particularly controversial are her positions on eugenics.[43]

Sanger visits China twice, in 1922 and 1936, at the invitation of two Chinese intellectuals belonging to the May Fourth Movement, Jiang Menglin and Chen Da, both educated in the USA and promoters of her ideas in China; Chen later will become an internationally renowned demographer.[44] During her first trip, Sanger is invited to give a lecture at Peking University, attended by an audience of 2,500 people; Hu Shi, another leader of the Movement, translates for Sanger.[45] Upon her return to the USA, Margaret Sanger herself, in a speech delivered at Carnegie Hall in New York, testifies about the event in Beijing:

> From Korea I went to Peking and there was able to address 2500 students in the Government University of Peking. I also spoke at the Rockefeller Institute as well as at a gathering of bankers, who gave a luncheon in my honor. I was particularly interested in the method of the Chinese in their grasp of the subject, and in their method of quick action when once they have a subject in hand. There were present a number of the professors and some others who were considered the "intelligentsia" of Peking. There were some splendid suggestions made that afternoon for carrying on the work, and the formation of a league was formed that night; but the immediate need was for practical methods, and they took the pamphlet "Family Limitation", translated it into Chinese, and the next morning that material was on the press, and five thousand pamphlets were printed and ready for distribution the next day. If anyone wishes to refute Malthusian theory, it is worth while before wasting his time, to take a trip to China, for there the population question with all the horrors that Malthus depicted, is vindicated.[46]

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43 Calandra, *Il corpo del Caribe*, pp.74-77.

44 Longkumer, "The Rockefellers, Margaret Sanger and the Eugenic Dimension of Birth Control", p.14.

45 Wang et al., “Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 936.

46 Margaret Sanger, "Birth Control in China and Japan.", Margaret Sanger Papers, Library of Congress, LCM 128:491, <https://www.nyu.edu/projects/sanger/webedition/app/documents/show.php?sangerDoc=

The reception given to Sanger in China contrasts with the opinions she expresses about the Chinese people. In the same speech, Sanger states:

> In China we witness the last act in the national tragedy of over-population. Here is a great Empire prostrate in the dust. China, the mysterious fountainhead of art, philosophy and the deepest wisdom of the world, has been brought down by the breeding and multiplication of the worst elements of the yellow race. It is difficult for anyone who has not visited China to realize the situation. Here are masses of humans who live below the level of animals. They eat, sleep, and breed in the crowded streets and sunless alleys. [...] I recall one unforgettable, unspeakable picture I saw in the native quarters of Shanghai – the prostrate body of a leper woman, covered with rags; her naked diseased children climbing over this inert figure, from a hole in the darkness above the rays of the sun beat down in a single shaft. Horrified by this spectacle we moved on, followed by a crowd of starving, naked children, some of them blind, all unspeakably diseased, crying in pitiful voices for coppers. Such are the results of obeying the age-old injunction to increase and multiply, carried to a literal conclusion. Such is the punishment of a herdlike obedience to blind instinct, of non-interference with the course of Nature.[47]

It is evident in Sanger the complete removal of the wars, unequal treaties, and the introduction of opium that the West had imposed on China during the "century of humiliation", which, as demonstrated by Pomeranz and Davis, were undoubtedly the main causes of the devastation that Sanger witnesses. For the American scholar, the reasons for the problems of China in the early 1920s are "the breeding and multiplication of the worst elements of the yellow race" and "a herdlike obedience to blind instinct." The conclusions that Sanger reaches at the end of her trip to China and Japan are remarkably harsh:

> After my eight months tour of the world, I am led to agree with H. G. Wells when he says that the whole world at present is swarming with cramped, dreary, meaningless lives, lives which amount to nothing and which use up the resources and surplus energies of the world.

101865.xml> , ultima consultazione 11/04/2023.

[47] *Ibidem.*

Two sentences of the manuscript are erased by an unknown author, but still readable:

> Our world is overcrowded with masses who are merely the breeding crowd of admitted misery and wretchedness. They do nothing to carry life forward. They are just the vain, defective imperfect repetitions of all that has gone before. [...]
>
> Our charity to these masses is in reality a crime against future generations, against the finest blossoming of the human spirit.[48]

Although Sanger probably did not express herself in these exact terms during her lecture in Beijing, her opinions are not a secret. It is natural to wonder how the intellectual elite of China at the time could accept and fervently promote her proposals. The explanation likely lies in the division that the May Fourth Movement had matured by the early 1920s, with the birth of the Communist Party in 1921, which attracted intellectuals closest to the popular, peasant, and anti-colonial cause, opposed to those who represented the pro-Western urbanized classes. The latter group reads a fundamental distinction in the references to the glory of imperial China present in Sanger's speech: for the advocate of birth control and eugenics, the problem is not *all* Chinese people, but rather the *poor and illiterate* Chinese. While expressing what by contemporary sensibilities can only be considered explicit racism, Sanger's speech at the same time suggests a glimmer of hope for the "yellow race," whose "worst elements" can be suppressed not by the direct action of Westerners – which Sanger harshly criticizes – but by the more "enlightened" part of China itself. This is a message that calls upon these local elites to take on the responsibility of conducting a "civilizing mission" that, while remaining entirely within a colonial, exceptionalist, and Western supremacist mechanism, entrusts to the indigenous ruling classes an indispensable role of active mediation, and with it the recognition of a moral superiority even over regressive "white" elements such as the Christian Churches. A circle of Chinese intellectuals, educated at Harvard, Yale, Columbia, and Cornell universities, gathers around Sanger, translating and disseminating her writings in Chinese.[49]

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[48] *Ibidem.*

[49] Longkumer, "The Rockefellers, Margaret Sanger and the Eugenic Dimension of Birth Control in Colonial India and Republican China", p.17; This radically pro-Western line of thought will still

Meanwhile, since 1921, Chen and Li fully embraced Marxism, founding the Communist Party of China and decisively moving away from Malthusian theories and the positions of the institutional Chinese academia, which remained firmly in the hands of pro-Western "modernizers."[50] Even within the Communist Party, however, traces of the previous tendency remain alive, which will resurface strongly after the death of Mao Zedong. It is following the long trauma shared by an entire civilization summarized in the preceding pages, and in light of the success of a specific "modern" orientation, pro-Western and scientistic – born in response to that trauma – that we must interpret the population control policies of the Reform and Opening-Up period. They will be the attempt to definitively solve one of the most painful sides of the "century of humiliation" through a "scientific" approach: it is not enough to tear down the bell towers to make it rain, instead, one must intervene rationally in society to reduce the imbalances between population and resources, containing its explosive potential. Therefore, Chinese demographic policies from 1979 to the present cannot be interpreted as a mere reaction to the hardships of the Maoist period; instead, they must be placed in a broader historical context, one that includes this previous, extremely traumatic historical phase for the Chinese people: inspiring the birth control policies applied by the post-Maoist leadership are the specters of the tragedies experienced for an entire century, and the Malthusian response that had been imported long before the food crisis linked to the failure of the Great Leap Forward.

Apart from the inspirational role of Margaret Sanger, the first initiatives in the field

find illustrious representatives throughout the rest of the twentieth century. Nobel Peace Prize winner Liu Xiaobo, for example, is famous for arguing in 1988 that to achieve true progress, China "needs another three hundred years of colonialism. The hundred-year-old colony of Hong Kong has become what it is today, and China is so big, of course, it will take 300 years of colonialism to become what Hong Kong is today. Is three hundred years enough? I still have doubts." This statement is often decontextualized to present the Chinese dissident as a simple "hater of China"; however, in other parts of the interview, Liu spoke of his great respect for traditional Chinese literature; at the same time, despite the criticism he received for his statement about colonialism, he never retracted it. More than just an "enemy" of the Chinese nationalist cause, Liu represents precisely that intellectual wing that aspires to the modernization and full development of China, considering, however, that the main obstacle to this "Chinese renaissance" lies in the internal forces in the country that rely on the popular consent of the lower classes, while the liberal West is seen as a model and potential "majority shareholder" in the project. In the disorganized "agenda" of this movement, the numerical reduction of the part of the population they consider most regressive will always be a constant. See “Liu Xiaobo, 'Dark Horse' of Literature”, Open Magazine, Hong Kong, Dicembre 1988, <http://www.open.com.hk/old_version/1011p68.html>, last consultation 11/04/2023.

[50] *Ivi*, p.939.

of active birth control in China using modern methods are primarily led by men, reformers, and members of a small intellectual minority, who are far removed from the ideal target of their initiatives: the millions of Chinese women living outside of that circle.[51] Analyzing briefly China before 1949 from the perspective of these women allows us to understand the reasons for the substantial failure experienced by Chinese reformers in this field before the advent of Maoism.

1.4- The trajectory of women's struggles during the "century of humiliation"

Expanding the historical context to include the "century of humiliation" in our analysis is perhaps even more important for understanding contemporary China from a gender perspective. In fact, while for the nation of China the "humiliation" lasted little more than a hundred years, for Chinese women, 1949 would represent partial emancipation from traditions and oppressive customs that had lasted for *millennia*.

The power dynamics between genders in China have been and still remain heavily skewed in favor of males; they are the result of centuries of dominance rooted in the patrilineal and patriarchal nature of the family in Chinese tradition.[52] Until 1949, still four out of five Chinese women are completely illiterate, and this is one of the reasons why none of the feminist battles that emerged in the West had substantially shaken the framework of total subordination of women to men before to the Empire and the State. Gail Hershatter reports on the efforts made in the field of female education since the late 19th century by some reformers such as Xue Shaohui, who in major urban centers - especially Shanghai - led to the creation of schools for girls where they could receive education in basic subjects such as History, Geography, and Sciences; however, they were prohibited from learning foreign languages, Confucian classics, and economic subjects, while they were required to learn "female tasks" such as sericulture, sewing, and other manual works traditionally associated with women.[53] The most significant problem, however, remained the inability of the

[51] Longkumer, "The Rockefellers, Margaret Sanger and the Eugenic Dimension of Birth Control", p.12.
[52] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.219.
[53] Gail Hershatter, Women and China's Revolutions, Rowman & Littlefield, London (United

imperial and then the republican government to provide basic education to women outside of major cities; Hershatter explains that

> The number of girls attending school at all levels continued to increase in the 1910s and 1920s, from 141,130 in non-mission schools in 1912–13 to 417,820 in 1922–23. But girls remained a small minority of students nationally, in the range of 5 to 7 percent. The number of women university students nationally was small: 847 in 1923 and 1,495 in 1928, or 8.5 percent of the total university student population. Nonstudents far outnumbered students at every level. In the North China province of Zhili, for instance, one-third of all boys attended school in 1916, but only 1.24 percent of girls.[54]

Margery Wolf attests to the failure of the Chinese feminist movement in its early stages when it develops parallel to the modernizing demands of the May Fourth Movement, a failure primarily due to the cultural abyss that separates urban elites from peasant masses:

> The demands being made by students and urban intellectuals of the May 4th era were realistic for students and urban intellectuals, but they were hopelessly irrelevant to the lives of rural or working class women.
>
> [...]
>
> City women pushed for birth control and the vote. Farm women probably had no notion of what the vote was, for their menfolk had little acquaintance with it. Contraception would have been a blessing to some, but they were shocked to hear it spoken of in public, and for many it was beside the point even bearing a child every two years could not guarantee that enough would live to support one in old age. Many farm women and even many urban working class women felt threatened by what they did hear about the reforms demanded by elite women. Eager but naïve women students demonstrated their own liberation by confronting older women on the streets and forcibly bobbing their hair and unbinding their feet.
>
> [...]

Kingdom), 2019, pp.73-77.

[54] *Ivi,* p.106.

> Men students demanded that they be allowed to divorce their old-style wives in order to make "love marriages," further threatening the only security rural women knew or could hope for. However obvious the need for these reforms seemed to urban elites, they had little support among the women in the towns and villages.[55]

Even the greatest success of the women's emancipation struggles in China before 1949, namely the abolition of foot binding in some regions, is often perceived in rural areas as a violent imposition:

> in the 1910s and 1920s, warlord soldiers and local officials would maraud through their villages, fining families who had bound their daughters' feet and sometimes hoisting the bindings on the tips of their bayonets. The women remembered such moments as invasive and frightening, not liberating.[56]

The rise to power of Chiang Kai-shek in the 1920s and his rupture of the United Front marks the end of the feminist movement in the republican period, with the persecution and killing of thousands of activists:

> Before [Nationalist woman leader] He Xiangning left Wuhan and went into retreat on Lushan Mountain, the killing of women activists began in the city. Protected by her deceased husband's stature among Nationalists, she watched from afar in horror while the Communist members of her women's department staff were hunted down and executed. Though the female casualties were considerably fewer than the male casualties, intense political symbolism was associated with the women's deaths. Women's bodies were subject to mutilation as a statement against female activism, which had come to be viewed as a disturbing indicator of a world turned upside down. When the Nationalist Commander Xia Douyin, for instance, ordered his troops to put down the peasant associations in Hubei, they reportedly "cut open the breasts of the women comrades, pierced their bodies perpendicularly with iron wires, and paraded them naked through the streets."
>
> Cai Chang estimated in her discussions with Helen Snow that the Nationalist troops killed more than one thousand Communist women organizers and

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[55] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.13.

[56] Hershatter, *Women and China's Revolutions*, p.68; Hershatter highlights how foot binding continued to be practiced in regions like Yunnan until the 1950s.

> leaders during the first year of the White Terror. No one has ever attempted to count the total number of women participants who lost their lives in the backlash that occurred throughout much of China, though the random accounts of specific incidents indicate that the number was not insignificant. In Hubei, for instance, five hundred women reportedly were slain in the spring of 1927. Some suspected women radicals were shot down in the streets such as occurred in the well-known massacre in Horse Square in Changsha. Others were arrested and summarily executed. Understandably, the vast majority of women activists, including Liu Qingyang and Xu Chengmei, dropped out of politics at this time. Inactivity normally brought immunity from arrest and prosecution.[57]

The Nationalist Party inaugurates a "New Women's Movement," whose profoundly regressive philosophy is summarized by its proponents as follows:

> For the modern Chinese woman, let her freedom be restrained by self-control, her self-realization be coupled with self-sacrifice, and her individualism be circumscribed by family duty. Such is our new ideal of womanhood and to realize this is our supreme problem.[58]

The struggle for women's liberation remains alive within the Communist Party, which adopts an "orthodox Marxist" approach to this issue: women's liberation will occur through their full participation in production. However, the more concrete and immediate demands of communist women are sacrificed on the altar of political realism, and more specifically to avoid hindering the Party's grassroots support, upon which its strategy is based: for example, according to Margery Wolf, the radical feminist Ding Ling, after delivering a fiery speech during Women's Day in 1942, is forced to withdraw from political and literary activities for two years "so as not to compromise the loyalty of male peasants".[59] It is no coincidence that, as we will now see, it will be during periods when ideology prevails over realpolitik that the issue of women's liberation will regain strength.

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[57] Christina Kelley Gilmartin, *Engendering the Chinese Revolution. Radical Women, Communist Politics and Mass Movements in the 1920s*, Berkeley (USA), University of California Press, 1995, pp.198-199.

[58] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.15.

[59] *Ibidem.*

CHAPTER 2

SERVE THE PEOPLE. POLITICAL REVOLUTION AND DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION, 1949-1976

With the defeat of the nationalists and the founding of the People's Republic in 1949, China entered a phase where demography as a discipline was officially sidelined. Birth reduction programs that had taken their first steps in the 1920s, interrupted during the years of Japanese occupation and civil war, were not reactivated. Nevertheless, it was precisely during the Maoist period that China experienced the most significant and irreversible decline in its fertility rate, especially during the 1970s. In this chapter, we will attempt to uncover the possible reasons for this radical demographic transition by following two parallel paths: on one hand, the evolution of the Great Helmsman's thinking and that of his closest collaborators on the issue of population control, which, as we will see, is far more complex than the uncompromising natalism often associated with the Chinese leader. On the other hand, it will also be important to follow the developments in the condition of women in China, as they undergo profound transformations that, although rarely directly related to the reproductive realm, will have significant effects on it.

2.1- From the PRC's foundation to the failure of the Great Leap Forward

The New Culture Movement, launched by Chen Duxiu in 1915 with the journal *La Jeunesse* as its primary medium of dissemination, evolved into the more militant May Fourth Movement with the demonstrations of 1919. Mao Zedong came into contact with the ideas of the New Culture Movement through some of his teachers at the First Normal School of Changsha, and in his earliest years of activism, he appears to have embraced these ideas. Mao himself recalled his system of thought at the time of his move to Beijing to continue his studies:

> At that time, my thinking was a curious mixture of liberalism, democratic reformism, and utopian socialism. I had a rather vague passion for 19th-century democracy, for the idealism of the utopians, and for classical liberalism, and I was sincerely anti-militarist and anti-imperialist.[60]

Upon arriving in Beijing, Mao was employed as an assistant librarian under the guidance of Li Dazhao. However, Li had already begun his intellectual journey toward Marxism, while Mao briefly gravitated toward the ideas of Pyotr Kropotkin and Mikhail Bakunin before abandoning utopianism and firmly embracing Karl Marx's perspective. What is important to highlight here is that while the "first generation" of Chinese communists, such as Chen Duxiu and Li Dazhao, fully went through a formative phase characterized by a kind of progressive, pro-Western positivism, Mao only brushed against these intellectual tendencies without ever deeply exploring or fully adopting them. His education was marked by a more contentious relationship between China and the West and between their respective cultures, having received a much more traditional education in Changsha than his mentor Li Dazhao, who had the opportunity to study in Japan.

In 1949, Mao delivered a speech in which he outlined what he believed were the reasons for the communists' victory in China, responding to the theories put forward that same year by U.S. Secretary of State Dean Acheson. Against Acheson's idea that one of the main reasons for the revolution was a structural poverty caused by the size

[60] Cit. in Claude Hudelot, *Mao : la vie, la légende*, Paris (France), Larousse, 2001, p.19.

of the Chinese population, Mao argued that

> It is a very good thing that China has a big population. Even if China's population multiplies many times, she is fully capable of finding a solution; the solution is production. The absurd argument of Western bourgeois economists like Malthus that increases in food cannot keep pace with increases in population was not only thoroughly refuted in theory by Marxists long ago, but has also been completely exploded by the realities in the Soviet Union and the Liberated Areas of China after their revolutions.[61]

Mao also rejected the idea that it was "the influence of new ideas coming from the West" that had played a decisive role in sparking the Revolution.[62] The Great Helmsman presents himself as a figure transcending the categories that had previously characterized the political and ideological struggle in China. On one hand, he is a promoter of Marxism-Leninism, a modern idea born of Western revolutions and originating from the West—albeit not from the *geopolitical* West, given the Soviet mediation. On the other hand, Mao emerges as one of the greatest adversaries of the liberal progressivism that had deeply influenced the formation of his mentors. In this regard, he adopts a rhetoric and measures towards Western social sciences that are much closer to the iconoclastic perspective of the Righteous and Harmonious Fists—the "Boxers"—than to the pro-Western stance of *La Jeunesse*.

Since the 1930s, the first Chinese sociologists trained in Malthusian theory had begun to warn of the dangers of overpopulation. However, pre-1949 family planning programs were extremely limited and did not address the root of the problem. They focused on the higher echelons of the population and failed to dismantle cultural prejudices that confined women exclusively to the roles of mothers and reproductive labor. In 1952, sociology programs were abolished in all Chinese higher education institutions as they were considered a "bourgeois pseudoscience"[63], and birth control programs are categorized by the official Party organ as a "potential ruin" for China and a "bloodless murder.".[64] It would, however, be incorrect to claim that the social sciences, and more specifically demography in China, were "demolished" since, in

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[61] Mao Zedong, *Selected Works*, Beijing (RPC), Foreign Languages Press, 1961, Vol. IV, p.453.
[62] *Ivi,* p.454.
[63] Bian Yanjie, Zhang Lei,"Sociology in China", *Contexts Magazine*, Washington D.C.(USA), American Sociological Association, Vol. 7, No. 3, Summer 2008, p. 20.
[64] *Renmin Ribao*, 25 Aprile 1952.

fact, they had never been fully constructed. The Maoist period is characterized rather by a slowdown and the semi-clandestine continuation of the development of these sciences. By the time of Mao Zedong's death in 1976, Chinese demography—understood both as a science and as a policy—was undoubtedly more advanced than it had been in 1949. The myth of the destruction and suspension of the development of social sciences in China stems from the erroneous idea that imperial and then republican China had already sufficiently developed these disciplines, and from taking Mao's denunciations of "bourgeois pseudoscience" too literally, without considering the military and political pressure that the PRC was under during his rule.[65] The officially pro-natalist stance of Mao's government did not lead to a population explosion. The exponential population growth in the following years, as we will see, was almost entirely due to the dramatic increase in average life expectancy.[66]

In any case, the direct measures and targeted birth reduction campaigns promoted by Sanger and the Chinese intellectuals aligned with her were completely discarded by the Maoist leadership. With the communists in power, women experienced significant changes in other areas, which, as we will see, still had a substantial effect on fertility rates. Once in power, Mao Zedong introduced a series of measures that radically challenged traditional Confucian culture, marking a significant change in the status of women in China, starting with the Marriage Law of May 1950. This law granted women the right to seek a divorce, which had previously been recognized only for men, and prohibited entrenched practices such as polygamy, proxy marriage, and the sale of women and girls as brides.[67] Between 1950 and 1958, the first of two mass campaigns for women's literacy was carried out.[68] A stronger acceleration in the

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[65] Greenhalgh e Winckler scrivono: «The imperial and republican states were indeed concerned about human numbers, but it was not until the PRC that the state was able to create the institutions that allowed population to emerge as a major domain of governance». Cfr. Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.32.

[66] Cfr. p.59.

[67] Hershatter, *Women and China's Revolutions,* p.221. Y.C.Yu spiega che "The promulgation of the Marriage Law in 1950 was of particular importance to the movement for women's liberation in China. The basic principle of the law was 'to abolish the arbitrary and compulsory feudal marriage system which was based on the superiority of men and which ignored the children's interest.... The new democratic marriage system is based on free choice of partners, monogamy, equal rights for both sexes, and on the protection of the lawful interests of women and children'." Yu, Y.C., "The Population Policy of China", *Population Studies*,Vol. 33, No. 1 (Mar., 1979), London (United Kingdom), Taylor & Francis, 1979, p.137.

[68] Cfr. p.116.

process of women's emancipation in China occurs with the launch of the Great Leap Forward. The gender issue is certainly not at the center of the ambitious modernization and industrialization plan; however, the integration of women into various professional sectors is one of its strategic pillars. Additionally, the collectivization of many tasks traditionally performed by women in the domestic sphere contributes to a stronger awareness on reproductive labor. In the production communes established during this phase, tasks such as childcare, cooking, and laundry are no longer managed at the nuclear family level but by the commune itself. Although the liberation of women is promoted as an objective inseparable from the more important goal of economic and technological development, it nonetheless benefits for the first time from open and concrete support from the central government

> Great Leap policies were an attempt to assimilate a low status, traditionally oppressed social group into key areas of national life. Through a process of participation and struggle women were to contribute to China's rapid modernization and they were also to achieve equality, thus fulfilling the commitment of the Chinese Communists to the goals of woman's emancipation.[69]

During the Great Leap Forward, the education rate for women continued to rise, and their recognized participation in the workforce also grew rapidly. Between 1959 and 1963, the percentage of women among workers increased from 15.4% to 25%. The governor of Hunan Province, considered one of the most exemplary in implementing the Great Leap Forward, reported that by 1958, "six million women were emancipated from domestic work." In 1960, women in Hunan had access to 100,000 childcare centers and were entitled to 45 days of maternity leave, while 180,000 of them held managerial positions within Party and State structures.[70] Even though the majority of women were still employed in agriculture, Phyllis Andors cites the example of the Anshan Foundry, which had no female employees in 1949, but by

[69] Phyllis Andors, “Social revolution and woman's emancipation: China during the great leap forward", *Bulletin of Concerned Asian Scholars*, 7:1, London (United Kingdom), Routledge, 1975, p.34.

[70] *Ivi*, p.36.

1962 had 600 women employed as engineers, managers, technicians, and designers, all of whom had been trained after the founding of the People's Republic.[71] Moreover, "March 8th" teams composed entirely of women were engaged in dam construction and reforestation projects. However, the failure of the Great Leap Forward halted this trend. As Andors reports, the prejudices still rooted in traditional Chinese society meant that "of all the policies adopted during the Great Leap, the attempt to change the role and status of Chinese women probably faced the most widespread, constant, and intense opposition."[72] When drought strikes during those years and agricultural production suffers, many see it as confirmation of the popular superstition that "if women work in the fields, it won't rain." According to Andors, it is precisely this widespread reaction to the new role of women in society that plays a significant role in the failure of Mao's accelerationist program.[73]

As already mentioned, within the Communist Party, there are still semi-dormant trends prioritizing limiting population growth. According to Thomas Scharping, during the turbulent period of the "Hundred Flowers," advocates for population control managed to influence Mao's thinking. However, it is following the famine caused by the failure of the Great Leap Forward that the strongly natalist official position begins to relax, particularly under the influence of Zhou Enlai, the Premier of the PRC. In a speech in 1963, he suggests that:

> a large population is a good thing, but as we are the most populous country in the world, we already have plenty of this good thing, and if we still let the population grow rapidly in an unplanned manner, it won't be a good thing any more.[74]

In an interview given in 1965 to Edgar Snow, Zhou emphasizes progress but also the urgent need to strengthen agricultural production to meet the food and clothing supply needs of the Chinese people. This is significant because during those years,

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[71] *Ivi*, "Social revolution and woman's emancipation",p.39.
[72] *Ivi*, p.40
[73] Cfr. *Ivi,* p.37
[74] Cit.in Scharping, *Birth Control in China*. Diversi passaggi storici ricordati in questo capitolo sono sintetizzati a partire dal lavoro di Scharping, in particolare dal capitolo 4 dell'opera, "Motives and goals of Chinese birth control".

Zhou is also the strongest advocate of the idea that the issue of birth control should be the responsibility of bodies tasked with the economy and reducing malnutrition, rather than those responsible for public health. That said, when Snow proposed resuming scientific exchanges with the West, Zhou Enlai brushed it off, calling them "secondary issues."[75]

Fig.2.1 - Zhou Enlai, frame from the interview given to Edgar Snow. *National Archives, "Interview with Zhou En Lai", National Security Council, 1965*

In this, Zhou demonstrates to be an "intermediate" figure, aware of the need to promote birth control without, however, opening China to direct contributions from Western demographic sciences. According to the Washington Post, in the same interview (which lasted about 5 hours in total), Zhou Enlai explicitly states a goal of reducing the population growth rate to less than 1% by the year 2000.[76] This is significant considering that in 1965 the official position of the Chinese government is still far from officially recognizing the need for population control. However, to

[75] National Archives, "Interview with Zhou En Lai", National Security Council, 1965 <https://archive.org/details/gov.archives.arc.655146>, ultima consultazione 08/03/2023.

[76] Cit. In Chen Pi-Chao, "China's Birth Control Action Programme, 1956-1964", *Population Studies*, Vol. 24, No. 2 (Jul., 1970), London (United Kingdom), Taylor & Francis, 1970, p.141.

counterbalance Mao's "natalism," there is not only the more moderate position of other important leaders like Zhou: starting from the second half of the 1960s, it is mainly the successes achieved by the women's struggle for the improvement of their social, economic, and cultural status that begins to have an irreversible impact on fertility in China.

2.2- The Chinese demographic transition during the 1970s

After the relatively short period of retreat following the end of the Great Leap Forward, Maoist China experienced a phase of renewed emphasis on the liberation of women during the Cultural Revolution. Here too, purely feminist demands were officially accused of "bourgeois thought" and entirely subordinated to class struggle, according to the principle that women's liberation can only occur through the full collectivization of the means of production and labor. However, unlike the Great Leap Forward, this liberation is no longer presented as a means to achieve the goal of socialist economic development, but rather as an end in itself. The image promoted during this phase is that of a woman completely emancipated from the domestic, sexual, and reproductive roles to which she was relegated by traditional culture, with an emphasis on the fundamental importance for women of activism and full participation in the political and economic life of collectivist communities.[77] The slogans of the Cultural Revolution particularly resonated with younger girls, who experienced during this phase a degree of freedom from family and traditional constraints that they never enjoyed before:

> Looking back on those years from the vantage point of the post-Mao period, women also recall their sense of adventure, excitement, and sometimes trepidation as they took to the rails and the roads to see Chairman Mao or emulated the CCP's Long March in treks across China. These travels gave both young men and young women a sense of China's vastness and provided a degree of autonomy from adult supervision that they would not have encountered in a more normal time. For young women in particular, this period of political activism and travel meant freedom from family and school

[77] Kay Ann Jonhson, *Women, The Family and Peasant Revolution in China*, Chicago (USA), University of Chicago Press, 1983, p.181.

constraints that young women of previous generations seldom had experienced.[78]

Other initiatives undertaken during the period of the Great Cultural Revolution tangibly improved the status of women in rural areas, particularly through the widespread dissemination of basic education and healthcare services.[79] In 1970, Zhou managed to persuade Mao and the Politburo to reframe the issue of birth control as an integral part of overall economic policies and poverty reduction, assigning it to the relevant ministries. This, from a statistical standpoint, appears to be the single measure that had the most significant impact on contemporary Chinese demographic history, far more than the OCP: from that year onwards, China's fertility rate experienced a dramatic decline, dropping from 5.9 to 2.8 children per woman in less than a decade.[80] Indeed, it's nearly impossible to overstate the ideological impact of this shift of responsibility for demographic policies to the ministries tasked with economic development, a decision that superficially appears to be a simple formal rearrangement.[81] Unlike the social sciences, which - rightly so - Mao and his supporters saw as inevitably tied to a process of importing ideas from the West, which they found unacceptable, disciplines related to agricultural production can be interpreted as having their own indigenous character. China before the "century of humiliation" had experienced significant progress in the field of water distribution techniques, so the enhancement of agricultural production through scientific development could simultaneously address both practical and ideological needs. In this regard, Maoist China achieved unprecedented results, where neither the late Empire, nor the Guomindang government, nor the pro-Japanese governments during the occupation had any success; as reported by Davis:

After Liberation (and despite the costs of the Korean intervention), water

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78 Hershatter, *Women and China's Revolutions,* p.246.
79 *Ivi,* p.249.
80 Cfr. Fig.0.2, pag.15.
81 Scharping points out that industrialization and urbanization had already caused an irreversible decline in cultivable land by that point, forcing the Chinese government to abandon the so-called "land-intensive" strategy and switch to a more complex approach to achieve sufficient food production for everyone. Despite all the reclamation efforts made, the simple increase in population had reduced the per capita cultivated area in China from 0.22 hectares per person in 1949 to 0.14 hectares in 1979, increasingly threatened by erosion, desertification, and salinization.

> conservancy was duly accorded the highest priority in successive agricultural plans, and, according to E. Vermeer, "during 1946-1954 the State funds expended on anti-flood work on the Yellow River constituted 22-fold the total invested during the period 1914-1932." Dam construction and dike repair in the 1950s was followed in the early 1970s by a pumpwell revolution in the north China plain which (measured from 1949) increased pump horsepower 400-fold and quadrupled the irrigated acreage along the Yellow River. Irrigation, in tandem with the expansion of the chemical fertilizer industry, was the most important productive force unleashed by China's agrarian reforms just as it was the principal engine powering India's contemporaneous "Green Revolution.".[82]

Embedding the issue of birth control within this vast collective effort toward a *socialist* and *Chinese* agrarian revolution thus brings about a radical change in perspective towards the issue itself, shifting from being considered "bloodless murder" fomented by imperialists to becoming a key factor in the country's redemption. This change appears necessary as the main tool used for agricultural production growth since 1949, namely the reclamation and cultivation of wild areas, had already exhausted its potential by the late 1950s. No other demographic measure alone seems to have had such an immediate and radical effect. However, there are at least two reasons not to consider this transition of birth control to ministries responsible for the economy as the main direct cause of the reduction in births in China. The first is that birth rates were also influenced by policies seemingly unrelated to demographic growth, particularly women's access to education. As we have seen previously, until 1949, the vast majority of women were denied literacy and the ability to write, giving rise to some interesting feminist resistance tools such as nü shu, a linguistic code developed and exclusively used by women in certain regions of central China.[83] In any case, Chinese girls aged between 15 and 19 with no schooling in 1949 accounted for about 80%, while the census conducted in 1982, a few years after Mao Zedong's death, recorded less than 15%.[84]

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[82] Davis, Late Victorian Holocausts, pp.374-375.

[83] Liu Fei-Wen, "From being to becoming: Nu¨shu and sentiments in a Chinese rural community", *American Ethnologist*, Vol. 31, N.3, August 2004, Hoboken (USA), Wiley-Blackwell, 2004, p.422.

[84] William Lavely, Xiao Zhenyu, Li Bohua, Ronald Freedman, "The Rise in Female Education in China: National and Regional Patterns", *The China Quarterly*, Mar. 1990, No. 121 (Mar., 1990), Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1990, p.65.

The second reason is that, despite not officially recognizing the risk of overpopulation, Mao's China had already implemented exceptional preventive measures since 1956, whose irreversible effects on the birth rate precipitated in the 1970s. In a 1970 paper, just before the birth rate curve in China began its most significant decline, Taiwanese scientist and politician Chen Pi-Chao detailed some of these measures. A widespread network of female workers and pioneers, trained through a two-week course on promoting birth control, assisted women during pregnancy and childbirth while introducing families to the concept of family planning, distributing contraceptives, and providing instructions on how to use them. Through a knowledge transmission system, this network later involved traditional midwives, vendors of local natural products, and agricultural cooperatives. Party and State apparatuses, along with their various branches, directly participated in awareness-raising efforts:

> Simultaneously, the provincial health department also undertook various activities - organizing exhibitions, group sessions and lectures in conjunction with a number of mass organizations. Each of these mass organizations directed its efforts to the target group most relevant to itself. The Women's Federation mobilized its members, especially those with three or more chiidren, to visit local birth control exhibitions and to attend group sessions and lectures. The Young Communist League and the trade unions preached the virtues of late marriage and contraception to their members. The Association for the Popularization of Science and the Red Cross Association promoted various methods of contraception through lectures, films or travelling exhibitions. Neighbourhood committees organized lectures and group sessions to which 'mothers with many children' were particularly invited. Hospitals and health stations set up clinics to provide technical guidance. The mass organizations also distributed contraceptives to their target population at nominal prices. In the course of 1957 and early 1958 the campaign, which had begun in the major urban centres, was gradually extended to smaller cities and finally to rural villages. In most of the populous provinces the campaign had reportedly 'descended to the hsien level' by the end of I957. In Honan, Kangsu, Shangtung, Hopei, Fukien and elsewhere the campaign 'had generally reached the overwhelming majority of lesser cities and villages'. For example, by December 1957, every one of Hunan's 95 hsien and cities (except for the areas inhabited by minority groups and the mountainous regions) was reported to have set up a permanent organization to promote planned childbearing, and

> over 20,000 basic level cadres, mostly female, had been trained.[85]

The newspapers showcase exemplary cases of Party cadres and prominent figures advocating for family planning, along with opinions from doctors warning against health risks associated with numerous and closely spaced pregnancies. For the illiterate population, home visits by volunteers, group discussions, and cultural entertainment forms are organized to raise awareness on the issue. Starting from 1962, the government intensifies propaganda against early marriage, and extremely candid sexual education courses are introduced in schools..[86] The practice of abortion, although officially discouraged by the government and indicated only as a last resort, spreads: Chen reports that even in 1962, specialized clinics in Shanghai experience a period of "lively" activity.[87] That year, the abortion law is also amended to eliminate the need for agreement from both spouses, leaving the entire decision solely in the hands of the woman. A stronger emphasis is also placed on vasectomy, which is more economical and less painful compared to female sterilization:

> Peking Jih Pao (Peking Daily), Kung Jen Jih Pao (Daily Workers) and Chung Kuo Chin Nien (Chinese Youth) [...] printed articles urging vasectomy upon their male readers. They argued that the responsibility for planned childbearing does not fall upon the female exclusively; the male, too, has a responsibility. He should get rid of 'feudal' ideas of male supremacy and selfishness. Although the principle of 'voluntarism' is stressed, the regime has not hesitated to apply administrative sanctions against non-compliants when 'persuasion' fails. According to one account, 'If a man had made two women pregnant, he was "encouraged" to be sterilized. If he refused, there was no apparent punishment, but thereafter he was considered to be a "rightist" and unworthy of holding a decent job.[88]

As the most chaotic period of the Cultural Revolution comes to an end, the

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85 Chen Pi-Chao, "China's Birth Control Action Programme, 1956-1964", *Population Studies*, Vol. 24, No. 2 (Jul., 1970), London (United Kingdom), Taylor & Francis, 1970, pp.143-144.

86 Chen Pi-Chao, "China's Birth Control Action Programme, 1956-1964", pp.145-148.

87 *Ivi*, p.150.

88 "Red China", *Look*, ist December I964, p. 26, cit.in Chen Pi-Chao, "China's Birth Control Action Programme, 1956-1964", p.152.

campaigns against Lin Biao and Confucius in the early 1970s continue to explore the causes of female subordination and to attack traditional family and patriarchal structures. However, as we will see later, the post-Maoist transition will bring an end to this trajectory. Therefore, it is precisely from 1949 until Mao's death that, despite some temporary setbacks, women in China experience the greatest historical improvement in their condition. For example, Banister reports that

> A nationwide mortality survey taken in 1976 revealed that as of 1973-75 the people of China had achieved an expectation of life at birth of about 62-64 years. Infant mortality had been reduced to somewhere between 50 and 100 infant deaths per 1,000 live births from a level close to 300 per 1,000 in 1929-31.4 These are advanced mortality conditions for a developing country. By 1975 females in particular had gained from a decline in the historical pattern of infanticide and neglect of girls, and from a rise in the status of women.[89]

In 1975, Chen Pi-Chao, writing in a publication of the Population Council, confirms that

> China's current policy indicates an unequivocal commitment to the planning of births. A 1971 State Council Directive (No. 51) set the tone for the 1970s: Planned birth is an important matter which Chairman Mao has advocated for many years, and demands serious attention by the leading comrades at the various [administrative] levels. Except for the thinly populated national minority areas and others, the leading comrades at each level must strengthen leadership, conduct penetrating propaganda and education, so that late marriage and planning of birth becomes voluntary behavior on the part of the broad masses in cities and the countryside, and strive hard to accomplish outstanding results during the Fourth Five-Year-Plan period [1971-1975]. The concrete action program since 1971 aims to accomplish the following goals: 1. Late marriage: late twenties in urban areas (28 for male, 25 for female); early to mid-twenties in rural areas (25 for male, 23 for female). 2. Childbirth spacing: five-year intervals after the first child. 3. Inculcation of small-family norms: two children in urban areas and three in rural areas-regardless of sex (that is, the number of sons). The term "planned birth" as used in China includes all of these elements, not just the use of contraception.[90]

[89] Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.718.

[90] Chen Pi-Chao, "China, The People's Republic of", *Studies in Family Planning*, Vol. 6, No. 8, New York (USA), Population Council, 1975, p.321

In 1979, another researcher summarized in Population Studies the characteristics of this comprehensive Maoist birth control program: 1) the three slogans Wan Xi Shao ("late, spaced, and few") – meaning late marriage, spacing between births, and a significant reduction in the number of births, 2) an extensive network of operators in the field, 3) abortion as an extreme solution in case of failure in the use of other methods, and 4) mass campaigns as the main tool to convince the population to adopt family planning, while simultaneously discouraging direct coercive measures and attempting to rebalance the distribution of responsibilities within the couple. Another study published at the dawn of the Deng era emphasized the link between the success of the Wan Xi Shao demographic policy and the established norms of marriage introduced in the 1950s:

> It is not to be expected that the adverse effects of millennial traditions can be eliminated in a quarter of a century. During the development and implementation of the present population policy in China, the re-establishment of an effective administrative system, changes in family structure and functions, changes in the status of women, and the development of public health services have been necessary conditions for social change. In particular, the establishment of a new and improved relationship between the individual and society has given individuals a new decision-making power in forming their families.[91]

Chen Pi-Chao reports the common sentiment faced by Party volunteers during family planning promotion campaigns as encountering a culture traditionally hostile to any family planning, risking failure and active resistance, especially from the rural population:

> According to the accounts of Communist newspapers, some peasants said that 'childbearing is a personal matter of the parents. Why should the Communist Party concern itself with such matters? The earlier we plant, the earlier we will harvest. The earlier we give birth to children, the earlier we will enjoy the blessings. Why practise contraception ?' Others said, 'The number of children one gets is predetermined by fate.' Still others felt that contraception caused 'too much trouble and nuisance '.[92]

[91] *Ivi*,p.137
[92] Chen Pi-Chao, "China's Birth Control Action Programme, 1956-1964", p.145.

However, the attempt to instill a new mindset can rely on another fundamental change seemingly unrelated to demographics, namely the reorganization of agricultural production, initially following the cooperative model and later transitioning to that of people's communes, which in the meantime undermined the material basis of traditional patriarchal familism:

> the outstanding change came with the establishment of the agricultural producer's co-operatives and later of the people's communes. This reform permanently destroyed the patriarchal tradition and gave a new meaning to the family. First of all, the family is no longer a production unit; peasants now work and produce for the commune and receive payment for their work. Secondly, the family is no longer a unit of trade; all the commune's produce is sold to the state collectively at a regulated price. Thirdly, the function of the family as a relieving agency in case of distress has been taken over by the commune, since the establishment of the commune welfare fund which covers expenses for cultural activities, education, items of collective welfare, and aid to members who are ill, retired or unable to work. The commune also subsidizes the rural co-operative medical system and provides relief to members who are in financial difficulties. More precisely, the family is no longer the only agency which can provide positive help to those who need it. [93]

Margery Wolf notes in 1983 that for Chinese women, some advancements had now been established and rooted, including the sense of "liberation from a life of isolation in domestic toil" through albeit harsh waged labor[94], access to employment in all productive sectors, adoption of the principle of "equal pay for equal work"[95], the need for male participation in household chores – although the concept of "double burden" for women remains widespread[96], and the opportunity to openly discuss sexuality and contraceptive methods.[97]

Indeed, multiple radical changes experienced by Chinese society during the Maoist period had a direct or indirect impact on the fertility rate. When these changes reached a "critical mass" and affected a new generation of women, around the late 1960s to early 1970s, the birth rate began a steep decline. Therefore, it is a mistake to

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[93] Yu Y.C., "The Population Policy of China", p. 136.
[94] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.56.
[95] *Ivi,* p.68.
[96] The term "double burden" refers to the responsibility of managing the household in addition to having employment outside of it. See Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, pp.73-74.
[97] *Ivi,* p.252.

think that family planning and the reduction of the fertility rate were issues addressed seriously only with the introduction of market mechanisms and the "one-child policy," portraying Mao Zedong as a staunch advocate of pro-natal policies.[98] This prejudice arises from a superficial understanding of the Marxist critique of Malthus, presenting the fierce criticisms of the English economist by Marx, Engels, and Mao as a preclusion on their part to the idea that uncontrolled population growth could be a problem, and therefore that no type of regulation and demographic planning was necessary.

2.3- Mao against Malthus: a "chinese way" to population control?

Engels had already envisioned a post-capitalist society in which human reproduction would be an integral part of the planning and organization of labor in his exposition of the theory of the "dual character" or "two kinds" of production:

> According to the materialistic conception, the essential and decisive motive in history lies in the production and reproduction of immediate life. These, in turn, are of two kinds. On the one hand, the production of the means of subsistence: food, clothing, shelter, and the tools that procure them; on the other hand, the procreation of human beings themselves, the reproduction of the species.[99]

According to Engels, human reproduction is inextricably linked to social organization, and with the evolution of the latter towards increasingly complex forms, it is unimaginable to think that the former is not profoundly influenced by the latter. Mao himself, despite rejecting the problematization of demographic growth in his 1949 response to Dean Acheson, demonstrates on several occasions that he

[98] Cfr. Martin King Whyte, Wang Feng, Yong Cai, "Challenging Myths About China's One-Child Policy", *The China Journal*, No. 74 (July 2015), Chicago (USA), University of Chicago Press, 2015, p.146.

[99] Frederick Engels, *L'Origine della Famiglia, della Proprietà Privata e dello Stato*, Milano, Uffici della Critica Sociale, 1901, p.5. It will be precisely from Engels's considerations that Deng Xiaoping will outline a theoretical-ideological framework that justifies birth control policies, a framework defined precisely as "the double character of production."

considers the size of the population both a resource and a problem to be reckoned with.

> In drawing up plans, handling affairs or thinking over problems, we must proceed from the fact that China has a population of 600 million, and we must never forget this fact. Why do we make a point of this? Is it possible that there are people who are still unaware that we have a population of 600 million? Of course, everyone knows this, but when it comes to actual practice, some people forget all about it and act as though the fewer the people, the smaller the circle, the better. Those who have this "small circle" mentality abhor the idea of bringing every positive factor into play, of uniting with everyone who can be united with, and of doing everything possible to turn negative factors into positive ones so as to serve the great cause of building a socialist society. I hope these people will take a wider view and fully recognize that we have a population of 600 million, that this is an objective fact, and that it is an asset for us. Our large population is a good thing, but of course it also involves certain difficulties.[100]

In the initial publication of the famous speech "On the Correct Handling of Contradictions Among the People" in 1957, the following words of Mao are reported, clearly in support of the implementation of stringent family planning policies:

> Our country has so many people, which no country in the world can compare with. It would be better to have fewer births. (Re)production needs to be planned. In my view, humankind is completely incapable of managing itself. It has plans for production in factories, for producing cloth, tables and chairs, and steel, but there is no plan for producing humans. This is anarchism—no governing, no organization and no rules. This government perhaps needs to have a special ministry—what about a ministry of birth control? Or perhaps establishing a commission, as part of the government?[101]

From another speech given also in 1957, the following words of Mao are reported: "Of course birth control is still necessary, and I am not for encouraging more births. [...] It's not OK to have human reproduction in a state of total anarchy—we need

[100] Mao Zedong, *Selected Works*, vol. V, Beijing (RPC), Foreign Languages Press, 1977.
[101] Cit. in King Whyte et al., "Challenging Myths About China's One-Child Policy", pp. 146-149.

birth planning." However, in subsequent editions of the speech, these passages are removed.[102] Therefore, while maintaining an oscillating position rhetorically, Mao Zedong demonstrates in practice to be attentive to the demographic balance of the country. Hsu Mei-Ling, a geographer at the University of Minnesota, writing in 1985, identifies three different campaigns launched respectively in the decades of the '50s, '60s, and '70s, and considers the OCP "not a departure but an extension of the previous planning policy.".[103] Probably due to the fact that during the Maoist period, *no real direct material disincentive* to procreation is introduced, the evolution of Chinese political demography during this phase is often underestimated; it must instead be remembered that it is precisely in the period *before* the introduction of the OCP that China experiences the most profound demographic change in its history.

> Between 1949 and 1978 the People's Republic of China completed most of its historic demographic transition from a situation of high mortality and high fertility to conditions of low mortality and low fertility, an unusual achievement among the world's developing countries.[104]

The fertility rate drops from a peak reached in 1963 of 7.78 in rural areas and 6.21 in urban areas, to a historic low in 1980 of 2.48 in rural areas and an impressive 1.15 in cities.[105] The portrayal of the OCP as a "great success" in urbanized areas of the country is at least a distortion, as it should essentially be presented as the consolidation of results practically already achieved before its implementation.

According to Malthus, China had already reached the peak of its population in the nineteenth century, inevitably constrained by periodic famines:

> In some countries population appears to have been forced, that is, the people

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[102] *Ibidem.*

[103] Hsu Mei-Ling, "Growth and Control of Population in China: The Urban-Rural Contrast", *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (Jun., 1985), London (United Kingdom), Taylor & Francis, 1985, p.248.

[104] Judith Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China, 1978-83", *The China Quarterly*, vol.100, December 1984, Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1984 p.717.

[105] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, pp.249; Il dato torna a crescere nel 1981, tuttavia come si vedrà in seguito ci sono buone ragioni per pensare che tale rimbalzo sia dovuto anche a una reazione attiva da parte della popolazione alle nuove politiche annunciate di limitazione delle nascite; Cfr. Hsu, "Growth and Control of Population in China", p.246.

> have been habituated by degrees to live almost upon the smallest possible quantity of food. There must have been periods in such counties when population increased permanently, without an increase in the means of subsistence. China seems to answer to this description. If the accounts we have of it are to be trusted, the lower classes of people are in the habit of living almost upon the smallest possible quantity of food and are glad to get any putrid offals that European labourers would rather starve than eat. The law in China which permits parents to expose their children has tended principally thus to force the population. A nation in this state must necessarily be subject to famines.[106]

According to Malthus, the country would not have been able to overcome these "positive checks," and its population would have remained stagnant and impoverished due to insurmountable structural impediments.[107] The English economist conceived the demographic transition towards a regime of low birth and low death rates as the result of an exclusively Western attitude towards the deliberate calculation of the costs and benefits of having children and the strategic postponement of marriage; it is necessary to avoid falling into the same simplistic reductionism as Malthus:

> In such a conception, non-Western patriarchy, social formation, and economic processes are all subsumed in a universal binary "other" that by its very nature is antimodern. China, in particular, is singled out as the personification of this other-partly as a consequence of its size, partly as a consequence of its better-documented history. Malthus specifically identified China as the prime example of a society dominated by the positive check and virtually devoid of any preventive check. Similarly Hajnal (1982) and Roger Schofield (1989) have proposed that if the Western European family system stood at one extreme of the social spectrum, China, together with India, occupied the other.
>
> [...]
>
> the absence of [...] studies of Chinese population history has facilitated the perpetuation of the binary opposition elaborated by Malthus. Superficial eighteenth-century commentaries have consequently become time-honored

[106] Thomas Malthus, *An Essay on the Principle of Population*, vers. Johnson 1798, Electronic Scholarly Publishing Project, 1998, p.41.

[107] *Ivi*, pp.101-102.

truths; Malthusian hypotheses have become accepted theories.[108]

It's not surprising then that Malthusian theories didn't gain much traction in China outside of narrow pro-Western circles, whether within or outside the Communist Party.[109] The Chinese demographic policy, especially during the Maoist era, demonstrates the possibility of economic development and demographic control beyond and against Malthus. Moreover, this policy isn't forcibly imposed on the "ground" of a culture simply unsuitable for development and demographic transition. Instead, it succeeds precisely because it's accompanied by measures that take into account the long-standing social and familial behaviors distinctively Chinese, diverging from the Western path. Lee and Feng identify at least four "distinctive aspects" of Chinese demographic culture that contribute to the development of an "indigenous" family planning trend, evolving independently of the influence of Western individualism that Malthus deemed indispensable. These four aspects include the Chinese approach to mortality, marital customs, fertility management, and traditional adoptions.[110] Gradually and organically intervening in these areas since the early 1950s, including traditional Chinese doctors in the dissemination mechanism of the family planning principle, and applying policies far removed from the Western model, such as the collectivization of caregiving work, Maoist China achieved its demographic transition following a model unimaginable to Malthus. During the Maoist period, the approach to population control thus followed a path separate from that of the rest of the world. With Mao's death and the rise to power in China of a leadership group committed to opening the country to the mechanisms of the global market, demographic sciences developed abroad quickly regained great relevance. It is therefore important to briefly analyze the evolution of demographic thought in the West during the period when China suspended exchanges in this field, in order to understand both sides of the comparison between two worlds that remained effectively isolated from each other for almost thirty years.

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[108] James Lee, Feng Wang, "Malthusian Models and Chinese Realities: The Chinese Demographic System 1700-2000", *Population and Development Review*, Vol. 25, No. 1, New York (USA), Population Council, 1999, p.35.

[109] Richard J. Wiltgen, "Marx's and Engels's conception of Malthus – The Heritage of a critique", *Organization & Environment*, Vol.11 No. 4, New York (USA), SAGE Publications, 1998, p.455.

[110] Lee, Feng, "Malthusian Models and Chinese Realities", pp.33-65.

2.4- Political Demography in the West from 1949 to the 1970s

A central role in the development of reflections, research, and practices in the field of birth control in the second half of the twentieth century is played by Non-Governmental Organizations, foremost among them the Population Council. This organization holds the patent for some of the most widely used models of intrauterine devices, such as the copper T IUD, Norplant®, Jadelle®, and the LNG-IUS contraceptive implant.[111] The organization is a branch of the Rockefeller Foundation, which over the years has contributed enormously to scientific research in the field of human reproduction, and its merits cannot be ignored.[112] However, it is necessary to critically analyze the message and actions that this organization has promoted during the historical phases we are examining.

Long before the creation of the Population Council, the Rockefeller Foundation was interested in the issue of reproductive control in China. It has been directly involved in the country since 1913, introducing birth control both theoretically and practically through training programs, field studies, and support for the production and dissemination of various contraceptive methods. For John D. Rockefeller 3rd, population growth in China was "a significant problem."[113] He was also among the main supporters and financiers of the initiatives of Margaret Sanger, whom we encountered in the previous chapter.[114] The foundation of the Population Council is the result of a "Conference on Population Problems" held in 1952 for a select, invitation-only audience, organized by Rockefeller and the future head of the Atomic Energy Commission, Lewis Strauss. The conference was attended by eminent scientists from various fields, including a number of Nobel laureates, and some of the most influential activists in the field of population control, such as Fairfield Osborn and William Vogt, the latter also the Director of the Planned Parenthood Federation of America (PPFA). Osborn and Vogt were respectively the authors of *Our Plundered Planet* and *Road to Survival*, two bestsellers in the 1940s that widely

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[111] Population Council, 2023, *Family Planning*, <https://www.popcouncil.org/research/family-planning>, last consultation 02/02/2023.

[112] For example, many of the studies referenced in this work have been published in a significant scientific journal published by the Population Council, the *Population and Development Review.*

[113] Wang et al., “Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 954.

[114] Longkumer, "The Rockefellers, Margaret Sanger and the Eugenic Dimension of Birth Control", p.11.

disseminated grim predictions about the planet's ability to support its growing human population. The conference was held at the Williamsburg Inn, which enforced a strict whites-only admission policy. The theme of the meeting was better defined by Rockefeller himself in the following terms: "whether or not there is a limit to the number of people that wisely can be permitted in the world, even assuming there is enough food to supply them."[115] The explicitly eugenic tones, openly racist attitudes, and clear excuses for colonialism that characterize the discussion are more understandable within the historical context of the early '50s than the one of today, however they remain particularly disturbing. Michael Connelly reports:

> The verbatim transcript suggests that the most sensitive and contentious debates — with participants accusing each other of "being provocative" before going off the record — concerned whether "industrial development should be withheld" from poor, agrarian countries like India.
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> […] Warren Weaver[116] considered the environmentalists too pessimistic, but he openly worried that development aid would only make Indians "nigger rich." Weaver translated: "a man who finds out that he has a little income.—And what does he do? Well, at that moment he just stops working four days or a week, and he just sits there. I do not think that is what we want to bring to India."
>
> […] Weaver was not the only one who fell back on his experience of divisions in American society to understand relations between rich and poor countries, particularly regarding "the potential degradation of the genetic quality of the human race"—as Detlev Bronk put it.
>
> […] Frederick Osborn painted a truly apocalyptic picture: "This little group of three or four hundred people, who produce most of the freedom of the human mind . . . may be engulfed by a great mass of people to whom these conceptions are largely alien."[117]

The only woman present at the meeting is Irene Taeuber, one of the four demographers tasked with coordinating the Conference. Like many of her

[115] Matthew Connelly, *Fatal Misconception. The Struggle to Control World Population*, Cambridge (USA), The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2008, p.157.
[116] Chief of the Natural Sciences Division at the Rockefeller Foundation.
[117] Connelly, *Fatal Misconception*, p.158.

colleagues, Taeuber is a strong advocate for prioritizing population control over economic development in the Global South. She argues that in Asia and the Middle East, "the survival of Westernized groups is at stake."[118] Connelly continues:

> On the last day, the meeting accorded a “fuzzy mandate” to a committee consisting of Rockefeller, Notestein, and Frederick Osborn—“a license for JDR to do pretty much as he liked,” as his biographers put it. What he liked, and what he paid for, came to be known as the Population Council.
>
> […The organization] became not only the world’s preeminent institute for policy-oriented research in demography and contraception, but also a nexus for all the other major players in the field.

The initial goal of the Population Council is summarized as convincing "Asians" to "desire population control for themselves," with the primary tool being the systematic production of "influence on public opinion and policies, even direct, channeling such influence through international agencies," and forming an indigenous scientific and intellectual elite that promotes the organization's goals, even if this means producing "rather poor quality" science.[119] Few years later, we find the participants actively involved in realizing this vision, as shown for example by Taeuber stating in an interview given to Chinese researchers:

> The future course of the population of China may seem to be a dependent variable, and in many ways it is. But given the immensity of the Chinese population and the formidable barriers to economic development, the rate of increase of the population may become the most critical of all the factors of change. If the Communists do not so recognize it at present, it is likely that they will be forced to do so eventually."[120]

Until the 1950s, the trajectory of demographic thought in the West does not deviate much from the positions Sanger had articulated thirty years earlier. It is only from the

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[118] *Ivi*, pp.156-158.
[119] Connelly, *Fatal Misconception*, pp..157-159.
[120] Wong ,"Consequences of China's New Population Policy", p.239.

1960s and 1970s, also due to critical pressure from anti-colonial struggles, that social and demographic sciences change tone, gradually losing explicit references to "race". Concern for safeguarding the West from the danger posed by non-European masses leading "narrow, grim, meaningless lives" is replaced by a more "digestible" discourse, namely the imminent ecological disaster primarily linked to overpopulation. In 1968, the most famous and representative work of this new trend, *The Population Bomb* by Paul R. Erlich, was published, followed in 1972 by another crucial work defining this current of thought, *The Limits to Growth*, a study conducted by a group of MIT computer researchers commissioned by the Club of Rome. In China, all studies more or less aligned with this Western perspective would be assimilated under the category of "Club of Rome", referred to as *Luoma Julebu*.[121]

However, it's not only non-governmental actors who are active on the issue of population control. A memorandum signed by Henry Kissinger on behalf of US President Nixon and declassified in the early 1990s reveals how the US government itself considered it crucial to integrate the dissemination of population control measures into its international strategy. In the report, overpopulation in developing countries is clearly associated with "national security," and various tactics are considered to exert pressure on the leadership of identified priority countries. China remains marginal in the memorandum precisely because the strategic program proposed in the document relies on direct intervention, which in China in 1974 is still considered impossible. The criteria indicated for classifying priority intervention areas, in order of importance, are as follows:

> long run U.S. political interests; impact of rapid population growth on its development potential; the country's relative contribution to world population growth; its financial capacity to cope with the problem; potential impact on domestic unrest and international frictions (which can apply to small as well as large countries); its significance as a test or demonstration case; and opportunities for expenditures that appear particularly cost-effective (e.g. it has been suggested that there may be particularly cost-effective opportunities for supporting family planning to reduce the lag between mortality and fertility declines in countries where death rates are still declining rapidly); national commitment to an effective program.[122]

[121] Greenhalgh, *Just One Child*, p.125.
[122] National Security Study Memorandum (NSSM 200), *Implications of Worldwide Population*

It becomes evident how China, at the moment when it reopens scientific exchanges with the USA just a few years later, meets all these criteria probably like no other country in the world. Therefore, it is unimaginable that the comprehensive, long-term strategy adopted by the USA for global population containment would not unfold precisely in the country that best aligns with the priorities of such a plan, once the opportunity arises.

In 1976, between January and September, both Zhou Enlai and Mao Zedong passed away. After a relatively tumultuous transitional period, Deng Xiaoping emerged as the new leader who would significantly change many of the policies of the People's Republic of China (PRC), including demographic policies. It was during this new phase that China introduced its most controversial population control measures.

Growth For U.S. Security and Overseas Interests, declassified and released on 7/3/89 by F. Graboske, National Security Council, p.76.

CHAPTER 3

CONTROL THE POPULATION. THE ECONOMIC BOOM AND THE “ONE-CHILD POLICY”, 1976-2000

After Mao's death, the People's Republic of China (PRC) faced a complex demographic and economic landscape: some data were objectively extraordinary, while others fueled justified concerns. The radical reforms introduced by Deng Xiaoping during his tenure aimed at the country's economic growth through integration into a world system from which his predecessor had kept a distance, despite some significant openings in the early 1970s. The process of Reform and Opening Up was warmly received by the West and had transformative effects of exceptional magnitude, yet it also caused profound imbalances and strong public mobilization around them. The controversial "one-child policy" emerged as a major theme during this phase. In this chapter, we aim to better understand this policy by analyzing it within different contexts: the broader framework of political and economic reforms, the Western response to it, and the various socio-cultural changes impacting Chinese women in the last two decades of the 20th century.

3.1- The “One-Child Policy” as an integral part of the Reform and Opening Up process, and the role of the West

The doubling of average life expectancy between 1949 and 1976 had more than compensated for the reduction in births, so the Chinese population in absolute terms continued to increase. A national survey conducted in 1976 revealed that life expectancy had reached 62-63 years, more than double that recorded in 1949, while

infant mortality had decreased more than tenfold over fifty years.[123] At the same time, per capita food quantity and economic availability for families remained stagnant, while arable land was decreasing at unsustainable rates due to urbanization and industrialization.[124] Previously, these imbalances had been addressed with mass campaigns associated with the 上山下乡运动 (Shàngshān xià xiāng yùndòng), literally the 'Up to the mountains and down to the countryside movement.' This involved a redistribution from urban to rural areas based on voluntarism and social pressure, initiated in the 1950s and accelerated during the period of the Great Cultural Revolution.[125] The shift in policy towards the promotion of *Wan Xi Shao* during the last five years of the Maoist era was driven by the idea that a more direct and actively targeted intervention was necessary to reduce births, albeit without introducing punitive measures.

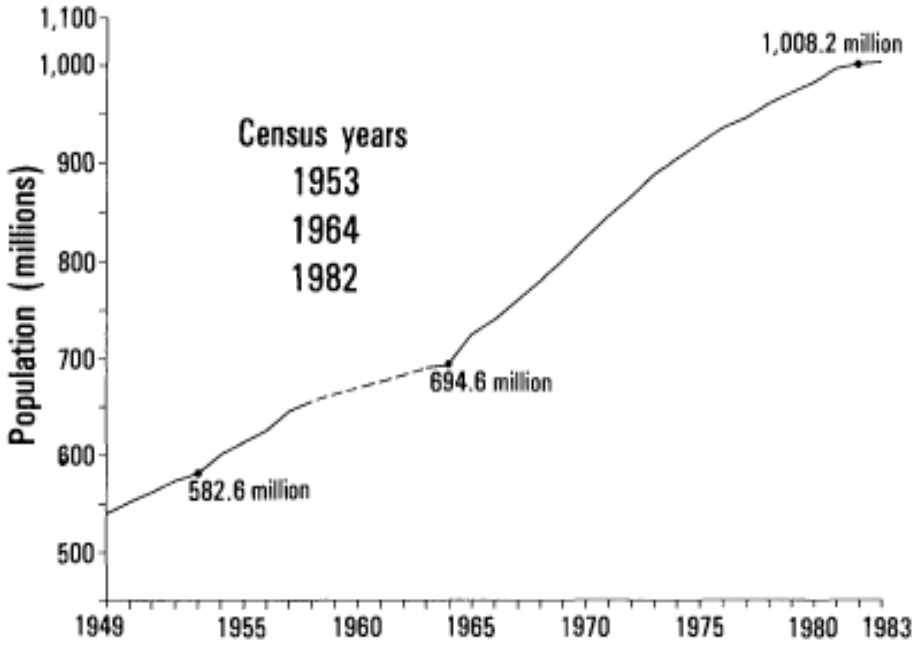

Fig.3.1 – How the curve of the Chinese demographic appears in 1983. Source: Hsu Mei-Ling, "Growth and Control of Population in China: The Urban-Rural Contrast", *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (Jun., 1985), pp. 241-257, London (United Kingdom), Taylor & Francis, 1985

[123] Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.718.
[124] Smil, "Who Will Feed China?", p.801.
[125] Anne McLaren riporta ad esempio che a partire dal 1966 circa due milioni di giovani Shanghainesi avevano lasciato la città per andare a vivere e lavorare in zone remote della Cina, salvo poi tornare in massa dopo la morte di Mao. Cfr. Anne McLaren, "The Educated Youth Return: The Poster Campaign in Shanghai from November 1978 to March 1979", *The Australian Journal of Chinese Affairs*, No. 2 (Jul., 1979), Chicago (USA), Chicago University Press, 1979, p.1.

The fear that demographic growth could jeopardize the achievements in life expectancy and access to essential goods and services becomes pressing. As seen earlier, it is not only the memory of the temporary yet profound crisis caused by the Great Leap Forward that keeps the Chinese leadership and people on edge, but also the specter of the century of famine and epidemics experienced by the three preceding generations. In this context, at the highest levels of the country's political leadership, the resurgent Westernizing tendencies, which had been subdued during Mao's rule, focus primarily on science. In May 1977, Hua Guofeng, then the paramount leader of China, approved the creation of the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences (CASS), an institute independent from the Chinese Academy of Sciences and dedicated to reintroducing disciplines that had been sidelined in the previous phase. The involvement of demographers and social scientists from "capitalist" countries is once again sought after and appreciated.[126] Demographic study centers are created in various parts of the country to train new specialists, and many promising young mathematicians and scientists are sent abroad to pursue advanced programs of study in statistics, demography, and related fields.[127] Chinese economists who had been excluded from the academy or had moved abroad during the Cultural Revolution are reinstated and encouraged to return to Beijing.[128] Julian Gewirtz emphasizes the importance of the introduction by these Chinese researchers of ideas and concepts from the West to the decision-making apparatus of the government:

> there was no single audience in China for the ideas and proposals of foreign economists. [First minister] Zhao Ziyang often acted as the arbiter and decider in debates over economic policy. At times he met personally with foreign economists, a sign of the importance attached to their visits to China. But he rarely engaged at length with these visiting experts. Instead, he drew on a fl exible network of Chinese economists and policy makers to interpret the advice from abroad. Some of these economic experts reported directly to the State Council, which Zhao led as premier, or were affi liated with central policy-making organs like the System Reform Commission and the Research Offi ce of the State Planning Commission. Others staffed government- run research institutions, most notably the Chinese Acad emy of Social Sciences (CASS), while universities like the prestigious Peking and Tsinghua universities

[126] Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.721.
[127] *Ivi,* p.736.
[128] Julian B. Gewirtz, *Unlikely partners : Chinese reformers, Western economists, and the making of global China*, Cambridge (USA), Harvard University Press, 2017, p.25.

employed others.[129]

This mediation and reinterpretation of Western social sciences are crucial. As we've seen in the case of the Population Council, major scientific institutions working in demography are fully aware of this process and its potential impact on policy. They recognize that it may lead to a decline in research quality through oversimplification, significantly influencing policy outcomes.

Under the influence of Deng Xiaoping's unstoppable rise, economics is nevertheless the discipline where it is most necessary to "look around":

> Economic expertise became critical to the goals of China's leaders— and economic policy makers began what Deng called "taking a look around," a casual- sounding phrase that belies the intensity of their efforts [...]
>
> In 1978, Deng told a vice premier before a trip to Western Europe: "We ought to study the successful experiences of capitalist countries and bring them back to China."[130]

As per the linguistic-cultural tradition, this turn and change in the economic, scientific, and technological development of post-Maoist China are given a name: the "Four Modernizations." Although initially conceived by Zhou Enlai, it later became closely associated with Deng's leadership. These modernizations refer to China's need to make a leap in its technical and productive capabilities in agriculture, industry, military, and scientific research.[131] In turn, these "Four Modernizations" are geared towards a singular, fundamental goal: achieving rapid economic growth, which since December 1978 adopts a crucial indicator, per capita GDP. This establishes a direct and inseparable link between the economy and demography, as the size of the Chinese population becomes a critical factor in measuring the success of the new post-Maoist course.[132] One of the main new scientific journals born in this

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[129] *Ivi*, p. 7.
[130] Gewirtz, *Unlikely partners*, p.3.
[131] *Ivi*, p.20.
[132] Huang Yanzhong, Yang Dali L., "Population Control and State Coercion in China", in *Holding*

phase, *Renkou yanjiu*, in its second issue published in 1981, very clearly synthesizes this link:

> The Central Committee of our Party has said that our gross national product should reach an average of US$1,000 per capita within this century. In order to reach this target, our GNP would have to increase at an annual rate of 8.6 per cent if our total population did not exceed 1.2 billion. But if the total population reached 1.3 billion, then the GNP must grow by 9.6 per cent annually. The latter rate would be very difficult to achieve.[133]

The struggle for women's emancipation is thus completely subordinated to the achievement of economic targets. In a short time, the fierce anti-patriarchal critique that had characterized the last years of Mao's government is abandoned, and the millennia-old prejudices that the Great Helmsman had tried to eradicate re-emerge. Margery Wolf notes that

> Although in 1980 women occasionally repeated slogans from the Anti-Confucius Campaign in answer to my questions, they also told me that it was "natural" for men to rule outside the home and women to rule within. Indeed, many seemed to think their newfound voice within the house, limited though it might be, was the victory they had been preparing for.[134]

At the time of the Fifth Plenary Session of the Party in 1980, Deng Xiaoping had completed the process of marginalizing the Maoist left, having achieved a majority of members adhering to his program within the Politburo and its Standing Committee, the highest levels of the Chinese decision-making apparatus. It is this majority of reformist centrists, promoters of China's opening to the global market,

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China Together: Diversity and National Integration in the Post-Deng Era, edited by Barry Naughton and Dali L. Yang, Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 2004, p.196.

[133] "An outline of propaganda for controlling population growth in China," *Renkou yanjiu*, No. 2 (1981), p. 2, cit.in Wong Siu-lun, "Consequences of China's New Population Policy", *The China Quarterly,* No. 98 (Jun., 1984), Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1984, p.222.

[134] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.24.

that introduces the harshest measures aimed at controlling births.[135] The projections – the *graphs* – produced by the new generation of the Chinese academy suggest the necessity of such measures.

The liberalizations introduced by Deng Xiaoping lead to the state's withdrawal from many sectors: in particular, the decollectivization in the countryside implies the suspension of most services that provided women with significant support for caregiving work, which once again becomes the responsibility of the family unit. At the same time, the cultural and political promotion of the Maoist image of the 'iron girl,' emancipated through work outside the home and equal to men in every respect, comes to an end. Instead, propaganda begins to emphasize biological differences that supposedly justify a new division of labor entirely oriented towards the rationalization of roles based on scientistic principles and 'nature'.[136] Gail Hershatter summarizes the rapid transition from a model that tended to suppress gender differences to one in which these are strongly emphasized as follows:

> During the Mao years women had been exhorted to contribute to socialist construction and told [...] that they could "do everything that men comrades can do." Now they were urged to make themselves attractive, support their men and children at work and school, and help ensure stability in an era of dizzying social change.[137]

In this context, the 'one-child policy' is introduced, justified as a measure to contain a possible rebound in fertility due to the regression of women's status, of which the top Chinese leaders are aware.[138] In the speech where he hands over the leadership of the Party and the country to Deng, Hua Guofeng announces in September 1980 that 'after much research,' the government has decided to adopt a 'one-child policy' and aims to contain the growth of the Chinese population to within 1.2 billion by the year 2000. A few days later, the Central Committee publishes a crucial open letter addressed to

[135] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.102.
[136] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.238.
[137] Hershatter, *Women and China's Revolutions,* p.252.
[138] In fact, economic expansion has led to a continued increase in women's participation in the workforce, albeit by only 3.3% during the five-year period from 1978 to 1983. However, this increase in labor force participation contrasts sharply with significant setbacks in almost all other areas.

party members and its youth league. In this letter, the goals mentioned by Hua are reaffirmed, presenting a dramatic scenario in case of failure and providing answers to the main objections that such a policy might raise, such as population aging, labor force reduction, and an accentuated gender imbalance. Consultation of the main works on the issue makes it clear that this is the moment identified by the majority of experts as when the one-child policy officially comes into effect. However, it is not possible to define it with complete certainty, as this policy will never be the subject of uniform and specific legislation, despite Deng Xiaoping stating the more generic need for legislation on family planning from the beginning of 1979.[139]

The concrete implementation of the directive follows a typical pattern, similar to that of other subsequent campaigns: the central government, based on the experts' projections, defines a specific goal for each province regarding the population growth rate. The provincial governments, in concert with the provincial Party leadership, in turn 'distribute' the expected growth across the various counties and municipalities, assigning each an ideal birth quota not to be exceeded. This process continues similarly down to the lowest level, that of neighborhood committees, which theoretically should know exactly how many births are 'authorized' among the families under their jurisdiction.

The 'one-child policy' thus materializes in the form of 'contracts' that families sign, committing to not exceed the assigned quota (generally one child in urban areas and two children in rural areas, with a wide and complex regime of exceptions). These documents are subsequently required to access various economic assistance services but, most importantly, are mandatory for employment in state-owned enterprises, with substantial monetary penalties for non-compliance.

However, on a large scale, if September 1980 is considered the moment when the OCP is more or less officially inaugurated, it initially proves to be a failure: in 1981 and 1982, the fertility rate, after hitting a historic low in 1980, paradoxically begins to rise again

The slight fertility rebound of 1981 and 1982 was caused by declining age at

[139] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, pp.95,107.

> marriage resulting in a concentration of first births in those years, and also by people rushing to bear second and higher order children before the government's one-child limit could catch up with them. According to the 1982 national fertility survey, firstborn children accounted for 47 per cent of 1981 births. Births of a second child constituted 25 per cent, while third and higher order births made up 28 per cent of live births nationwide in 1981.[140]

The new "scientific" and regulatory approach to population control thus fails to achieve the desired effects, with the crucial 1982 census unequivocally demonstrating that the program is failing; reasons are attributed to the population's fear that the campaign might intensify in subsequent years, prompting a "rush" to have a second or third child, and to the lowering of the legal marriage age. From January 1, 1981, the government had indeed reduced the minimum age for marriage to 20 years for women and 22 years for men, responding to the demand from rural populations to ease the high limits of the *Wan Xi Shao* policy of the previous decade, thus helping them "digest" the new birth limitation policy. The rebound in the fertility rate alarms Chinese leaders, prompting from 1983 onwards the reintroduction of the late marriage requirement, although not directly reinstating the minimum age, as a key criterion alongside the number of children in various documents comprising the "system" of the OCP .[141] During this period, this measure is accompanied by a mass campaign and a period of reduced scrutiny regarding abuses, resulting in the fertility rate declining again in 1984-85, though not returning to the levels of 1980. It is during this phase that many of the most glaring cases of coercion against women are documented. Margery Wolf, a direct witness of this process in 1983, describes it as "a very efficient system that simultaneously assigns responsibility and grants some flexibility at every level, but which also lends itself to serious abuses that could occur especially among local cadres less attentive to methods and more focused on numerical targets."[142] Wolf reports typical examples of such abuses and the limited effectiveness of disciplinary measures put in place to contain them:

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[140] Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.731.
[141] *Ivi*, p.728.
[142] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, pp.241-243.

> During the mass sterilization drives of 1979, nearly all women in some villages who had borne three or more children were sterilized. The issue of forced abortion, a subject burdened with moral questions in the West, cannot be ignored. In interviewing about contraceptive techniques in one rural commune, I was told that their commune had performed 587 abortions in 1980: of these 587 abortions, 252 were "big month" abortions. "Big month" abortions are those performed on women past their fifth month of pregnancy. When I asked why there were so many of these late abortions, I was told that it was a far greater number than usual, but when the new government regulations were announced disallowing third-order births, these women were already far into their pregnancies. They were nonetheless considered illegal pregnancies. I have no way of knowing whether or not these women were willing to have abortions. Abortions are, beyond a doubt, performed with unknown frequency on women who do not want them, and they may sometimes be done under cruel and degrading circumstances. Whenever abuses of this sort burst forth into the newspapers, central government and provincial authorities make strong and sincere statements condemning the local cadres who are held responsible. They may even take more punitive actions, but the pressure on local cadres to meet their quota remains.[143]

Testimonies like this can be found in great numbers in every later Western publication on the issue. The OCP can appear as a demographic policy which is completely alien to the Western liberal-democratic model, but to judge it as such would erase the fundamental role of the Malthusian theories coming from the West that inspired the Chinese "reformers", but also the *direct* and *active* contribution of Western political and academic institutions to the OCP, especially during its most coercive phase: during the first five-year period of the implementation of the policy, which includes the widest and arguably the harshest mass campaign of 1983-84, the "international community" led by the West shows fully endorses the birth-reduction effort in China.

The United States' support to scientific apparatuses, foundations, non-governmental organizations and most of all to the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) is particularly relevant for the development of the Chinese demographic policy of this phase. Between 1965 and 2004 the US government, through the United States

[143] *Ivi*, pp.245-246.

Agency for International Development (USAID) and the UNFPA, has invested 17.3 billion dollars in birth-control programs in “priority” countries. With Deng's Reform and Opening Up, China becomes the main focus of the population containment policies that were brought forward by the NSSM-200 document signed by Kissinger in 1974, that we've encountered in the previous chapter: China clearly corresponds to the criteria of that classified paper more than any other country in the World. A group of researchers dives into the content of this crucial document and others related to it:

> The primary purpose of U.S.-funded population control efforts was to maintain access to the mineral resources of less-developed countries. According to the [NSSM-200 document], elements of the implementation of population control programs could include: • the legalization of abortion; • financial incentives for countries to increase their abortion, sterilization, and contraception-use rates; • indoctrination of children; and • mandatory population control and coercion of other forms, such as withholding disaster and food aid unless a country implements population control programs. NSSM-200 also specifically declared that the United States was to cover up its population control activities and avoid charges of imperialism by inducing the United Nations and various nongovernmental organizations - specifically the Pathfinder Fund, the International Planned Parenthood Foundation (IPPF), and the Population Council - to do its dirty work.[144]

Winckler recalls that from the early 1980s to the end of the 20th century, UNFPA conducted five cycles of programs in China, gradually shifting from pure demographic growth containment to promoting reproductive health.»[145] Winckler continues highlighting the efforts that the UNFPA deploys starting from the beginning of the '90s to push the Chinese leadership towards “less coercive approaches, more health-oriented”, but He liquidates the previous decade as the time when the UN fund “helps in training demographers and improve contraceptive methods”.[146] The Wang group instead shows that

> For many years, the U.S. government has funded the U.N. Fund for Population Activities (UNFPA). One of the main targets of UNFPA money was the

[144] Wang et al., “Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 955.
[145] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.147.
[146] *Ibidem.*

> People's Republic of China (PRC) and its widely criticized forced abortion and family planning program. According to its own documents, the UNFPA has donated more than $100 million to China's population control program; bought and custom-designed a $12 million IBM computer complex specifically to monitor the population program; provided the technical expertise and personnel that trained thousands of Chinese population control officials; and presented China with a U.N. award for the 'most outstanding population control program'. Thus, there is overwhelming evidence that the draconian measures applied by the Chinese government drew heavily from a script drafted in Washington, DC in the highest levels of government.[147]

That "demographic nightmare" gripping the West, projected exclusively onto non-European populations regardless of the "digestibility" of its rationale—first as open eugenic racism, then as "ecological sustainability"—remained a dominant theme in the early 1980s, as is evident from the sources. Margery Wolf herself gathered material for her *Revolution Postponed* during the early years of Deng's government, highlighting numerous issues in a Chinese society characterized by a "continuous oppression of women." As we have seen, she was an eyewitness to the implementation of the One-Child Policy during the first "birth reduction campaign" in 1983, reporting on cases of abuse like those mentioned earlier. However, when it comes to suggesting the most urgent measures to be taken on a large scale, she argues that

> [In urban China,] what is needed is radical steps to socialize housework and domesticate males. Turning now to rural China, we find a different set of problems. For many years China's agricultural production has been running a breathtaking race with its population growth, sometimes falling behind but generally keeping barely even. However, without sharply increased production of food and sharply decreased production of children, the race will soon be over and the new economic policies in the cities will be of little use. Accordingly in 1980 the government began decollectivizing much of Chinese agricultural production.[148]

A few pages later, Wolf is even more direct:

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[147] Wang et al., "Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 955.
[148] *Ivi*, p.268.

> without *draconian measures*, overpopulation will destroy any hope of a better life for China's people.[149]

It is truly remarkable that an author like Wolf argues that the government still needs to take "draconian measures" to address the challenge of overpopulation, despite writing from a feminist and Western perspective, despite the One-Child Policy already being in effect for more than three years, and despite having directly witnessed cases of excess in its implementation. Judith Banister, whose studies would become a definitive reference in the field of Chinese demography, wrote in 1984:

> China's government will have to cope with continuing population growth for the rest of the decade, a great need for expansion in the number of jobs and productivity of work, and a contraction in the population of elementary school age. The increasing flexibility already demonstrated by the government in its handling of the economy since 1978 augurs well for its ability to deal constructively with these challenges.[150]

In 1983, the UNFPA even awarded its first United Nations Population Award to General Qian Xinzhong, the Chinese Minister of Family Planning.[151] In short, a unanimous chorus of approval from Western political and academic institutions greeted "the most coercive phase in the entire history of the One-Child Policy."[152]. Tyrene White, more than twenty years later, would therefore acknowledge that

> Since the late 1960s [...] many Western population experts had urged the use of all necessary measures to halt the rapid growth of global population, and a few went so far as to advocate the use of coercive and punitive ones. Although China publicly condemned this pessimistic, Malthusian view, it arrived at the same place by a different analytical and ideological pathway. When it declared rapid population growth a major threat to its modernization goals, therefore, and began to set strict targets for local and national growth rates, many

[149] *Ivi*, p.271. Il corsivo è nostro.
[150] Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.739.
[151] Wang et al., “Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 954.
[152] Connelly, *Fatal Misconception*, p.347.

> observers outside China applauded the move as a reasonable reaction to a grave and debilitating, even crippling, problem of "overpopulation."[153]

In light of the testimonies and the historical trajectory analyzed so far, even White's summary is questionable in suggesting that China actually followed a "distinct analytical and ideological path" that was truly "different" from the one that developed in the West starting with Malthus. Given that the sudden introduction of direct population containment policies occurred not only through the more "Westernizing" segment of the Chinese political elite but also with the more or less direct contribution of multiple Western actors, it is difficult to see how the One-Child Policy could genuinely be viewed as the result of an endogenous path, parallel and separate from the thought of Sanger or the Population Council. If anything, it is precisely the product of a radical and sudden reopening of China to those ideas.

After the end of the birth reduction campaign of 1983-84, there was once again a significant rebound in the second half of the 1980s, with the number of children per woman almost returning to 3 in 1987. A third and final, drastic mass campaign conducted between 1989 and 1993 pushed the rate down again, this time without it rising back up. The following chart illustrates the trajectory of the fertility rate in China during the years of the most restrictive implementation of the One-Child Policy (labeled as "Phase 1" in the following chart).

[153] White, *China's Longest Campaign.* , p.xii.

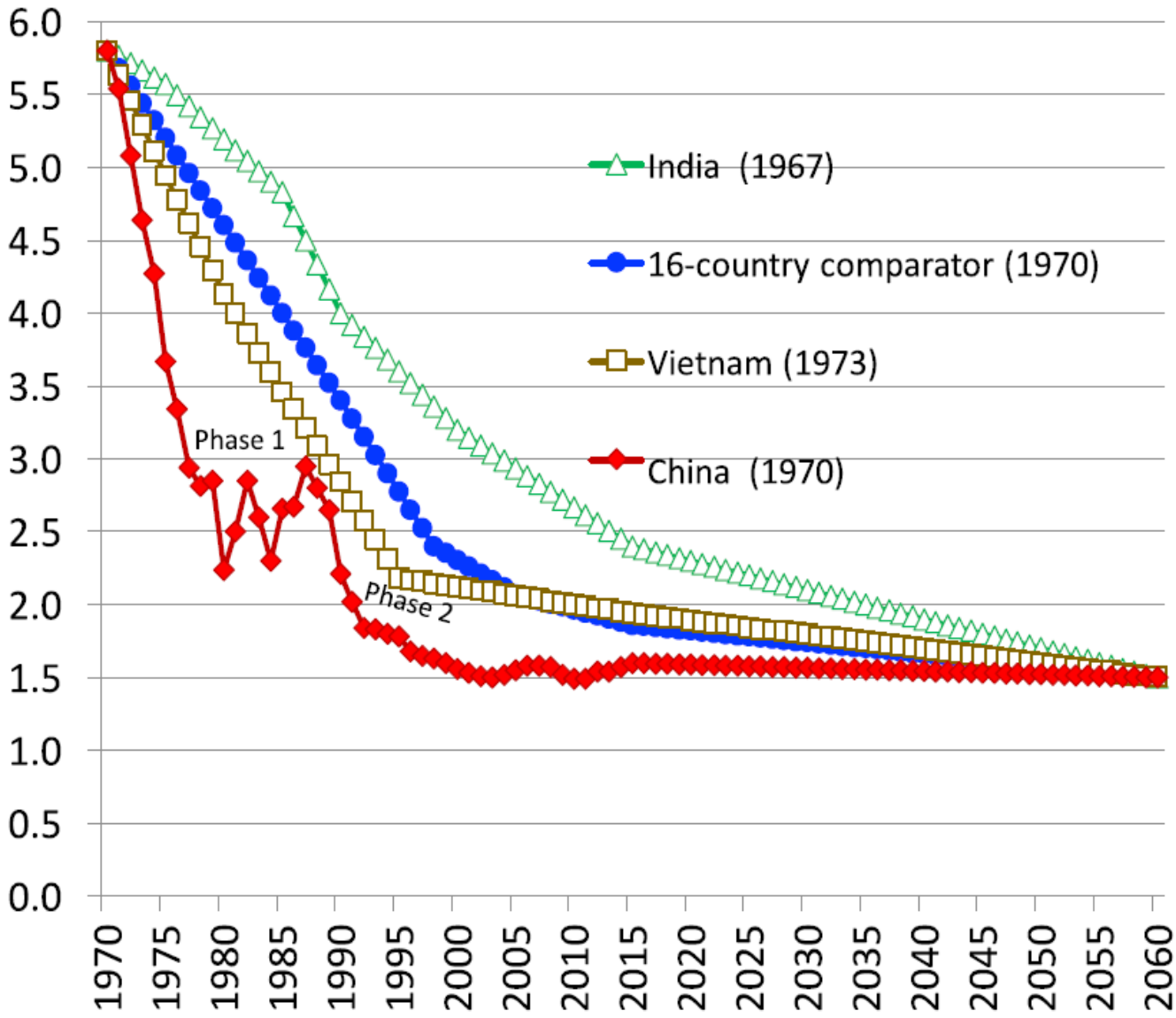

Fig.3.2 – Comparative birth rates projection, 1970-2060, produced by Daniel Goodkind; Cfr. Daniel Goodkind, "The Astonishing Population Averted by China's Birth Restrictions", p.1379

Despite the "rhetorical" distortions previously mentioned regarding graphs, in this case stemming from the somewhat arbitrary choice of the start and end dates, it is worth noting the irregular trend of the Chinese curve throughout the 1980s. However, if a more regular trend were applied to the curve, it would be apparent that, relative to this trend, the actual curve seems to show a net positive or even neutral impact on

the fertility rate in China during the implementation of the OCP. The debate regarding the effectiveness of the OCP will be revisited in Chapter 5, but for now, what is interesting to highlight is simply this *irregularity* in the trajectory. The steep declines in fertility correspond to two of the major mass campaigns launched in 1983 and 1989 respectively, while the rebounds observed in the fertility rate during 1981-82 and 1985-87 need to be explained. Among the identified reasons, we find the aforementioned reduction in the legal minimum age for marriage[154], but also the general regression of women's status due to the exclusive focus on economic growth: Indeed, in pursuing this singular objective, the division of productive and reproductive labor during this phase sees an explicit return to the primarily domestic role of women, a correlation that is universally recognized as being linked to high birth rates.

> Once again, under the radical new policies of the Four Modernizations, women are being told to step aside in the interests of the nation. Articles which appeared in the press on [International Women's Day, 1978] clarified the extent to which women's roles were being reevaluated in light of the new strategy for Chinese development. The theses were clear. Even though women were held up as "the other half of the sky," with important contributions to socialist construction, their release from "backbreaking manual labor and tedious housework" was to be gradual. In the meantime, a double burden was clearly stated. “Women workers, commune members and women scientists and technicians need to work hard and study, but they have to spend a considerable portion of their time tending to housework and children.”[155]

The rural population, which is simultaneously experiencing the onset of the "household responsibility" agricultural policy, is the most active in resisting the directives of the OCP, leading to a renewed appreciation of the economic importance

[154] Banister explains: “The late marriage age requirements of the 1970s were effective in raising China's mean age at first marriage, but they caused much dissatisfaction, particularly in cities where minimum marriage ages were extremely high and rigidly applied. The leadership decided to give way on this issue and adopted a new Marriage Law, effective 1 January 1981, that sharply dropped the minimum legal marriage ages to 20 years for women and 22 years for men in all Han Chinese areas. According to official figures, in the first six months of 1981 there were 6-73 million marriages nationwide, compared to 3-26 million in the same months of 1980. Because in China couples rarely practise family planning before the birth of their first child, the surge of marriages in 1981 and thereafter was followed by a surge of first births in late 1981 and throughout 1982 and 1983." Cfr. Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.728.

[155] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.26.

of having a large family.[156] More generally, Deng's reforms lead to an overall weakening of the social network that had previously enabled effective and widespread control at all levels[157], while increased agricultural productivity allows many families to offset the economic penalties associated with the OCP by increasing their earnings.[158] Internal migrations, also facilitated by the new Reform and Opening policies, make it more complicated to supervise and control the population.[159] Several other phenomena can be listed as possible contributing factors to what appears to be a relative failure of the "one-child policy" throughout the 1980s. These phenomena share a common characteristic: they are direct or indirect consequences of the state's *retreat* from the economic and social arenas, which is viewed positively by the international academic community. For many liberal scholars, the introduction of the OCP seems to be at odds with the rest of the reforms introduced by Deng: the personal freedoms gained in the socioeconomic sphere are seen as being in sharp contrast to invasive demographic policies that infringe upon fundamental human rights. However, if the OCP is interpreted as a preventive measure introduced by a leadership that fears a demographic explosion following the radical economic reforms it has implemented, both its coercive nature and its relative ineffectiveness compared to the Maoist policies become more understandable. Mao's rejection of Malthusian theories did not, as some might think, equate to the wholesale promotion of uncontrolled population growth: a *holistic* approach of a distinctly *political* nature had led to a buildup of factors that allowed China to achieve its demographic transition in record time during the 1970s. This approach worked as long as a thick and widespread network of relations between the State, the Party,

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[156] Margery Wolf explains: "As if the left hand did not know what the right was up to, the government has also begun a major economic reorganization of the commune system. Instead of the land being farmed by a production team under the direction of team leaders, families are working the land as individual units. The right to work a particular piece of land is more or less auctioned off, with the individual family allowed to keep as its profit whatever it makes over the bid. If the family does not meet the bid, it is in debt to the collective. Even some of the small brigade factories are being leased out, usually to a group of men who join together for that purpose only. The farmers grasp the situation and draw their own conclusion. They see that they are once again in economic control over their own destinies, and that the larger their family work force, the more prosperous that destiny will be. The consequence of their thinking is that the birth rate in some communes has already begun to climb precipitously." Cfr. Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.249.

[157] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.221-222; Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.725.

[158] Wong Siu-lun, "Consequences of China's New Population Policy", *The China Quarterly*, No. 98 (Jun., 1984), Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1984. p.227.

[159] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.93.

society, the community, and individuals was actively maintained. The centrist and Westernizing faction that came to power between 1976 and 1979, in order to "liberate productive forces," decisively moved towards the thinning of this network, and to try to contain the feared demographic side effects, resorted to *technocratic* and scientific analyses and measures, shifting the issue of reproduction from the political to the *regulatory-administrative* domain (which also explains Deng's emphasis on "rule of law"), and later resorted to mass campaigns to compensate for the disorganization of the OCP.[160]

However, some doubts can be raised about the validity of the Chinese leadership's fears of a demographic explosion following the introduction of the post-Mao economic reforms. Along with the decollectivization, many services and incentives for families were reduced under Deng's government; the cost of raising and educating children increased exponentially, with a long-term impact on family planning that is much more significant than the financial penalties associated with the OCP.[161] The movement of countless internal migrants from the countryside to the cities brought with it an urbanization of habits and mindset[162], and as we have seen, urban populations had already reached a fertility rate that made the OCP almost redundant even before its introduction. Almost all the factors that seem to have the potential to cause a resurgence in birth rates in China, upon closer examination—and with hindsight—actually present ambiguities in terms of demographic effects, to the extent that the return to relatively high fertility rates during the 1980s could largely be attributed to *the Chinese population's reaction to the OCP* itself. The ongoing debate about the real impact of the "one-child policy" will be revisited later. For now, however, we can draw some historical considerations:

1. During Mao Zedong's government, after two decades in which birth rates increased primarily due to the expansion of basic healthcare services, the fertility rate fell dramatically in the 1970s due to a combination of factors such as education and women's access to employment, despite the pro-natalist

[160] Susan Greenhalgh, *Just One Child – Science and Policy in Deng's China*, Berkeley (USA), University of California Press, 2008, p.xvii; Cfr. Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.107.
[161] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.221.
[162] *Ivi,* p.93.

rhetoric and economic incentives provided by the government to families.

2. The adoption of GDP per capita as an "absolute indicator" of the success of the post-Maoist government makes population size a variable that must be carefully monitored in every way.

3. The "retreat" of the state from the social, economic, and familial life of the Chinese under Deng Xiaoping instills in the country's leaders a fear of demographic explosion, leading to the adoption of a series of measures and campaigns summarized in the literature on the subject under the name of "One-Child Policy."

Throughout the 1980s, the OCP was characterized by alternating phases of strict enforcement and significant relaxations. Naturally, the periods when restrictive measures were intensified were also those in which the most glaring cases of abuse were reported. For example, following the poor results achieved by the birth-reduction policy in the early years, certified by the 1982 census, a campaign promoting sterilization for all couples under 40 who already had two children was launched in that same year. A few months later, the spread of stories and experiences of men and women forced into sterilization triggered a strong reaction, leading to a moderation of the campaign and the formal repudiation of its excesses in a Central Document published at the beginning of 1984.[163] The pressure exerted by the OCP on families lead to a resurgence of infanticide in rural areas, particularly of female infants. In this case as well, the authorities came under pressure from the media and the public:

> By the end of 1981 stories and finally editorials in China's newspapers were addressing a new problem, confirming rumors I had picked up earlier that year when interviewing in the countryside. Female infanticide was reappearing in rural China, in some areas with an alarming frequency. For example, the Anhui Provincial Women's Federation, which was sent to investigate persistent stories of female infanticide in Suixi and Huaiyuan counties, found that in Huaiyuan there were 16.4 percent more boys "born" than girls. A normal birth ratio

[163] Tyrene White, "Two Kinds of Production: The Evolution of China's Family Planning Policy in the 1980s", *Population and Development Review*, Vol. 20, Supplement: The New Politics of Population: Conflict and Consensus in Family Planning (1994), New York (USA), Population Council, 1994, p.145.

> would, of course, show 6 percent more boys than girls, so this leaves a startling 10 percent of the girls "missing." In some communes the discrepancy was even more dramatic, the highest being a 27 percent predominance of male births reported over female births reported. The investigators had no doubt about what had happened to the missing girls.[164]

During the Fifth National Women's Congress in September 1983, the influential leader of the All-China Women's Federation, Kang Keqing, depicts a rather grim situation:

> The feudal idea of regarding men as superior to women has reappeared, along with other prejudices. For instance, in some places, open and subtle discriminatory demands have been put forward in order to impose restrictions on the involvement of women in study and work and on the selection and promotion of women cadres. In production, labour protection for women has been ignored. Arranged marriages have encroached upon women's freedom to choose their husbands. What is most intolerable is that some ugly things which had been eliminated since the founding of New China have recurred. Crimes such as female infanticide, abuse of women, maltreatment of mothers who give birth to girl babies and abduction and persecution of women and children have been reported from time to time.[165]

Among the various phenomena that Kang denounces, some are closely linked to the new "one-child" demographic policy, particularly the ostracism against women who give birth to daughters and the infanticide of female infants. Several observers will come to argue that it is this policy that causes a "drastic gender imbalance in China.".[166] In reality, infanticide as a tool for sex selection has been a long-standing problem in China, tied to the strong preference for male children. For example, Pomeranz reports that during the period of the last imperial dynasty (Qing, 1636-1912):

> Life expectancies at birth seem low, in part because of very high rates of

[164] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.271.
[165] Cit.in *Ivi*, p.262.
[166] Wang et al., "Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p.962.

> infanticide — perhaps as many as 25 percent of female newborns were killed, with the rate peaking in the eighteenth century. Infanticide was widely used as a family planning device, and the unusually good records for this population make it possible to see just how widespread it was.[167]

Also Margery Wolf mentions that

> The birth of a daughter in traditional China was a disappointment; the birth of a second daughter brought grief and perhaps death to the infant; the birth of a third daughter was a tragedy for which the mother was most assuredly blamed. [...] An infant girl might be slipped into a bucket of water at birth; daughters could be sold into slavery at three or four years, or as prostitutes or concubines at twelve to fourteen years.[168]

The graph created by Lee and Wang helps to better visualize the extent of the phenomenon, which, as Pomeranz notes, reached its peak in the eighteenth century. We observe how, for eighty years spanning the late 1700s and early 1800s, the meticulous imperial census offices recorded more than 2.5 female infants dying during their first year of life for every male infant.

Fig.3.3 - Ratio of Female to Male Infant Mortality in China, England, France, and Sweden, 1700-1840; Source: James Lee, Wang Feng, "Malthusian Models and Chinese Realities: The Chinese Demographic System 1700-2000", *Population and Development Review*, Vol. 25, No. 1, New York (USA), Population Council, 1999, p.41

[167] Pomeranz, *The Great Divergence*, p.38.
[168] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.1-2.

It should be noted that during the most acute phase of imbalance, the ratio tended to reverse after the first year of age, which means that the higher mortality of females in the first year was more due to the reduced care received by female infants than to "active" infanticide. The higher survival rate afterward suggests a sort of "natural selection" of girls who were more resilient than average; however, the data remains equally significant. Gail Hershatter reports that

> decisions made by individual families—to drown a newborn daughter, to sell a girl child or a teenager—produced a noticeable aggregate effect in distressed areas. In Xuzhou prefecture in Jiangsu, for instance, the average ratio of men to women in 1874 was 129:100.[169]

Therefore, when more than a century later Kang Keqing denounces "crimes such as female infanticide," she rightly presents them not as a new phenomenon resulting from the "one-child" demographic policy, but rather as the reemergence of a centuries-old deviation produced by traditional patriarchal (or "feudal," as Kang describes it) culture.

Even so, doesn't the "one-child policy" significantly contribute to the resurgence of the strong preference for male children? At first glance, one might think so; however, Daniel Goodkind points out that the "one-and-a-half-child" rule introduced in 1984 —allowing families to have a second child if the first was a girl—actually served as a strong incentive to have a female first child, more so than a "universal two-child policy" advocated by the same critics of the OCP would have.[170] In any case, although infanticide is a shocking practice, it was not widespread in China during the 1980s, and at this stage, the gender imbalance increased by only 1%. It was in the early 1990s, with the introduction and spread of technologies to determine the sex of the fetus, that this imbalance rapidly expanded, no longer due to the now residual practice of infanticide but rather to the much more "modern" practice of sex-selective abortion. However, the OCP remains, in our opinion, a contingent factor rather than a determining one in the spread of this practice. Even in 2016, when the "one-child

[169] Hershatter, *Women and China's Revolutions,* p.39.
[170] Goodkind, "The claim that China's fertility restrictions...", p.268.

policy" had long been abolished, large-scale raids were still being conducted to dismantle the clandestine networks providing fetal sex screening services, which had been made illegal in China since 1994 precisely to combat sex-selective abortions.[171] Therefore, in light of the broader slowdown of the feminist cause in China during the years of Reform and Opening Up, we believe that the "main culprit" for the resurgence of infanticide and the spread of sex-selective abortion is not the OCP, but rather the more general process of depoliticization and liberalization introduced by a wider spectrum of Chinese policies during those years. This process allowed for the partial reassertion of the strongly patriarchal traditional culture that Mao had actively fought against. Pointing to the OCP as the cause of infanticide, sex-selective abortion, and the resulting gender imbalance in China is instrumental: it serves to place the responsibility for these phenomena on an "inexplicable," specific coercive measure, the "only blemish" on a broader economic and social program—Deng Xiaoping's—that was globally welcomed with great favor by the West. Recognizing the central role that the overall process of Reform and Opening Up plays in the regression of feminist struggles and women's condition risks undermining the widespread contemporary narrative of a China that only under Deng began to participate in the "human rights regime" and "modernize by formally repudiating the excesses of the Cultural Revolution."[172] In reality, it was only during the Maoist period that there was a substantial reduction in the historical gender imbalance, along with the only moment in modern Chinese history when more females than males were officially born, as indicated by the 1982 census data provided by Li Chengrui:

[171] "China arrests over illegal network determining baby gender", BBC, 15 Ottobre 2016, <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-37667917>, last consultation 03/05/2023.

[172] Ann Kent, *China, the United Nations, and Human Rights: The Limits of Compliance*, Philadelphia (USA), University of Pennsylvania Press, 1999, p.42.

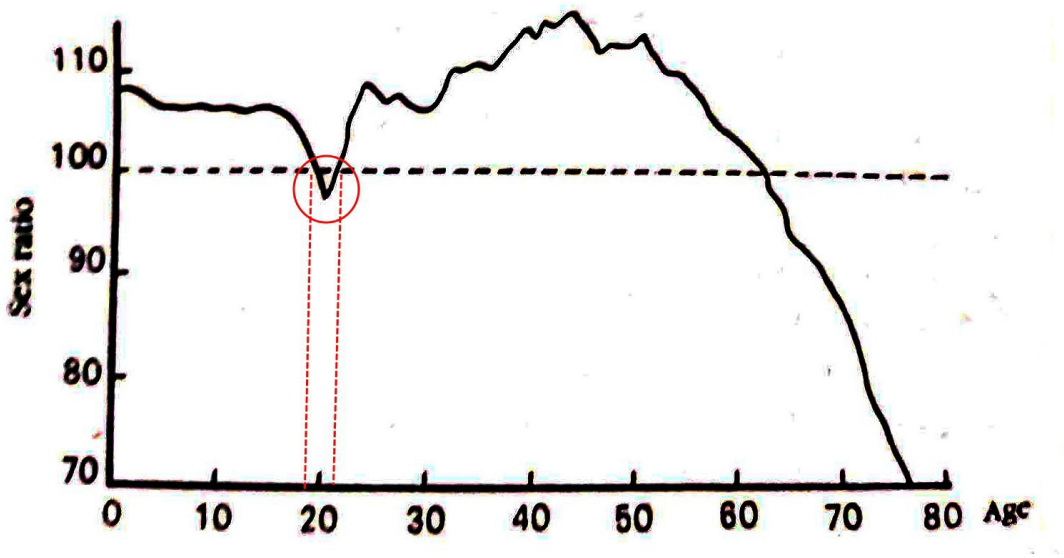

Fig.3.4 – **Gender Ratio by Age Recorded in the 1982 Census.** Only the generation born between 1961 and 1963 shows more females than males (the decrease in the male-to-female ratio among those over sixty is irrelevant to the argument, as it results from the naturally greater longevity of women). Source: Li Chengrui, *A Study of China's Population*, p.46

By highlighting these data, we do not intend to create a simplistic reversal of the more common historical judgment, presenting the Maoist era as a "golden age" for women's rights followed by a "nightmare" under Deng Xiaoping. However, we find it essential to problematize the widespread image of China under Mao Zedong as a time of only terror and oppression, and to view the opening of significant "individual freedoms" as occurring when the country embraced market dynamics. The history of women in New China since 1949 serves as clear evidence of the weakness of this narrative.

3.2- "Crossing the river by touching the stones": an ambivalent political demography from the top leadership to the local cadres

The forced birth reduction campaigns during the Deng era, legitimized by the general directive of "one child per woman," never lasted more than 12-18 months. During

these periods, internal opposition within the Party grew, supported by public dissent and media coverage, forcing the government to rebalance its approach and relax the strictness of its demographic policy. In summary, the overall picture presented in the 1980s is one of a policy that was simplistically conceived, and implemented in a fragmented and inconsistent manner. Some have viewed this as an example of Deng Xiaoping's "pragmatic method," known for the famous slogan "crossing the river by feeling the stones." However, this interpretation does not explain why, while such "pragmatism" achieves extraordinary results in the economic sphere, it somewhat fails in population control. In reality, as John Ross points out, Deng's approach to economic policies was certainly practical in terms of implementation but was also rooted in a deep theoretical reflection developed within China over the years, well illustrated in the writings of the Little Helmsman, which are often underestimated or completely ignored by Western academia. In works such as *We Are Undertaking a Completely New Enterprise* or *In Everything We Do We Must Proceed from the Realities of the Primary Stage of Socialism*, Deng synthesized a refined and original economic thought that, in its application, led to extraordinary results. In what Ross even describes as a "return to Marx," Deng created a departure from the forced collectivization inspired by the Soviet Union to return to the gradualism proposed by the German philosopher in the *Critique of the Gotha Program*. In this approach, after fully developing the productive forces, capitalism creates the conditions for its own transcendence.[173] Domenico Losurdo explains how the radical economic transformation imposed by Deng was far from being based on the principle of a laissez-faire approach hostile to long-term planning:

> The China that arose from the Cultural Revolution resembled the Soviet Union to an extraordinary degree in its last years of existence: the socialist principle of compensation based on the amount and quality of work delivered was substantially liquidated, and disaffection, disengagement, absenteeism and anarchy reigned in the workplace. Before being ousted from power, the “Gang of Four” attempted to justify the economic stagnation, debating the populist reason for a socialism that is poor but beautiful, the populist “socialism” that in the early years of Soviet Russia was dear to Pierre Pascal [...]

[173] John Ross, *China's Great Road. Lessons for Marxist Theory and Socialist Practices*, Glasgow (Scotland), Praxis Press, 2021, p.144.

> Then populism became the target of Deng Xiaoping's criticism. He called on the Marxists to realise "that poverty is not socialism, that socialism means eliminating poverty." He wanted one thing to be absolutely clear: "Unless you are developing the productive forces and raising people's living standards, you cannot say you are building socialism." No, "there can be no communism with pauperism, or socialism with pauperism. So to get rich is no sin" (Deng 1992–95, vol. 3, 122, 174). Deng Xiaoping had the historic merit of understanding that socialism had nothing to do with the more or less egalitarian distribution of poverty and privation. In the eyes of Marx and Engels, socialism was superior to capitalism not only because it ensured a more equitable distribution of resources but also, and especially, because it ensured a faster and more equal development of social wealth, and to achieve this goal, socialism stimulated competition by affirming and putting into practice the principle of remuneration according to the quantity and quality of work delivered. [174]

Ross ironically comments on the tendency to interpret the economic success of Deng's policies as the result of a policy conducted, so to speak, "by feel":

> it is sometimes argued that this success was merely due to "pragmatism" and achieved without overall economic theories, concepts, or a leadership really understanding the subject (particularly with no knowledge of US academic economics!). If true, then the study of economics should immediately be abandoned – if the greatest economic success in world history can be achieved without any understanding of the subject it is evidently of no practical value whatever.[175]

Thus, in the formula that yields China's per capita GDP indicator, the improvement in the economic data in the numerator was pursued with great attention and commitment, relying not only on experience from "capitalist" countries but also on the socioeconomic fundamentals of the Maoist period, thereby creating a "hybrid" economy that leveraged advantages from both models. Demographic policies, on the other hand, followed another path and achieved decidedly less impressive results

[174] Domenico Losurdo, "Has China Turned to Capitalism?—Reflections on the Transition from Capitalism to Socialism", *International Critical Thought*, 7:1, Milton Park (United Kingdom), Routledge, 2017, p.19.

[175] Ross, *China's Great Road*, p.141.

precisely because the key measure they were based on did not strike a balance between Chinese realities and social sciences imported from the West, clashing with the former and overestimating the state of the latter, particularly in the early stages of the OCP's development, when the so-called "international community" strongly supported the draconian measures prescribed by this policy. Thus, the economic goals of the Five-Year Plans during Deng's administration—the numerator in the per capita GDP formula—were all widely surpassed, while the demographic goals—the denominator—were never achieved. The result was still a wholly satisfactory outcome: at the end of his time at the head of the State, Deng's target of quadrupling per capita GDP by the year 2000 was now projected to be reached as early as the early 1990s[176], which provided new arguments for those within the Party advocating for a relaxation of the birth control policy.[177]

As we have seen earlier, the OCP never becomes law but remains merely a general guideline. One of the reasons for this is the strong opposition from many delegates to the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC), where proposals that do not gain sufficient broad support are blocked before they even reach the National People's Congress, the highest legislative body in China.[178] However, in addition to the explicit political opposition from representatives at the Congress and from the Maoist left, the control and implementation apparatus itself showed ambiguity at all levels. Several authors particularly highlight the role of local authorities, who often lacked the expertise to properly implement the directives and sometimes actively participated in manipulating data to avoid sanctions.[179] These authors give rise to a widely held interpretation of the OCP, depicting it as a program that enjoyed strong support among the high-ranking Chinese leadership but lost momentum as it extended to the lower levels of the state hierarchy. However, the fact

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[176] Wang Feng, Cai Yong, Gu Baochang, "Population, Policy, and Politics: How Will History Judge China's One-Child Policy?", *Population and Development review* Vol.38 (2012) (Supplement), New York (USA), Population Council, 2013, p.125.

[177] White, "Two Kinds of Production", p.149.

[178] In 1984, Wong Siu-lun reports that Qian Xinzhong, one of the proponents of the OCP, "still hopes to have the series of laws established within a year," despite the fact that "dissent at the lower levels of the political hierarchy [is] quite strong." As seen, Qian's hopes are not realized, and the OCP in its original formulation will never become law. Wong concludes that "the current demographic policy apparently encounters ideological, political, and ethical barriers.". Cfr.Wong, "Consequences of China's New Population Policy", p.224.

[179] Per un riassunto delle difficoltà pratiche che il programma incontra per mancanza di fondi e personale, cfr. *ivi*, p.204.

that at the level of communes and neighborhoods, the personnel responsible for birth control were structurally short of funds and man-hours also reveals an insufficient political will from above for the actual enforcement of the policy.

We can, in our view, legitimately doubt a unanimous and consistent belief among the top Chinese leaders regarding the declared goal of "one child per woman." Deng Xiaoping himself never publicly declared his support for any direct birth control policy[180], and upon closer examination, it becomes clear that the demographic policy remained divisive at the highest levels of government.

> the literature as a whole ignores the realities of elite conflict and political change in Beijing. Most analysts assume that the one-child policy emerged out of a leadership consensus; they therefore disregard the possibility that shifts in the composition of the central party and state organs could lead to modifications in the content or implementation of China's one-child policy[181]

Edwin Winckler identifies four leaders as the main supporters of a strict implementation of the OCP: Li Xiannian, Chen Yun, Hu Yaobang, and Li Peng. These are representatives of what Winckler calls the "Financial Tendency," a kind of "right wing" within the party that advocates for market opening and a neo-Malthusian approach to birth control.[182] Of these four, however, only the first appears to show no ambiguity.

Li Xiannian is one of the three main leaders of the post-Maoist transition led by Hua Guofeng. With Deng Xiaoping's rise to power, Li is tasked with setting the specific objectives for the demographic policy, and he is the one who officially declares for the first time in 1979 that China's population should be kept "below 1.2 billion" by the year 2000—an objective that, as we have seen, will fail. All of Li Xiannian's most radical public statements regarding the need to reduce fertility by any means are, in any case, prior to the letter that inaugurates the "one-child policy."

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[180] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.18.
[181] White, "Two Kinds of Production", p.139.
[182] Unless otherwise noted, the biographical passages about these four leaders in the following pages are summarized from Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, pp.99-101.

Chen Yun, the eldest and most prominent of the four, is presented by Winckler as "one of the main supporters of birth planning as an integral part of development policy." One of Chen's most significant political achievements is the reallocation of major public investments from heavy industry to agriculture and light industry. Therefore, Winckler hypothesizes that Chen's support for reducing births may stem from the concern that such investments could be entirely consumed by population growth. However, this hypothesis does not find explicit references in the work of the renowned communist leader. Moreover, in 1983, during the period of the most radical implementation of the birth reduction policy, Chen Yun is not involved in this effort; instead, he is found in the role of leading the "Campaign Against Spiritual Pollution"[183], a mobilization against Western influences in various areas of culture, from philosophy to fashion to eroticism. Chen Yun's priorities therefore do not seem to be focused on reducing fertility in the country, nor does his policy appear to align with the openness to Western thought, which at this stage is still the main inspiration and theoretical support for radical anti-natalists.

Regarding Hu Yaobang, Winckler himself admits that "it is not clear how ardently he was truly committed to achieving the goal of one child per woman"; he expresses some doubts from the beginning and appears open to introducing many exceptions to the rule. Li Peng, described by Winckler as "*relatively* uncompromising"[184], goes through phases where he supports uncompromising implementation, and others where he shows broad openness and even a willingness to introduce significant innovations, such as combining contraception promotion initiatives with efforts to combat poverty.

Meanwhile, starting in the mid-1980s, the analysis of the OCP in the international public debate begins to irreversibly complicate: one of the first to raise scientifically grounded criticisms of the negative effects of the post-Maoist demographic policies is the sociologist Wong Siu-lun from Hong Kong. Although Wong still considers Western concerns about the size of the Chinese population to be generally valid, he writes in 1984:

[183] Pico Iyer, "Battling 'Spiritual Pollution'", *Time Magazine*, 28 Novembre 1983, <https://web.archive.org/web/20081222021147/http://www.time.com/time/magazine/article/0,9171,926379,00.html>, last consultation 19/04/2023.

[184] The italic is ours.

> The bold initiatives in population policy have been launched in haste without either a sound empirical or theoretical foundation. Policy decisions have been made before systematic *tiaocha yanjiu* (investigations and research) have been carried out.
>
> Before the new turn in China's population policy, the official I orthodoxy had been that population growth was primarily a blessing. The emphasis then was on the assertion that men were essentially producers. Now the official view tends to take the opposite view of regarding population growth as mainly a liability for economic development and the present stress is on men as consumers. It is true that this new point of view accords with received world opinion nowadays. But the economic consequences of population growth are a matter of analysis and evidence and not of majority opinion. As far as I know, the issue is still a contentious one.[185]

Although Wong does not seem to fully endorse them, in his article he cites studies that present arguments against forced population reduction, highlighting their potential relevance to the Chinese case and calling for at least a more thorough investigation.[186] Between 1984 and 1986, the Chinese government was already shifting its demographic policy, even canceling the annual meeting on "birth control work" of 1984 and focusing the meetings of 1985 and 1986 on shifting attention from "quantity" to "quality.»[187] Meanwhile, the international *zeitgeist* had shifted: with the rise of the "hardline" stance represented by the Reagan and Thatcher governments, there was a renewed hostility towards the socialist bloc after years of *détente.* At the same time, environmental concerns temporarily lost their intensity, while both the feminist and anti-abortion movements evolved into increasingly critical positions—both from the "left" and the "right"—toward China's "one-child policy." From the mid-1980s onwards, stories, articles, and studies focusing on the most dramatic cases of "individuals suffering from the brutal implementation of the OCP" flourished. As even Western experts opposed to the policy would later

[185] Wong, "Consequences of China's New Population Policy", p.231-232. In the rest of the article, Wong voices concerns that at this stage are expressed by a minority within the Party and Chinese society, including worries about an aging population and the "character" of only children. These issues will become increasingly important to public opinion in the following decades, and therefore decisive in setting government priorities. See Wong, "Consequences of China's New Population Policy", p.235-236.

[186] *Ivi,* pp.232-233.

[187] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.116.

recognize, these often created inappropriate distortions.

> Clearly the stories Western journalists have told about China's population policy have been crafted to fit larger Western narratives about China. Similarly, the individual cases they have presented as emblematic were selected to fit those stories (cf. Madsen 1995; Weston and Jensen eds. 2000). Thus, in the mid-1980s, the dominant news story in theWest was of a coercive totalitarian regime, the cases of journalistic interest those of individuals suffering from the brutal enforcement of the one-child policy.[188]

The turbulent months leading up to the collapse of the Soviet bloc were also those in which Deng's China experienced its last major mass campaign aimed solely at the quantitative reduction of births; the significant changes that had meanwhile transformed the country brought with them new challenges.

By the end of the 1980s and the early 1990s, it was increasingly clear that the original goal set at the inception of the OCP would not be achieved: by the year 2000, the Chinese population would undoubtedly exceed the target of 1.2 billion. Taking advantage of this, the internal factions within the Party more hostile to birth reduction gradually succeeded in raising this target to 1.3 billion during this period.[189] In response to the latest rebound in births that began around 1985, the last major campaign of direct fertility control took place during these years. Its results varied depending on the areas and the level of actual control exercised by the central government: where local officials were not subject to rigorous checks, collusion between them and the population tended to occur to conceal excess births. Zhang Weiguo, a sociologist at the University of Toronto, conducted field research in several villages in Hebei during this period, finding that in these rural areas, "the role of local officials with respect to peasant families is weakened" and that "the implementation of state family planning work is increasingly mediated both by the families and by the local authorities."[190] Zhang specifically notes that in some cases, local administrators encouraged births beyond the quota to supplement the village or

[188] *Ivi*, p.12.
[189] *Ivi*, p.96.
[190] Zhang Weiguo, "Economic Reforms and Fertility Behaviour in Rural China: An Anthropological and Demographic Inquiry", *European Journal of Population*, Vol. 15, No. 4 (Dec., 1999), Berlin (Germany), Springer, 1999, p.328.

municipal budget with revenue from fines imposed by the OCP. Generally, the contradictions between the heterogeneous regulations that made up the policy and the scarce resources allocated at the local level created a situation that led to a significant degree of negotiation:

> With no effective means to press villagers to comply with the formal family planning regulation, which requires for late marriage, late child birth, and longer birth intervals when the birth of a second child is permitted, local cadres implement a modified local policy. Cadres mostly do not interfere on timing of marriage, timing of giving birth of the first child, contraception before birth of second child, and they allow the birth of a second child. Some couples even try to have the third or fourth child when they have only girls, which is prohibited by formal family planning regulations. Local cadres replace the state formal policies to informal rules and norms, because of their incapacity to control of reproductive behaviour of individual couples. It is also a bargaining strategy adopted by cadres. Cadres allow reproductive couples to marry earlier, to have children earlier, and to have two children without enlarging birth intervals. Couples, in turn, should not have further births, or they should co-operate to submit their fine, or have abortion or sterilisation.[191]

However, in some areas where fertility remained high, local officials, in their attempt to meet campaign goals, resorted once again to abuses, which in some cases provoked violent reactions from the population:

> where state authority was uncertain and fertility high, local officials instituted brutally coercive campaigns—involving beating husbands, confiscating property, and demolishing houses—that drove people to violent extremes. In one Henan village, a peasant whose neighbor had informed local officials about his wife's fourth pregnancy crippled the neighbor's wife and young child before beating the man to death. In a Yunnan township, a compulsory sterilization campaign provoked collective protests that injured bodies, upended lives, and destroyed local government institutions.[192]

[191] Zhang Weiguo, "Economic Reforms and Fertility Behaviour in Rural China", p.329.
[192] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.225.

Academia and international media, often puzzled by the supposed inconsistency between "economic liberalization" and the "social engineering practices" of the Deng era, sometimes presented the new restrictive phase of the OCP as a response to the events of Tiananmen Square. However, they failed to establish any direct connection between the two.[193] In any case, in terms of large numbers, following the campaigns of 1988-93, China's fertility rate officially stabilized around 1.8-1.9 children per woman, a level that no longer required particularly severe measures to control demographic expansion. However, this data likely suffered from significant reliability issues: over the years, the streamlining of the state control apparatus and the development of increasingly effective forms of resistance by the population had compromised the quality of censuses, especially due to the widespread practice of concealing "out-of-quota" births and infant deaths. Maria Giovanna Merli, following her field studies in the Ciqixian district of Shandong, explains:

> Births closely followed by an infant death and births unauthorized by the family planning programme may be left out from all statistical reports. This has to do with a synergistic process of omission that finds village workers, data collectors and parents in agreement, as the definition of a reportable birth is induced by the statistical-administrative apparatus, a product of the village-level negotiations between local cadres and rural couples striving to adjust to the strictures of the family planning programme.[194]

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[193] Huang, Yang, "Population Control and State Coercion in China", p.217, write "Amid the diplomatic freeze that greeted China, General Secretary Jiang Zemin argued that China's economic independence rested on controlling population growth and called for doing 'a good job in family planning by all means' (JKB, October 17, 1989). As a result of the central leadership's push, implementation of birth planning policies was more vigorous in the early 1990s." However, no clear link is established between the "diplomatic freeze" and the birth reduction campaign, especially since the campaign began before the Tiananmen Square events, with its early signs being expressed by government bodies as early as late 1988. See Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.125.

[194] M.Giovanna Merli, "Underreporting of Births and Infant Deaths in Rural China: Evidence from Field Research in One County of Northern China", *The China Quarterly*, Vol.155, Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1998, p.651; Other studies reach the same conclusions as Merli: a group of Chinese researchers in 1993 found inconsistencies in the sex ratio by age, noting that certain gaps in the registration system allowed parents to more easily omit the registration of children under the age of three. When these children reached a certain age, many were subsequently registered, and since they were predominantly female, this resulted in a significant correction of the sex ratio. See Zeng Yi, Tu Ping, Gu Baochang, Xu Yi, Li Baohua, Li Yongping. "Causes and implications of the recent increase in the reported sex ratio at birth in China," *Population and Development Review* 19,2 (June 1993), pp. 283 –302.

Merli points out that the infant mortality data for Ciqixian was significantly too low compared to the average of regions with similar conditions, and that the sex ratio of second children is excessively skewed towards males. Consequently, the birth rate data was now tainted by a systematic underestimation related to the removal from the records of all births followed by the child's death, and the non-registration of many second children, particularly females. As a result, the fertility rate for the 1990-1995 period can be realistically estimated at just above 2.[195] In any case, the Eighth Five-Year Plan concluded in 1995 having officially achieved—and even exceeded—for the first time the set demographic targets.[196]

3.3- Jiang Zemin and the reform of the "one-child policy"

During the last mass campaign carried out between the late 1980s and early 1990s, reports of abuse and corruption related to the OCP had multiplied, so in 1993, the task of monitoring and reporting coercive and illegal practices was officially entrusted to family planning associations.[197] Thus starting from the mid-1990s, under the leadership of Jiang Zemin, China's demographic policy began to reform, moving towards reduced direct control and greater attention to the deviations produced by the OCP:

> In the middle 1990s the Jiang era began with a phase of controlled consolidation: state-centric reforms to correct program maladministration, to professionalize birth work, and to improve positive incentives for citizen compliance. However, unlike the middle Deng period, that quasi-consolidation did not involve inadvertent relaxation of enforcement. In the late 1990s, if therewas renewed "advance," it was not toward reintensification of hard birth planning but towards increasing reform of it.[198]

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[195] Penny Kane, Choi Ching Y., "China's one child family policy", *The BMJ* (formerly *The British Medical Journal*), London (United Kingdom), British Medical Association, 1999, p.993.

[196] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.96; Another factor contributing to the deterioration in the quality of policy implementation and data collection is the growth of corruption. Winckler explains: "the program also suffered a rising tide of misdirection and misappropriation of funds. At best, local governments used birth planning revenues to fund general expenses; at worst, local cadres used birth revenues to fund their personal consumption"; See *Ivi,* p.128.

[197] Kane, Choi, "China's one child family policy", p.994.

[198] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.131.

In 1995, a comprehensive Law on Maternal and Child Care came into effect, which no longer emphasized family planning based on quantitative measures, but rather focused on the prevention and termination of pregnancies in cases of high risk of genetic diseases (as also stipulated by the Marriage Law). This law officially codified the prohibition of determining the sex of the fetus, a practice that had already been discouraged through regulations published since the end of the previous decade.[199] With the development of technology and the increasingly widespread access to abortion services, the practice of infanticide in China had almost disappeared, replaced, as we have seen, by the exponential increase in selective abortions.[200] In the decade spanning the 1990s and 2000s, the controversial issue of sex selection of fetuses stirred Chinese society, while prevailing habits regarding the ideal family size had already begun to render the OCP obsolete, which was itself subjected to increasingly broad reforms and exceptions.

Another phenomenon that gained new attention in public discourse in China during this period was the illegal trafficking of children, often involving female infants. With the relaxation of the one-child policy, the traditional ideal of a family with two children—a boy and a girl—quickly reasserted itself among the urban population. In families seeking their first child, the preference for a male child tended to disappear, with some studies even showing a preference for a daughter. Conversely, in rural areas, where the fertility rate was high enough for the OCP to still pressure families to reduce the number of children, the preference for male children remained strong ;[201] This led to the creation of a black market through which 'excess' girls were transferred from rural areas to the cities.[202] The spread of commercial mass media tended to fuel heated debates, often exaggerating the extent of such phenomena, and came into direct conflict with institutional and party information organs. This conflict extended across the entire field of reproductive and gender issues, with top-down promotion of a model of a 'strong woman'—politically active and competing with

[199] See LAW OF THE PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF CHINA ON MATERNAL AND INFANT HEALTH CARE (Adopted at the Tenth Meeting of the Standing Committee of the Eighth National People's Congress on October 27, 1994 and promulgated by Order No.33 of the President of the People's Republic of China on October 27, 1994).

[200] See pp.78-80.

[201] Zhou Chi, Zhou Xu Dong, Wang Xiao Lei, Zheng Wei Jun, Li Lu, Therese Hesketh, "Changing Gender Preference in China Today: Implications for the Sex Ratio", *Indian Journal of Gender Studies*, 20(1), New Delhi (India), SAGE Publications, 2013, p.58.

[202] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.226.

men in education and work—contrasted by the marketing industry's portrayal of a woman dedicated to her appearance, home, and children.[203] All this contributed to rapid social and cultural changes, with the general tendency of urban populations to adopt lifestyles and family planning choices increasingly similar to those of more economically developed countries, while simultaneously 'Sinicizing' these models. In this context, birth control policy became less central in public debate and in the policy-making processes of ministries dealing with social, educational, health, and family issues.

The decline in the importance of the OCP was also due to the fact that, although the initial goal of keeping the population below 1.2 billion by the year 2000 had been abandoned, the exponential economic growth experienced during the 1980-2000 period more than compensated for the failure of demographic control measures. The per capita GDP was entirely satisfactory from a purely statistical standpoint, and agricultural productivity and trade had reached levels that would generally ensure food security, thereby reducing the need to forcefully lower a birth rate that at this point was comparable to that of much wealthier countries. The real issue turned out to be not so much the production of sufficient resources, but their equitable distribution; in 1995, Vaclav Smil wrote:

> In large cities banqueting among the newly rich entrepreneurs, bureaucrats and army men has reached often obscene proportions. Yet in 1994 at least 12 million urban residents lived in desperate poverty: in spite of spending two-thirds of their income on food, their diets were still inadequate and they were malnourished. Totals of malnourished people are much larger in rural areas: China's poorest provinces still struggle to assure the reliability of an adequate supply of staple carbohydrates.
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> [...]
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> in 1993 researchers of the Chinese Academy of Agricultural Sciences wrote that "there are still 87 million people in China who have difficulties getting warm clothes and enough to eat, and in some places the grain shortage is quite conspicuous."[204]

[203] Stanley Rosen, “Chinese women in the 1990s: Images and roles in contention,” in Maurice Brosseau and Lo Chu Ken (eds.), *China Review,* 1991. Hong Kong, Chinese University of Hong Kong, pp. 17.1–17.28.

[204] Smil, "Who Will Feed China?", p.807.

It thus became evident to the government that merely controlling the population and opening up to market dynamics were not sufficient to fully achieve the shared wealth aspirations stimulated by the advent of the Reform and Opening Up period. Therefore, the convergence between the relaxation of regulations and Chinese families' aspirations regarding the number of children eased the social tensions related to the OCP, while other new issues stirred the grassroots support on which the Party relied for the stability of its government. Winckler summarizes the profound transition occurring in the mid-1990s as follows:

> Overall, the entire concept of the birth program began to shift from direct control to indirect regulation: from "birth according to plan" to "birth according to law." Thus the most fundamental change was in the plan, which shifted from mandatory toward indicative. Instead of imposing a schedule on which communities and their couples were allowed to have births, planning increasingly became policy analysis for the government to use in allocating its own resources: projections of likely demographic outcomes, analyses of related social problems, and proposals for solving them.
>
> [...]
>
> During the middle 1990s a main program objective was to make "crash" enforcement campaigns unnecessary by building adequate routine administrative capacity and by requiring adequate routine implementation work. Crash campaigns were still conspicuous in the early 1990s, particularly in the most populous agricultural provinces that the program targeted at that time. [...] In 1995 program leaders declared crash campaigns impermissible and established targets for phasing them out by the end of the century: in 16 provinces by the end of 1998, 21 provinces by the end of 1999, and all 31 provinces by the end of 2000. At the turn of the millennium national leaders declared that effort "basically" successful.[205]

Demographic policy was thus gradually integrated into the broader program of rural poverty alleviation. It remained closely tied to the economy; however, with the increasing complexity of Chinese analysis and policies in the field, which were no longer solely focused on quantitative development but increasingly concerned with

[205] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.132-141.

the *quality* of growth, the study and intervention on population dynamics also became more comprehensive. This shift was marked by the adoption of a new slogan, the *San Jiehe*, literally 'Three Connections,' or 'Three Integrations': family planning was now conceived as inseparable from the development of village agricultural economy, the support for improving citizens' housing and nutritional standards, and the construction of 'happy and civilized' families—referring to access to education and basic services. The Three Integrations policy was officially launched in 1995 and was the subject of a special conference. Edwin Winckler summarizes the content of Jiang Zemin's speech delivered during the meeting as follows:

> progress require[s] coordinated development, aimed at villages, particularly women. The birth program must be linked to other, "collateral" government programs. Previously the birth program had collaborated with other government departments, such as health (for maternal and child health services), science and technology (for contraceptive research), pharmaceuticals (for contraceptive production), civil affairs (for marriage work), and public security (for household registration information). Now the birth program must collaborate also with departments such as agriculture, banking, and commerce — and they in turn must collaborate with the birth program.[206]

According to Winckler, with the Three Integrations policy, the Jiang government hoped

> [...] that linking social reproduction to economic production would make stand-alone negative birth limitation less unpalatable to the general population by connecting it to the delivery of what citizens would regard as more positive services—particularly reproductive health but also poverty alleviation.[207]

During the same conference, Peng Peiyun, a veteran Party activist, Minister responsible for the family planning program, and recently promoted to a member of

[206] *Ivi*, p.143
[207] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.143.

the State Council[208], explicitly linked the new strategy to the need to 'avoid the heavy collateral burden' of previous policies.[209] The 1990s thus represent a phase of significant reorientation towards a strategy aimed at eliminating the very need for the OCP, with an expansion of healthcare services and, above all, a rapid and increasingly widespread dissemination of diverse and less invasive contraceptive methods. Between the beginning and end of the decade, abortions are reduced by two-thirds, reaching a minimum of interrupted pregnancies among married women of less than 2% by the year 2000.[210]

Although the pressure to relax the more restrictive demographic policies primarily comes from within, the 1990s are also a period in which China strengthens its participation in global multilateral institutions, thereby confronting foreign criticisms more directly. In the previous decade, China had already joined seven important human rights treaties (including the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women), but a possibly even more significant development was the negotiations that led to China obtaining 'Most Favored Nation' status in trade relations with the USA, achieved in 1994. At that time, Bill Clinton decided to separate the recognition of this status from the US assessment of 'human rights protection' in China, not without controversy. Between the late 1980s and early 1990s, the tone of Western criticism against many of China's policies, including, of course, the OCP, had indeed intensified. These are indeed the years when perhaps the most evident contradictions arise regarding the support previously given by the West to drastic birth reduction in China, not only in the media but also in academic circles. China is placed in a paradoxical position when its radical demographic policies are judged both insufficient and excessive. In a telling shift, John S. Aird, an author who has studied Chinese demographic policies since the Maoist era, had written in 1962: 'The failure of Communist China to control population growth [...] will have an incalculable impact on the global political stage.'[211]; Sixteen years later, in 1978, while acknowledging that the Chinese government's efforts had produced results he

[208] Composed of 35 members, the State Council, centered around the figure of the Premier, is the highest *state* authority in China; like all other government institutions, it has a corresponding *party* body, the Politburo.

[209] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.144.

[210] Huang, Yang, "Population Control and State Coercion in China", p.219.

[211] John S. Aird, "Population policy in Mainland China", *Population Studies: A Journal of Demography*, 16:1, 1962, p.57.

had not anticipated, Aird still emphasized as a risk the fact that 'many of those who now support [the birth reduction policy] have probably not adopted the new values and might be ready to revert to traditional behaviors at the next political upheaval.'[212]; Finally, after another 12 years, in 1990, Aird published a work whose title itself is indicative of the evolution of his discourse on the issue: *Slaughter of the Innocents: Coercive Birth Control in China*. The book draws a direct connection between the Herodian massacre of infants described in the Gospels and China's 'one-child policy.[213] From the demographic nightmare, through concerns about sustainability, to the accusation of mass infanticide, there is a complete reversal from the initial positions. It was in this context that Jiang Zemin, if only for pragmatic reasons, clearly responded to the demands of the USA for a reform of its policies, at least in areas that did not directly challenge the political and institutional structure of the People's Republic. However, the reform of the OCP towards a strong moderation was not universally welcomed in the West, as, in the meantime, the 'catastrophic' projections regarding the sustainability of demographic growth in the 1990s resurfaced. The most emblematic work in this regard is *Who Will Feed China?* by Lester Brown, published in 1995. Brown revived the specters of an 'Asia [that] has many more people per arable hectare than Europe,' and despite being the only Asian country to have implemented such a radical policy as the OCP, China still 'faces unique and complex demographic problems' due to the 'lack of a migratory escape valve,' 'scarcity of arable land,' and 'exceeding the carrying capacity'.[214] This work completes a 'transfiguration'—in our view, only superficial—of concerns about the size of the Chinese population: from an apocalyptic, Spenglerian perspective, which was supported by early 20th-century defenders of the 'white race,' it now presents itself as a question of pure ecological sustainability. Some demographers critical of the OCP, losing sight of the racist genealogy of the 'demographic nightmare,' will end up arguing that 'the origins of the one-child policy are rooted in Western environmentalism».[215]

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[212] John S. Aird, "Fertility Decline and Birth Control in the People's Republic of China.", *Population and Development Review* Vol.4 No.2 (1978), New York (USA), Population Council, 1978, p.246.

[213] John S. Aird, *Slaughter of the Innocents: Coercive Birth Control in China*, Washington DC (USA), AEI, 1990, p.3.

[214] Lester R. Brown, *Who will feed China? Wake-up call for a Small Planet*, New York (USA), W. W. Norton & Company, 1995, pp.36-52.

[215] Wang et al., "Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 958.

In the renewed debate characterized by this extremism of positions and rhetoric, Vaclav Smil intervened in 1995, writing a review of Brown's work:

> I believe it is as counterproductive to gather more support for such bleak outlooks as it is to dismiss any concerns about future performance by pointing to the successes of the recent past. I have argued repeatedly against joining the debates about the future of modern civilization in general, and about China's capacities in particular, from extreme positions defined either by unreconstructed catastrophists or by unreflective cornucopians. Instead, I would like to encourage both a broader and a deeper interdisciplinary research in the vital question of China's food production capacity whose only prerequisite must be a sine ira et studio approach.
>
> Such inquiries would benefit from paying careful attention to three kinds of surprisingly neglected realities. The first is the need to recognize scholars' ignorance of many critical variables. Secondly, it is necessary to acknowledge the complexity of the existing situation and strive to provide representative accounts instead of focusing on meaningless means or on captivating, but extreme, examples. Finally, the enormous potential for higher efficiencies in China's farming cannot be ignored.[216]

Noting that China was already relaxing the more restrictive measures of its demographic policy, the Czech scholar offered a balanced view, which simultaneously aimed to discourage a return to coercive birth reduction while maintaining a perspective that addressed the issues of food and ecological sustainability:

> During the 1980s the Chinese felt reasonably confident that they would be able to keep the total below 1.2 billion; by the early 1990s they conceded 1.25 billion; the real figure will be just over 1.3 billion. [...] Even with per capita consumption frozen at the early-1990s level these totals would require a 23 per cent increase in grain harvests by 2010, and a 40 per cent rise by 2025.[217]

[216] Smil, "Who Will Feed China?", pp.804-805.
[217] *Ivi*, p,807

In 1995, the Chinese government published its first White Paper on the state of human rights in the country, and it is noteworthy that the chosen theme for this first issue was precisely Family Planning[218]. Following this, several reforms were enacted in the second half of the decade that directly or indirectly impacted the birth control program, collected under the new slogan '*yiren weizhu*'—'putting people first.' The global public discourse on overpopulation had meanwhile changed, and China could not ignore this, as explained by Winckler and Greenhalgh:

> The international population regime had recently changed paradigms, from top-down government control of population growth to bottom-up empowerment of women to manage their own fertility. The PRC birth program quickly absorbed and adapted many of these new ideas, which revived and reinforced its own early maternal and child health objectives.[219]

The 2000 census marked the definitive failure of the original OCP goal set in 1980, with a population reaching 1.26 billion.[220] Nonetheless, the 'double only-child' reform was introduced in the same year, allowing all couples where both spouses were only children to have two children, regardless of the limits in place in their district.[221] This was the first of a series of reforms that, over the course of fifteen years, would have gradually led to the definitive abolition of the 'one-child policy'.

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[218] Chen Dingding, "China's Participation in the International Human Rights Regime", *Chinese Journal of International Politics*, Oxford (United Kingdom), Oxford University Press, Vol.2, 2009 , pp. 401, 403.

[219] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.401.

[220] Wang et al., ""Population, Policy, and Politics", p.125.

[221] Wang Zhihe, Yang Ming, Zhang Jiaming, Chang Jiang, "Ending an Era of Population Control in China: Was the One-Child Policy Ever Needed?", *The American Journal of Economics and Sociology*, Vol. 75, No. 4 (September 2016), Hoboken (USA), Wiley, 2016, p. 930.

CHAPTER 4

REJUVENATE THE NATION. CHINESE POLITICAL DEMOGRAPHY IN THE 21st CENTURY

In 1949, at the dawn of the People's Republic, Mao Zedong had declared that 'under the government of the People, it will take only a few years to completely solve this problem of providing employment, or rather feeding the entire population, both in the North and the Northeast as well as in the rest of the country.'[222] In the fifty years that followed, the paradigm adopted to achieve Mao's ambitious goal underwent two fundamentally different phases: as we have seen, the first phase, under the leadership of the Great Helmsman, relied on a *holistic, anti-Western,* and *political* interpretation of the country's socioeconomic problems. It used mobilization campaigns as the primary tool, where the Leader and the masses exerted at the same time a top-down and a bottom-up pressure on the intermediate bodies of Chinese society; The second phase, primarily championed by Deng Xiaoping, gave absolute priority to the 'development of productive forces' and abruptly reversed the previous course by adopting a *specialized*, *Westernizing*, and *regulatory-administrative* vision. It introduced targeted quantitative indicators to measure progress and a top-down system for disseminating and applying new ad hoc regulations aimed at improving these indicators. In the latter part of Jiang Zemin's period and under Hu Jintao's government (2003-2013), this approach was reformed; however, it was not a radical change but rather a general 'softening' of its most controversial aspects, including, of course, demographic policy. Despite the unprecedented economic and social development of China since 1949, Mao's prediction of 'a few years' proved to be quite unrealistic as the new millennium began. In 2000, there were still nearly 100 million Chinese living in absolute poverty according to the government's own

[222] Mao Zedong, *Selected Works*, vol. IV, Beijing (RPC), Foreign Languages Press, 1961, p.453.

indicators. The leadership had come to understand that quantitative development indicators alone were insufficient to address the complex socioeconomic problems of the poorest and most isolated segments of the population, and that applying purely restrictive measures risked being counterproductive when material development conditions did not align with established cultural and social norms. Let us examine the main continuities and the most significant changes occurring in this most recent period compared to the phases discussed in the previous chapters.

4.1- Hu Jintao's gradualism e the OCP's obsolescence

To stabilize demographic policies, a transition was first initiated from a *regulatory-administrative* approach to a *legal* one: the OCP had not previously been clearly established in the form of law but had always been implemented based on administrative directives. A 2001 law, while not including specific regulations on the number of children, for the first time incorporated the institutions responsible for birth planning into the Chinese legal code. It simultaneously set important limits on their actions and focused the punitive measures much more on abuses and mismanagement rather than on violations of the child limits:

> Some of the progressive changes that the law introduced were intended to reduce abuses, increase incentives, and foster women's development. Officials "should conduct administration strictly in accordance with the law, should enforce the law in a civilized manner, and must not infringe upon citizens' legal rights and interests" (Article 4). The law contained punishments for maladministration (Articles 36 to 39) and provision for citizens to appeal decisions or sue administrators (Article 44, as authorized by other laws). Chapter 4 of the law authorized rewards and other preferential treatment for compliance (Articles 23 through 28) but left arrangements and funding to local government and employers (Articles 27 and 29). As for women, birth planning should be linked to their education and employment and to improving their health and raising their status (Article 3). Implementation should include measures to strengthen maternal and child health care (Article 11). There must be no discrimination against female children and their mothers (Article 22), and sex selection of children through ultrasound and abortion was strictly prohibited.[223]

[223] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.159.

Although the overall vision gradually shifted towards a more *qualitative* measure of the country's development, it still remained tied to a technocratic conception that prioritized achieving *quantifiable* objectives. This included increasingly more data that had not previously been given much weight and gradually aligning them with those adopted by major international institutions. Thus, this phase remained strongly influenced by the West, whose impact extended both in the scientific field and in popular culture.[224] The insistence on scientific objectivity as the primary basis for legitimizing political choices is evident in Hu Jintao's main contribution to the theoretical framework of the Chinese Communist Party, the theory of the 'scientific outlook on development.' If Chinese demographic policies were relaxed during this period, it was not because the leadership had rejected 'technocratic' conceptions in favor of a more 'principled' vision. The fundamental justification for the measures taken remained pragmatically anchored in 'science,' but in the meantime, science had evolved.

Also changed were the habits and mindset of the Chinese population, including those related to family planning. Various field surveys revealed deep transformations in the aspirations of families and women:

> The evidence [...] suggests that the populace, especially those living in urban areas and in areas of strong policy enforcement, are slowly accommodating to the national reproductive policies. Individual family size preferences are coming closer to those of the state. China's One-Child-Policy is increasingly obsolete [...].

In her 2006 study, Maria Giovanna Merli emphasizes, however, that there are no signs that the government intends to abolish or radically modify the birth regulations:

> Yet the state still holds firm the rules of population control, investing the political resources necessary to ensure local implementation of national birth planning policies […]
>
> The government continues to set mechanistic demographic targets which forbid any change in the One-Child policy until 2020.[225]

[224] *Ivi*, p.158.

[225] Maria Giovanna Merli, "The Past, Present and Future of China's Birth Planning Policy", *Il Politico*, Settembre-Dicembre 2006, Vol. 71, No. 3 (213), Pavia (Italy), Rubbettino Editore, 2007, p.105; Greenhalgh and Winckler cite numerous other studies confirming Merli's findings:

Ideal number of children	China (%)	Rural (%)	Urban (%)
0	1.1	0.4	3.2
1	35.8	30.1	52.4
2	57.2	62.1	43.1
3+	5.9	7.5	1.4
Mean	1.70	1.79	1.43

PERCENTAGE NAMING ONE CHILD AS IDEAL, BY AGE

Age	China	Rural	Urban
15–19	50.1	47.0	60.1
20–24	51.9	48.7	61.4
25–29	41.7	35.4	60.8
30–34	33.1	27.0	51.2
35–39	29.8	23.2	48.7
40–44	29.1	20.2	50.0
45–49	24.7	19.8	40.3
All groups	35.8	30.1	52.4

Fig. 4.1 – Preferences regarding the ideal number of children in China, 2001; Source: survey of a sample of 39,140 women aged 15 to 49 in Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.228

The difficulties in pursuing the birth limitation policy no longer stemmed from population resistance; the real problem became the economic maintenance of the extensive control apparatus necessary for implementing the policy, given the exponential reduction in revenue from fines for 'excess children.' Meanwhile, costs had also increased due to the investment in diversifying methods and enhancing technologies. The financial pressure was thus shifted to local government budgets, which either incurred debt or passed this burden onto businesses and individuals through taxes.[226]

"Despite some difficulties interpreting answers to questions about familyideals in the context of a strong family size policy, both the consistency of the finding across surveys conducted around the same time and the size of the changes over time suggest that a real decline in family size preferences has been underway since the early 1990s, evident in all but the poorest areas of the country (Feng and Zheng 2002). Ethnographic data support and fill out this picture. Village ethnographies suggest that during the 1990s rural couples grew wary of having three children or two sons but more eager to raise a daughter (Judd 1994; Greenhalgh and Li 1995; Peng and Dai 1996; Zhang 2002). By the late 1990s and early 2000s, some young newlyweds were opting to stop at one, even if that one was a girl (Xie, Gu, and Hardee 2000; Zhang 2003; Yan 2003)." See Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.228.

[226] Merli, "The Past, Present and Future of China's Birth Planning Policy", p.103.

The 'one-child policy' was therefore increasingly losing its relevance in the new historical and social context. Although the government claimed it wouldn't have reformed it until at least 2020, as seen, local administrations now tended to constantly negotiate it with society, given that the harshest penalties were now only for excesses in the application of overly strict rules, while the risk of a sudden 'bounce' in births beyond the allowed quotas due to imprecise controls was extremely unlikely. Maria Giovanna Merli conducted a second survey in 2011, finding that 'several areas record fertility levels below those permitted by the current policy. Perhaps even more notable is that multiple sources suggest that ideal family sizes and reproductive intentions might remain below the replacement level even without any policy-imposed limits.'[227] Just five years after describing the OCP as 'increasingly obsolete,' Merli in 2011 judges it as already completely 'anachronistic.'[228]

Let us now look at a testimony from the 'model community' of Qiyi:

> Qiyi (July 1st) People's Commune outside the city of Shanghai is a progressive commune and a showplace for foreign visitors. [...] Its birth rate was 1.64 percent and its natural growth rate, 1.08 percent. Nevertheless, when it was surveyed [a year after], an overwhelming 84 percent of women of reproductive age said the ideal number of children per family was two. For those who already had one child, 78.1 percent wanted another.[229]

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[227] Maria Giovanna Merli, S. Philip Morgan, "Below Replacement Fertility Preferences in Shanghai", *Population (English Edition, 2002-)*, July – December 2011, Vol. 66, No. 3/4, Aubervilliers (France), Institut National d'Etudes Démographiques, 2012, p.521; The survey is conducted in the Shanghai area, one of the regions subjected to the strictest limits throughout the period of the OCP. In response to the question posed by the survey, 'If you were allowed, would you have a second child?', Merli concludes that "if policy were relaxed and all those answering yes to the hypothetical question had one more child, the mean number of children would not exceed 1.38 children. If we focused solely on cases where the last-born child is younger than 10 and the mother is age 30 or less, the estimate of intended fertility would rise to 1.43. Thus, even allowing for the sensitivity of intentions to life course stages and projecting the behaviour of future cohorts, intended fertility in the absence of policy would still be less than 1.5 children". Merli also notes that almost no one with two or more children desires another child, while many who are already permitted to have more than one child for various reasons do not intend to take advantage of this exception: "Most people who live in Shanghai are allowed only one child and currently have one child. When asked this hypothetical question, 19.8% of this group would wish to have another child or are uncertain. This finding does indicate substantial "pent-up" demand for a second child. Very few people with two or three children would like to have another child, even in the event of policy relaxation. The most remarkable result is the large proportion of those eligible for two children who do not intend to have a second child (66.1%)." See Merli, Morgan, "Below Replacement Fertility Preferences in Shanghai", p.533, 536.

[228] *Ivi*, p.538.

[229] Hsu, "Growth and Control of Population in China", p.253.

These data seem to reflect the reality of 2011, as, being a rural community, one would expect a slightly higher fertility rate compared to Shanghai. Referring also to the table on page 99, a majority still believes that the ideal number of children is 2, so that even without specific birth limits, the trend is to keep the fertility rate below the replacement level. In reality, this testimony was collected in the years 1979-1980, when the OCP *had not yet been implemented*. Although applied only in a few select areas where political investment was particularly high, the 'Maoist' model had already achieved results in 1980 that the 'scientific' approach adopted by the centrist faction would only manage to attain thirty years later. This is one of the issues from the Reform and Opening period that came to the fore at the end of Hu's administration, along with other issues where the post-Maoist government of thirty years showed significant weaknesses, such as environmental protection and widespread corruption. The vast majority of Western social scientists, perhaps having been too easily carried away by the reckless proclamations of the 'End of History' from the late 1990s, expressed themselves during Hu's administration in terms like these:

> China is incrementally transitioning away from communism, the party state is gradually withdrawing from the economic and social spheres, the legal foundations of government policy has strengthened, the devolution of government functions and funding from the central to the local governments has altered the balance of power between center and localities and limited political reform has taken place in the form of local elections.[230]

In the more or less veiled certainty that economic liberalization should necessarily be followed by a complete political, social, and cultural restructuring of China in the Western model, authors like Greenhalgh, Winckler, Merli, and Scharping exhibit a gradual "removal" of the fact that it was primarily the *Westernizing* and *reformist* factions that introduced the most direct control and repression of births in China. These same currents exacerbated the issues that troubled Chinese society at the end of Hu Jintao's decade in power. Therefore, just as it seemed inexplicable to many scholars that Deng's market-opening reforms were simultaneously accompanied by

[230] Merli, "The Past, Present and Future of China's Birth Planning Policy", p.93.

the introduction of more stringent body-control policies than those of the Maoist era, so too it is difficult for them to explain the "third phase" of China's demographic policies inaugurated by Xi Jinping. With the rise of this "new left," the economic sphere has indeed been brought under tighter state control, while "paradoxically"—only for some—important social openings have been introduced, particularly concerning the "one-child policy."

4.2- The "new left", Xi Jinping and the end of the OCP

In 2013, just a few months after Xi Jinping was elected President of the People's Republic of China, the abolition of the One-Child Policy was announced on a national scale, replaced by a new "two-child policy" which imposes no penalties on families with up to two children regardless of their district of residence.[231] The news "surprised many in the field" of studies on the One-Child Policy, including several of its most ardent critics.[232] After a transitional phase, the new policy was fully implemented in 2015.[233] Comparisons with the "purity" of the Mao era are among the arguments that strengthen the "new left." However, this faction does not advocate for a mere restoration of Maoism; instead, it critically reinterprets it within a broader framework, often in a way that is not so much *anti*-Western as it is *post*-Western and distinctly *Chinese.* Meanwhile, various studies have revealed an entirely indigenous capacity to address demographic issues as well:

> Most recently, it has become clear that [before 1839] Chinese families of various classes, and in both good and bad times, employed a variety of strategies to limit their family size, space their children, and select their genders. The most widely used strategies appear to have been delaying pregnancy in marriage and then preventing pregnancy after establishing a family; recent research suggests that this made the reproductive careers of Chinese women significantly shorter, on average, than their European peers,

[231] Martin King Whyte, "Modifying China's One-Child Policy", February 2 2014, published online by E-International Relations, <https://www.e-ir.info/2014/02/02/modifying-chinas-one-child-policy/>, accessed 11th January 2023, p.1.

[232] Daniel Goodkind, "The claim that China's fertility restrictions contributed to the use of prenatal sex selection: A sceptical reappraisal", *Population Studies*, November 2015, Vol. 69, No. 3, London (United Kingdom), Routledge, 2015, p.274.

[233] Wang et al., "Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 930.

> despite virtually universal early marriage. The result was birthrates per marriage and per woman that were well below those of western Europe throughout the 1550–1850 period. In sum, it appears that various groups of Asians were at least as able and determined as any Europeans to keep birthrates down for the sake of maintaining or improving their standards of living. Moreover, the evidence of Chinese and Japanese birthrates lower than European ones supports the evidence for lower death rates (and thus a fairly high standard of living), and vice versa.[234]

The new trend can therefore be presented not only as a continuation of the more positive phases of the Maoist era but also as a revival of the millennia-old history of China prior to the century of humiliation. This is articulated through concepts introduced by the new leader into the Party's theoretical framework, such as the "Great Rejuvenation of the Nation" and the "Chinese Dream." The holistic dimension is also being re-emphasized by social sciences in China; here is how a group of Chinese researchers expressed it in 2016:

> The underlying ideology of modernity teaches us to think that every problem has a simple, direct solution, whereas, in fact, social systems are complex, organic systems. Both the one-child policy and market-oriented population policy are products of modern mechanistic thinking that neglects the whole system and the internal relationships between the components of the whole. Both treat people as instruments, either as political tools or economic tools.[235]

In advocating for the need to implement a new "post-modern" demographic policy—evidently not synonymous with neoliberal but rather with post-Western—the group shows strong expectations toward the Xi government. While remaining firmly anchored to concepts such as modern science and individual rights, they do not identify the usual "contradiction" between economic and social policy that confuses much of Western academia:

> Is it possible for China to implement such a postmodern population policy? It would be doomed to be a tortuous road to develop a postmodern population policy since there is no a ready-made example for China to learn from, and the

[234] Pomeranz, *The Great Divergence*, p.41.
[235] Wang et al., “Ending an Era of Population Control in China", p. 970.

> scientism as well as the mechanical thinking still prevail. But the painful lessons of the one-child policy, the resurgence of Chinese traditional culture, the awakening of individual rights consciousness, and the philosophy of President Xi Jinping enable people to feel hopeful. Take Xi Jinping's philosophy of population as an example. As China's "most powerful leader since Mao," who is called "the new Mao" by some Western media, he holds high the banner of Mao Zedong. As Mao's successor, Xi Jinping values population and emphasizes that population is a "huge power" and vows to "always put the people first." More important, he has taken decisive actions, such as terminating the one-child policy and providing 13 million unregistered citizens (most born in violation of China's one-child policy) with crucial documents, giving them access to long-denied healthcare and schooling. All of these actions convince us that it is very likely for China to develop a postmodern population policy since it is a nation-state of Yi-jing (The Book of Changes), with a strong faith that "change is possible."[236]

The optimism of Chinese researchers is based on what they see as a continuity extending from pre-1839 China, through Mao Zedong, to Xi Jinping. To understand this optimism, it is necessary to move beyond the one-dimensional portrayal of Mao as an iconoclast and destroyer of everything that represents China's past. As noted, the Great Helmsman was considerably more anchored to Chinese culture compared to his early teachers. Of the three characteristics of Maoist population control listed earlier—holistic, indigenous, and based on political mobilization before technics—at least the first two indeed have more in common with classical Chinese philosophy than with contemporary Western thought. Meanwhile, as we have seen, Deng's demographic policy was experienced by Chinese society as a "foreign body" in the country's modernization process. The "scientism" and "mechanical thinking" that these researchers attribute to demographic policies introduced after Mao's death appear genuinely alien to Chinese culture, whose approach to technics is explained by the renowned philosopher Yuk Hui as follows:

> It is undeniable that there were certain philosophies of nature in ancient China, notably in Daoism and its further 'technical' continuation in alchemy. But this philosophy of nature did not indulge in speculations on the basic material

[236] *Ivi*, p. 972.

> elements of the world, as was the case with Thales, Anaximander, Empedocles, and others, but rather treated of an *organic* or *synthetic* form of life— organic in the sense of its being subject to a mutual causation in which the universe is considered as a totality of relations.
>
> [...]
>
> Daoism is very critical of any imposed order, whereas Confucianism seeks to affirm different kinds of order; on the other hand, they seem to supplement each other, as if one asks after the "what", the other after the "how". [...] they both embody what I call a 'moral cosmotechnics': a relational thinking of the cosmos and human being, where the relation between the two is mediated by technical beings.
>
> [...]
>
> For the ancient Greeks, technics imitates nature and at the same time perfects it. 'Techne' mediates between 'physis' and 'tyche' (chance or coincidence). This idea that technics might supplement and 'perfect' nature could not possibly occur in Chinese thought, since for the latter technics is always subordinate to the cosmological order: to be part of nature is to be morally good, since it implies a cosmological order which is also a moral order.[237]

Clearly, Xi Jinping's insistence on the continuity of a historical arc that begins with Lao Tzu's China, passes through Mao, and extends to the present is also a narrative that tends to downplay the significant breaks with the imperial past that characterized the Communist Party's rule. However, it is also emblematic of Xi's attempt to synthesize these different historical phases, aiming to legitimize a line that returns to focusing on the *organic* nature of phenomena—including demographic ones—developing a distinctly *Chinese* approach to addressing them, and placing technics in the service of a resolutely *political* program. In this new direction, there is no room for measures like the One-Child Policy, which tried to regulate behavior by filling with mere administrative restrictions a space previously occupied by ideology, the State, and the Party. Just five years after its implementation, the "Two-Child Policy" is also abolished, in the same year, 2020, in which the government announces the complete eradication of absolute poverty across the country, achieved through a

[237] Yuk Hui, *The Question Concerning Technology in China. An Essay in Cosmotechnics*, Falmouth (United Kingdom), Urbanomic Media, 2016, pp.63-70. Il corsivo è nostro.

mobilization that evokes both the image of the eighteenth-century "hydraulic empire" and Mao's campaigns.[238] China thus exits from the third and final phase of its restrictive demographic policies: the "One-Child Policy" becomes history without ever being fully normalized. We have identified the main reason for this failure as the fact that it was simply unsuitable both for the system that was supposed to ensure its implementation and for the culture of the masses it targeted. Fertility rate rebounds, population defense strategies, and scandals raised by the media are all clear indicators of the "rejection crisis" that contemporary Chinese society has produced in response to this policy.

However, it remains to be explained why the fertility rate in China, since the peak reached in the 1960s, has decreased to current levels, below the replacement level. As mentioned earlier, some demographers argue that economic development is the determining factor. However, the growth of per capita GDP in a country cannot be automatically correlated with the reduction in births, especially in the case of China, where the most acute phase of this reduction occurs *before* the economic boom. To understand China's demographic transition, it is necessary to revisit the history of the People's Republic of China through the lens of gender.

4.3- Why are fewer children being born in China?

As Matthew Connelly states, "the only factor that has been proven to have a consistent and convincing correlation with the reduction in fertility is the increase in

[238] On February 25, 2021, the Chinese government announced the eradication of extreme poverty in the country, based on indicators known as the "three guarantees and two assurances," which refer to access to housing, medical care, education, basic food, and clothing for all citizens. Between 1949 and 2021, 850 million people in China have gained access to these goods and services as a result of poverty eradication campaigns, meaning that China has contributed 70% of the total global reduction in poverty over the past 70 years. In the "targeted" phase of these campaigns, which began in 2013 and lasted for 8 years, 1.1 million kilometers of roads were built, 98% of rural villages were connected to the internet, housing for 25.68 million people was renovated, new homes were built for 9.6 million, and countless infrastructure projects were completed for water access, sanitation, and electrification, with a total expenditure equivalent to approximately 250 billion dollars. UN Secretary-General António Guterres described this process in 2019 as "the greatest achievement in history in the fight against poverty." See Tings Chak, Li Jianhua, Lilian Zhang, *Serve the People: The Eradication of Extreme Poverty in China*, Studies on socialist construction, Vol.1 (July 2021), Tricontinental: Institute for Social Research, 2021, pp.4-6.

the education level of women."[239] Amartya Sen concurs, citing numerous studies confirming the "abundant statistical evidence linking female education (including literacy) to reduced fertility across various countries worldwide."[240] Paul T. Schultz, who has made the correlation between female education and demographics a focal point of his extensive research, finds that

> Where only education is entered nonlinearly as a series of splines or unrestricted dummy variables, increasing education of women is generally associated with lower fertility, certainly after a threshold of about four years of schooling, a level which may be roughly equivalent to functional literacy. [...] In 38 countries where World Fertility Surveys were conducted during the 1970s [...], women at age 40-49 with seven or more years of schooling have 1.6-2.9 fewer births than women with no schooling. Total fertility rates (TFR), which reflect current birth rates summed over ages, differ by even a larger amount between women with more and less education.[241]

Studies specifically conducted in China yield the same results. For instance, Hsu reports:

> When women of reproductive age are grouped by levels of education and their average number of children, the negative correlation between the two variables is revealed. Better educated women have also been found to marry lat- er and to be more knowledgeable about birth control methods. It is interesting to note that, at least in this sample study, within each educational group the rural setting is related to a higher level of fertility. In other studies, however, the results have been more definitive in relating education to fertility without the noticeable effect of the "rural factor".[242]

The trend in fertility rates in China remarkably mirrors another curve, that of female illiteracy, especially in rural areas:

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239 Connelly, *Fatal Misconception*, p.23.
240 Sen, "Population Policy", p.11.
241 Paul T Schultz, "Demand for Children in Low Income Countries," *Handbook of Population and Family Economics,* vol.1A, Amsterdam (Nederland), North Holland, 1997, p.381.
242 Hsu, "Growth and Control of Population in China", p.249.

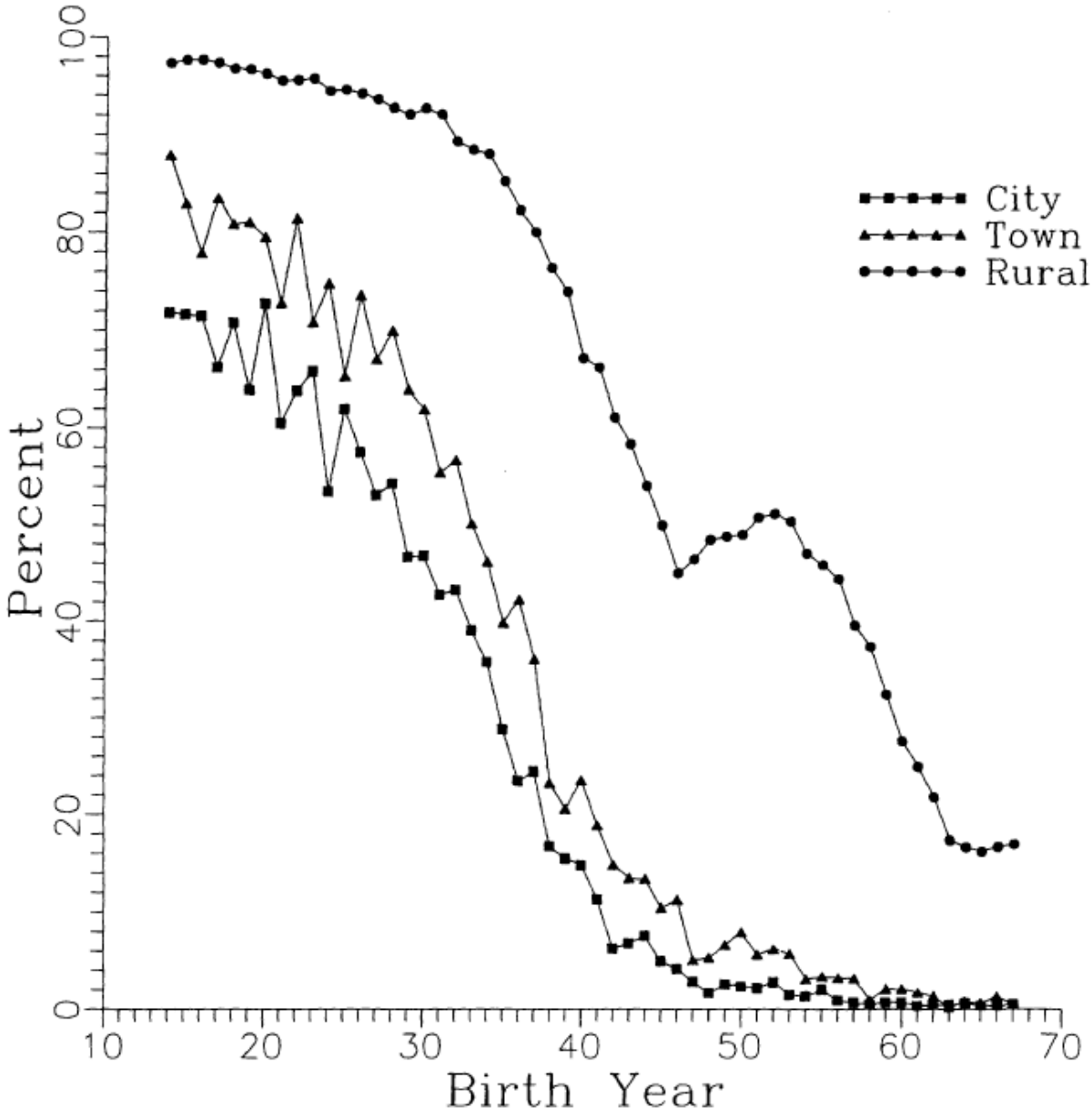

Fig.4.2 - Illiteracy Rate Among Women by Year of Birth in China, 1910-1970. Source: William Lavely, Xiao Zhenyu, Li Bohua, Ronald Freedman, "The Rise in Female Education in China: National and Regional Patterns", *The China Quarterly*, Mar. 1990, No. 121 (Mar., 1990), Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 1990, p.68

In Chapter 1, we observed that at the time of the founding of the People's Republic of China, the vast majority of Chinese women had no access to basic education. As illustrated by the graph provided, the process of female literacy in China experienced a radical acceleration, particularly in rural areas, starting from 1949. It is the girls born from the late 1930s onwards who, upon reaching school age, began to

effectively learn to read and write.

> Over 92 per cent of females born before 1932 are illiterate. There is a drop for the cohort born in 1932, but the sustained decline in illiteracy does not begin until the 1935 cohort, corresponding to an educational experience of the mid 1 940s. However, the rural educational expansion of the early 1 950s could have included some older females affected by adult literacy programmes, and it is thus impossible to say exactly how much progress was made prior to 1950. However, in general it can be said that only under the People's Republic did a substantial proportion of rural women attain literacy.[243]

This process experienced a period of stagnation for the generation born around the late 1940s to early 1950s, before resuming vigorously for those born around the mid-1960s. Considering that during this historical period, girls typically achieved literacy between the ages of 10 and 15, Lavely identifies the times when the People's Republic of China made significant progress in this area and those when the primary education program for women encountered difficulties.

The first phase of acceleration and the subsequent interruption of the process are not surprising: following the establishment of the People's Republic, Chinese women learned to read and write en masse. However, in response to the crisis caused by the failure of the Great Leap Forward, the educational program experienced a crisis lasting approximately ten years. Yet, it regained momentum and saw its most vibrant period during what is now unanimously considered the darkest phase of the Maoist era—the Cultural Revolution—before again facing a period of stagnation in the early years of the post-Mao transition.

> Our findings can be summarized as follows: The rise of female education occurred mainly in two periods - the 1950s to 1958, and the late 1960s to mid 1970s.[244]

These data do not justify the hypothesis of a direct causal relationship between female literacy and fertility reduction. If that were the case, the two curves would need to follow similar trajectories with a lag of approximately ten years between

[243] Lavely et al., "The Rise in Female Education in China", p.66.
[244] *Ivi*, p.61.

them, which is not observed.[245] What we have proposed, however, is a correlation, which is more complex and influenced by other factors.[246] To support this, the trajectory of the curves shows surprising correspondences about *twenty* years apart from each other, as if literacy campaigns had a directly proportional impact on the fertility rate not on the women who were of *school age* during those periods, but rather on the women *born* during those years:

	Date of birth	*Period of peak fertility*	*Data observed*
Group 1	1940-49 (pre-PRC)	1960-69, no birth-reduction policies	Growth and peak fertility rate
Group 2	1950-58 (during mass women literacy campaign)	1970-78, *Wan Xi Shao* policy	First stable reduction of fertility rate
Group 3	1959–68 (women literacy campaign slows down)	1979-89, One-Child Policy (harsh)	Fertility rate unstable, but not reduced (brief reductions followed by rebounds)
Group 4	End of the 1960s – half '70s (second women education mass campaign)	1989–95, One-Child Policy (milder)	Second stable reduction of fertility rate

In light of this, at least in the Chinese case, the most likely hypothesis in our view is this: *literacy and education for women remain the primary key factor in the reduction of the fertility rate in China, a reduction that stabilizes within the context of a broader set of active policies aimed at improving the status of women.* The "delay" in these effects is due to the time needed for such policies to have a real

[245] Given the age of reaching literacy at 15 years and the peak fertility age at 25 years.

[246] In another study published in 1990, Lavely emphasizes the complex nature of the correlation between female education and reproductive control: "Education appears to be associated with the early adoption of fertility control, but one must be cautious about assigning education as the "cause." Although education has an effect independent of urbanization when urbanism is represented by broad categories, educational levels may serve as proxies for other community-level factors." Cfr. William Lavely, Ronald Freedman, "The Origins of the Chinese Fertility Decline", *Demography*, Vol. 27, No.3, pp.357-367, Durham (USA), Duke University Press, 1990.

impact on: 1) women's decision-making power – including in reproductive matters – compared to men, 2) the decision-making power of younger women relative to older women in the family, and 3) the final establishment of a new standard for family planning following a period of intergenerational conflict within families.[247] In any case, in China, fertility reduction occurs *after* the decline in female illiteracy but *precedes* the massive economic development of the 1980s and 1990s. Therefore, attributing the decrease in births solely to economic development is not only inaccurate but represents a complete reversal of the factors: if the relationship between development and lower fertility must be simplified to a causal connection, in China it would not be development causing the reduction in births, but the exact opposite. However, as the history of the "one-child policy" teaches us, a stable and sustainable reduction in birth rates cannot be introduced mechanically or achieved "by decree"; it can never be a "primary cause." It will always be a consequence of other processes, which can indeed be triggered by specific political measures aimed at female empowerment—foremost among them, basic education. For authors like King White, Scharping, and Greenhalgh, it seems impossible to recognize a fact that appears quite evident to us: the success of the Wan Xi Shao policy of the 1970s didn't occur because it was particularly coercive—essentially, it was not coercive at all—but mainly because, formally setting aside natalism, it addressed the needs of a new generation of more educated and professionally integrated Chinese women. We observe in these and many other authors a tendency to forcefully place Chinese demographic policy within a framework of complete alterity of contemporary China compared to the rest of the world: an image of a country where no significant social phenomenon occurs organically as a result of healthy modernization, but rather a place where every change is the result of a forced imposition, whether directly from the government or caused by wild processes of "marketization." .[248] The "One-Child Policy" thus becomes a kind of symbol, an emblematic representation of how "things work" in China. We believe this image is both incorrect and harmful. Undoubtedly, in the history of Chinese demographics, the One-Child Policy was certainly a lengthy and extremely problematic interlude, and perhaps even more so from the perspective of women's history. However, it cannot be the symbol of the entirety of women's

[247] Si tratta di uno schema suggerito da Amartya Sen, “Population Policy: Authoritarianism Versus Cooperation", *Journal of Population Economics*, vol.10 n.1, Berlin, Springer-Verlag, 1997.

[248] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.228.

condition in China: with the abolition of the OCP, the trajectory of women's rights in China since the founding of the People's Republic actually closes the last qualitatively distinctive "gap" compared to the rest of the international community, representing overall one of the greatest processes of female emancipation in history —and perhaps the greatest, if only for the enormous scale of the population involved.[249] Considering the state of feminist issues in 1949, a look at the World Bank Gender Data Portal[250] can help us understand the extent of the changes experienced by Chinese women over seventy years. It measures gender equality based on 14 key indicators, and the data for China on some of these indicators is remarkable:

- Maternal mortality during childbirth in China is now five times lower than in India, the only country of comparable size, and which in 1949 was far wealthier than China (Indicator 1).

- Between 1960 and 1975, the percentage of teenage mothers in China decreased more rapidly than in the rest of Asia and the world, reaching very low levels and remaining well below the regional and global averages ever since (Indicator 2).

- According to 2011 data, the percentage of girls who complete secondary education at school age is as high as 100.5% (compared to 98.6% for boys). This indicates not only that virtually all Chinese girls have access to education up to high school but also that progress is being made even among older women, to the extent that they are becoming statistically significant (Indicator 3).

- The female employment rate in China recorded in 2021 is 61.6%, with a gap of 12.7% compared to male employment. A culturally similar country often used for comparison, Japan, which is frequently presented as an example of "healthy" democratic development in contrast to China, has a gap of 17.7%. Proportionally, if China had the same figure as Japan, 60 million Chinese women currently employed would instead be unemployed. South Korea has an even larger gap of 19%, while in India, the difference between female and male employment rates is as high as 50.9%. If China had this same gap, there

[249] Come fa giustamente notare John Ross, "The simplest and clearest gauge of the historically unparalleled scale of China's [...] achievement[s] is the number of people directly benefitting from it as they lived within China's borders – this being measured not only in absolute numbers but as a proportion of the world's population."; Cfr. Ross, *China's Great Road*, p.8.

[250] Source: <https://genderdata.worldbank.org/>, last consultation 06/05/2023.

would be 300 million more unemployed women globally.

- The proportion of unpaid domestic work in China remains significantly skewed against women, who spend 2.6 times more time on it than men. However, in absolute terms, Chinese women do not spend more time on domestic work than women in the United States and Norway (with all three countries at 15.3% of the 24-hour day) and even less than Swedish women (16%). Additionally, the gap compared to men is once again lower than in culturally similar countries, such as South Korea, where women spend 3.2 times more time than men on domestic work, and Japan, where the difference is nearly five times, double that of China (Indicator 6).

- Despite often being rightly criticized for the relatively low representation of women in political power, China has 24.9% of seats in the national parliament occupied by women, compared to just 9% in Japan and 19% in South Korea (Indicator 12).

In the introduction to her *Revolution Postponed*, Margery Wolf stated that:

> Only the most ardent anti-Communists would deny that life for the average person in Communist China has been raised to standards beyond the hope of the previous generation. People live better and longer lives, and they have that most valuable of emotions, hope for an even better future. The criticisms I have made in the last few pages and will be making in the next few hundred are not intended to deny that accomplishment or even to diminish it.[251]

Forty years after the publication of Wolf's work, which was highly critical of China at the time, these words would probably sound "biased," overly favorable to the "Dragon." This is because, despite China's current integration into the global system like never before, the rhetoric against it has progressively deteriorated, resulting in what is effectively a "black legend," and the analysis of its demographic policies has not been exempt from this process.

[251] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.26.

Fig. 4.3 – Mural created in a rural village reorganized around "red tourism" activities (tourist sites related to the Communist Party of China's struggle for power and the founding of the People's Republic), within the context of the poverty eradication campaign in Wanshan District, Guizhou Province. Photo: Xiang Wang, April 2021.

CHAPTER 5

THE DEBATE OVER THE REAL IMPACT OF THE ONE-CHILD POLICY

Almost a decade after its abolition, the OCP is still the subject of intense scientific debate:

> Despite the scope of that literature, however, no consensus has emerged on how to understand the process by which the policy was formulated and how it evolved. Where some see China's leaders making a rash decision to escalate pressures on couples to control births, others see a rational leadership responding to expert (albeit flawed) demographic advice and gearing population policy to fit modernization goals. Where some see an autonomous state using threats and force to impose an un- popular and intrusive birth-limitation program, others see a constrained state, one in which the capacity to enforce strict birth limits is undercut by the impact of economic reforms. And where some see a core elite successfully wielding the tools of Maoism and Leninism to implement the one-child policy, others see a multi-tiered state organization in which local governments, exercising a degree of autonomy, have the capacity to modify state demands.[252]

Starting from the late 1990s, one issue in particular has fueled the debate within the expert community: the effectiveness of the OCP itself, which had previously been undisputed. The question that began to be asked, in its most succinct form, is: Did the "one-child policy" really work in reducing the population in China?

[252] White, "Two Kinds of Production", p.137.

5.1- How many births has the OCP actually prevented? Issues with the counterfactual approach

In 1997, the renowned economist and philosopher Amartya Sen published an article titled "Population Policy: Authoritarianism Versus Cooperation" in the *Journal of Population Economics*. In it, Sen argues that "coercive" models of fertility rate reduction are not only ethically problematic but also less effective than programs based on "cooperation."[253] While still relying on a relatively unrefined comparative analysis[254], and proposing an alternative cooperative model to coercion that appears, in some respects, too complex to be implemented as a comprehensive policy outside the cited cases, the article marks the beginning of a line of research that would question the presumed effectiveness of the OCP, which had been generally accepted until that time. The topic is appealing to the scientific community not only because the issue is "hot" and of widespread interest but also because it demonstrates the potential, if supported by sufficient evidence, to have a profound impact on future decisions by the Chinese government itself. A few years later, while the number of births prevented by the OCP is generally estimated to be around 250 million[255], Merli notes that "some observers argue that the one-child policy of family planning post-1979 has been either useless or of only transient importance."[256] A decade later, the thesis of the fundamental uselessness of the OCP has become widely accepted in demographic studies. Wang, Yong, and Gu argue in 2013 that "a universal two-child policy" per family would "not only have allowed China to achieve its population control goal but would have also produced more favorable demographic and social conditions."[257]

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[253] Amartya Sen, “Population Policy: Authoritarianism Versus Cooperation", *Journal of Population Economics*, vol.10 n.1, Berlin, Springer-Verlag, 1997, pp.3-22.

[254] For example, in support of the thesis that better fertility reduction goals could have been achieved in China with non-coercive methods, the article includes passages such as: "Kerala, in fact, had a higher fertility rate than China in 1979 (3.0 as opposed to China’s 2.8), and by 1991 its fertility rate of 1.8 is as much below China’s 2.0 as it had been above it in 1979. Despite the added “advantage” of the one-child policy and other coercive measures, the Chinese fertility rate seems to have fallen more slowly than in Kerala."; See Sen, “Population Policy: Authoritarianism Versus Cooperation", p.16.

[255] See as an example Kane, Choi, "China's one child family policy", 1999, p.994: "since [the One-Child Policy] inception reductions in Chinese fertility have reduced the country's (and the world's) population growth by some 250 million. These reductions in fertility have eased at least some of the pressures on communities, state, and the environment in a country which still carries one fifth of the world's people".

[256] Merli, "Has the Chinese Family Planning Policy Been Successful in Changing Fertility Preferences?", p.557.

[257] Wang et al., "Population, Policy, and Politics", p.123.

In 2015, Wang and Yong, along with King Whyte, describe the effectiveness of the OCP as a "myth":

> Of all the myths that have circulated regarding the one-child policy, the one that has gained the most currency recently is that it has prevented 400 million births. Supporters of the policy argue that such a huge number of prevented births not only fueled China's dramatic post-1978 economic boom, as claimed by the Chinese government, but also contributed to global well-being.
>
> [...]
>
> it is highly misleading to claim that the one-child policy successfully prevented 400 million extra births. Despite the coercive ferocity of the campaign, China's rapid economic development since 1980 deserves the lion's share of the credit for the (much more modest) numbers of reduced births that have occurred as the country's total fertility rate further declined, from about 2.7–2.8 at the end of the 1970s to perhaps 1.4–1.5 today.[258]

The figure of 400 million prevented births is derived from a study funded by the Chinese government's family planning agency—which, however, includes births prevented by Chinese demographic policies starting from 1970, thus covering the period before the OCP.[259] The main reasons provided by King Whyte, Wang, and Yong to support the thesis that this figure is severely overestimated are threefold:

1. The calculation of 400 million prevented births is based on a wholly unrealistic counterfactual scenario, which seriously underestimates the reduction in fertility rates that would have occurred regardless of any birth control policy being implemented.[260]

2. This calculation does not take into account the actual dynamics of fertility rate reduction in China, particularly the fact that the most significant phase occurred *before* the introduction of the OCP;[261]

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[258] King Whyte et al., "Challenging Myths About China's One-Child Policy", pp.155, 159.

[259] Wang et al., "Population, Policy, and Politics", p.120; Cfr. Yang Kuifu, Chen Shengli, Wei Jinsheng, *Zhongguo jihua shengyu xiaoyi yu touru* (The Costs and Benefits of China's Birth Planning), Beijing, People's Press, 2000.

[260] King Whyte et al., "Challenging Myths About China's One-Child Policy", p.156

[261] *Ivi,* p.158.

3. The main cause of the reduction in fertility rates is economic development, yet this factor has not been credited, with the claim being that the "400 million births" were prevented solely due to the government program.[262]

But the alternative scenario proposed by King Whyte, Wang and Yong also relies on the "exploration of a counterfactual": according to a model used "for the latest United Nations projections," the three demographers conclude that "the decline [in births] would have continued into the 1980s. By 2010, fertility would have dropped to the current observed level [in 2013] of about 1.5 children per woman."[263]

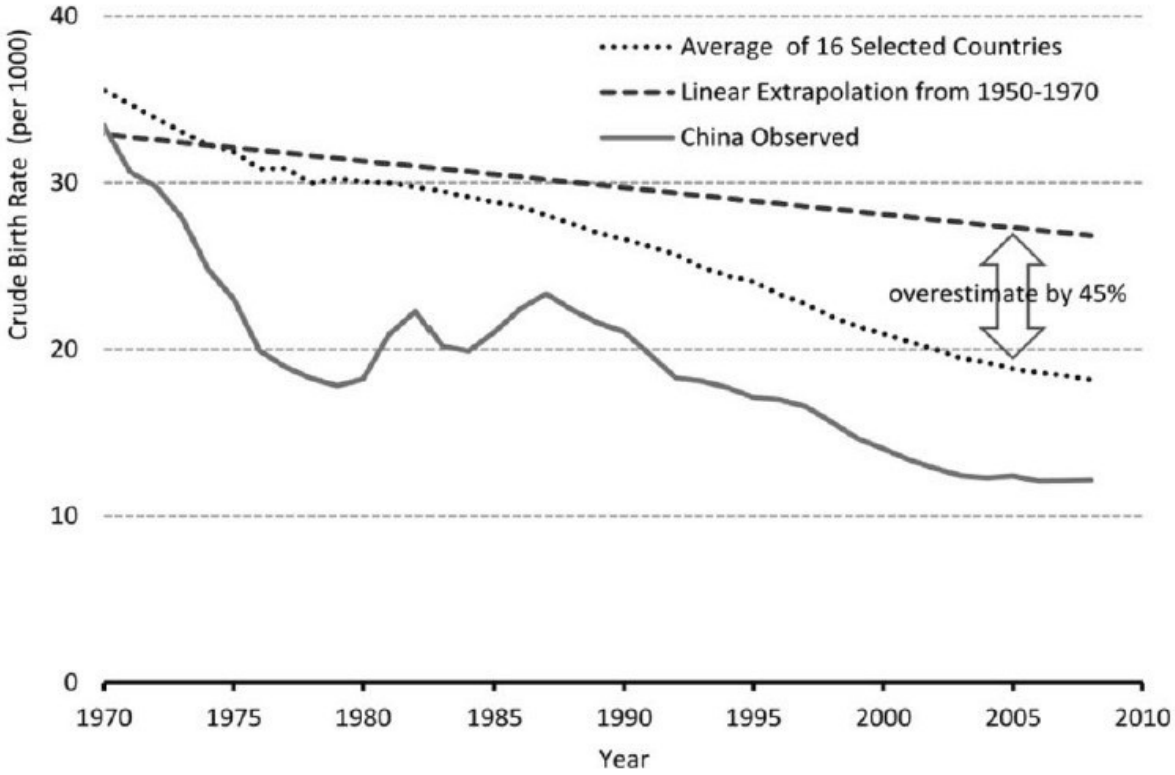

Fig.5.1 - The first major critique by anti-OCP demographers of the estimate of 400 million prevented births is as follows: The projection from studies that provide this figure (dashed line) is compared with the actual trends from a sample of 16 countries. The demographers aim to show that, without any specific birth control policy, China would have essentially followed the trajectory of these countries (dotted line). Furthermore, with the introduction of less restrictive policies, such as the two-child policy implemented in Vietnam, similar results to the actual outcomes (solid line) would have been achieved, with a trajectory that would have been more stable. Source: King Whyte et al., "Challenging Myths About China's One-Child Policy", p.156.

[262] *Ibidem*
[263] Wang et al., "Population, Policy, and Politics", p.122

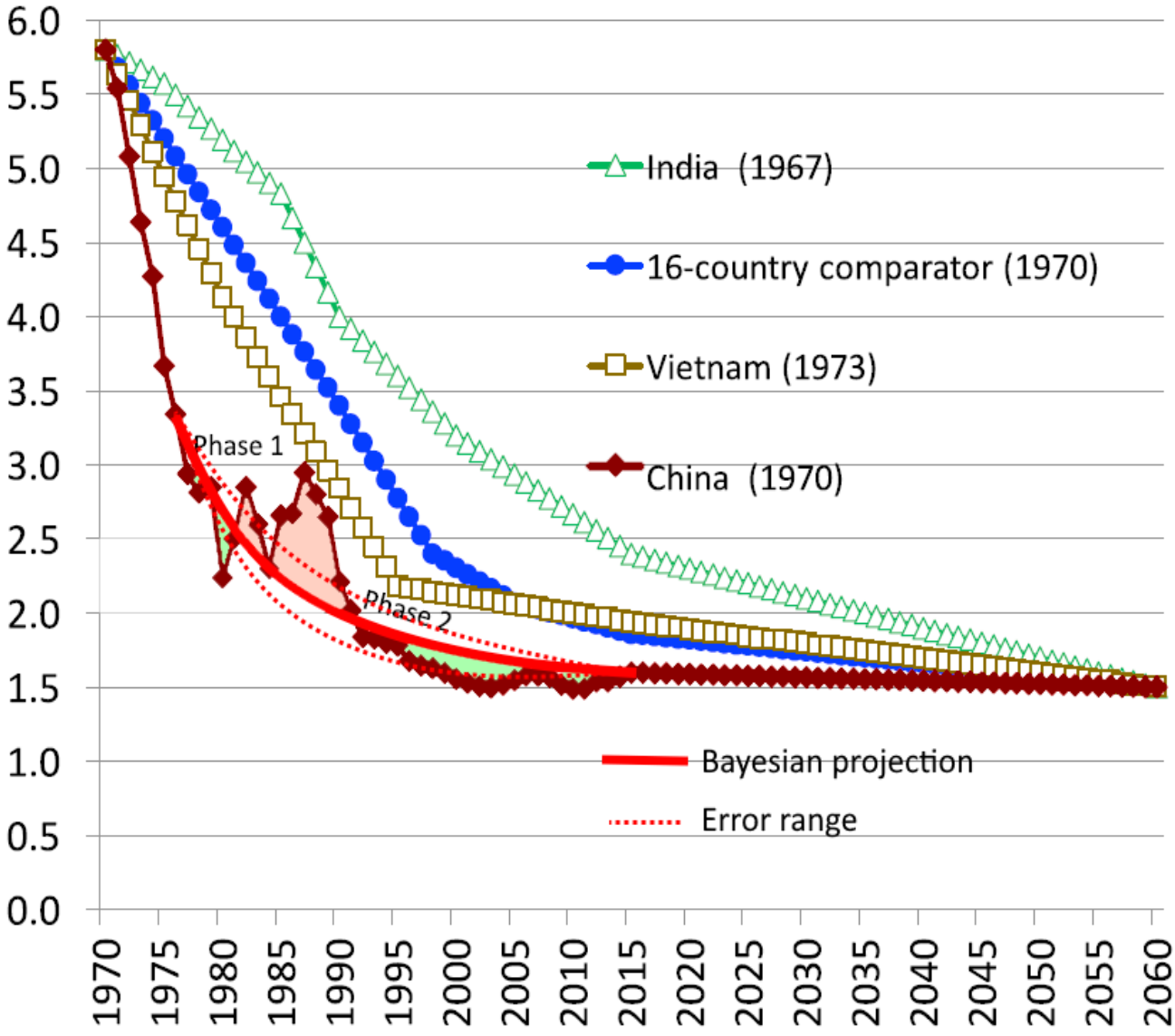

Fig.5.2 - Approximate representation of the counterfactual scenario proposed by anti-OCP demographers, with the introduction of a "two-child policy" in the post-Mao era (light red lines), compared to the actual trend during the period 1979-2015 (dark red line). Assuming that with a "two-child policy" the same fertility level achieved by the OCP in 2010 would have been reached, and predicting a more linear trend compared to the "ups and downs" experienced by China during that period, the "one-child policy" appears even counterproductive towards a net reduction in births.
Sources: Wang et al., "Population, Policy, and Politics", p.122; Goodkind, "The Astonishing Population Averted by China's Birth Restrictions", p.1379.

There are certainly merits to the hypotheses presented by Wang Feng, King Whyte, and others; however, while not delving into the specifics of their calculations due to my background in a different field of study, a historian can already identify at least three weaknesses in the framework proposed by this group of demographers. The first, similar to Sen's case, is an application of comparative analysis that seems insufficiently problematized. The second is related to the group's assertion that the "main cause of fertility reduction" is "economic development": as previously noted, the most significant phase of China's demographic transition actually occurred *before* the economic boom, so this explanation is flawed by a chronological issue[264], due to the intention of demonstrating that all demographic policies adopted by the People's Republic have been violently coercive and counterproductive, not just the "one-child policy".[265] The third weakness of the thesis is a methodological issue: this revisits the problems raised in the first part of this work regarding the inevitably rhetorical nature of data and graphs, especially in the context of presentations based on hypothetical and alternative scenarios compared to how events actually unfolded, i.e., what we call "counterfactual history." Lawrence Stone has cautioned us about this:

> There are grave doubts whether counterfactual history - described by one critic as 'if my grandmother had wheels she'd be a greyhound bus' history - is of much practical use to historians, who are concerned with what happened, not with what might have happened but didn't. It is, after all, a fact that America did build railroads instead of relying on water transport for bulk goods. Counterfactual history is a useful methodological aid to clear thinking about historical hypotheses, but nothing more.[266]

The amusing hyperbole highlights the risk of spreading clichés based on unprovable hypotheses. Clearly, the image of a "China that never adopted the OCP" is more

[264] See p.117; Regarding the link between economic development and the reduction in fertility rates, the renowned italian demographer Massimo Livi-Bacci also warns against too easily establishing a causal relationship between the two: We should not accept as "law" a relationship observed during an historical period in which increased well being seems to have favored the spread of voluntary fertility control. The present day lack of correlation between fertility and income levels suggests that other complex motivations, only slightly connected with the availability of material goods, govern the fertility decisions of couples."; Cfr. Massimo Livi-Bacci, *A Concise History of World Population*, Chichester (United Kingdom), Wiley Blackwell, 2017, p.142.

[265] Cfr. King Whyte et al., "Challenging Myths About China's One-Child Policy" p.159.

[266] Stone, *The Past and The Present Revisited*, p.26.

plausible than a "grandmother with wheels," yet it remains an impossibility. Referring back to the graph shown on the previous page, the profoundly rhetorical effect it produces is evident: attention is focused on a "what if..." scenario versus "what actually happened," materializing in the reader's mind a differential of suffering and coercion between the two that is equally unrealistic. Judgments of merit or value based on these "counterfactual stories" are at least debatable. This context produces narratives that easily slide from "counterfactual" to "anti-factual," with the spread of clichés and distortions. Moreover, the very method of constructing an argument based on a counterfactual scenario proves its rhetorical and malleable nature, when other authors build an argumentative structure on this foundation that leads to opposite conclusions.

5.2- "Spreadsheet demographers". Rhetoric and Ethics in Demographic Studies.

In 2017, an independent researcher, Daniel Goodkind, published a study titled "The Astonishing Population Averted by China's Birth Restrictions: Estimates, Nightmares, and Reprogrammed Ambitions" in *Demography*, one of the leading peer-reviewed journals—if not the most influential—in the field of demographic studies. Based on the same projections as Wang et al., Goodkind concludes that the estimate of "400 million prevented births" claimed by the Chinese government is, in fact, well-founded:

> Counterfactual projections based on fertility declines in other countries suggest that China's program-averted population numbered 360–520 million as of 2015. The low end of this range is based on Vietnam—China's best national comparator, with a two-child program of its own—and the high end is based on a 16-country comparator selected, ironically, by critics of the official estimate. The latter comparator further implies that China's one-child program itself averted a population of 400 million by 2015, three-quarters of the total averted population. All such estimates are projected to double by 2060, due mostly to counterfactual population momentum. These and other findings presented herein affirm the astonishing impact of China's draconian policy choices and challenge the current consensus that rapid socioeconomic progress drove China's fertility well below two children per family. International comparisons

> of fertility and income suggest instead that China′s very low fertility arrived two or three decades too soon. If China had not harshly enforced a norm of 1.5-children during the last quarter century, most mothers would have had two children, one-half birth higher than observed.[267]

Goodkind's study provokes strong reactions within the scientific community. One of the main authors previously cited, Wang Feng from the University of California, Irvine, sends an email to *Demography* co-editor Stephen Matthews shortly after the publication, describing Goodkind's paper as "morally irresponsible." Governments facing high fertility rates might be tempted to introduce similar coercive measures if they believe, based on studies claiming that the "one-child policy" was effective in drastically reducing fertility, that such measures work. Wang's group calls for the withdrawal of the publication. However, Matthews responds by stating that Goodkind's article "has passed the standard double-blind peer review process," despite previous work by the same author having encountered "fierce resistance." The controversy extends beyond the specific field and is discussed in major popular media outlets, reaching a broad audience.[268] In *Demography*, the group led by Wang Feng responds in 2018 with an article that describes Goodkind's work as "spreadsheet demography":

> Spreadsheet demography sees human beings as “units” to fit into a demographic model in which parameters are “free” to vary without consideration of their empirical or sociological meaning. [...]A simplified message, derived and presented unidimensionally, can underestimate the multidimensional complexity of society. It is these exercises that follow the fashion of “spreadsheet demography,” exercises that are devoid of critical self-reflection, wedded to outdated theories and divorced from social and cultural realities that give demography and demographers a bad name. In other words, in spreadsheet demography, *population* takes primacy over *people.*[269]

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[267] Goodkind, "The Astonishing Population Averted by China’s Birth Restrictions”, p.1375.

[268] Mara Hvistendal, "Analysis of China's one-child policy sparks uproar", *Science* (online), 18 Ottobre 2017, <https://www.science.org/content/article/analysis-china-s-one-child-policy-sparks-uproar>, last consultation 16/04/2023.

[269] Wang Feng, Cai Yong, Shen Ke, Stuart Gietel-Basten, "Is Demography Just a Numerical Exercise? Numbers, Politics, and Legacies of China’s One-Child Policy.", *Demography* ,1 April 2018; 55 (2), Durham (USA), Duke University Press, 2018. p.694; The italics are in the original

But what "multidimensional complexities of society" did the projections from the same authors five years earlier, based on entirely hypothetical scenarios, account for? The criticisms directed at Goodkind for relying on spurious comparisons and for hypothesizing an "unrealistic" rebound in fertility are weaknesses that also affect the opposing thesis, regardless of how one might be more plausible or refined than the other. The rather furious reaction to Goodkind's study actually reveals that the critique is not so much about the quality of the data and projections he presents, based on a past political and social reality, which is the direct subject of the analysis. Rather, the criticism is aimed at the "irresponsible" publication of research that does not consider the potential effects it might have on the current political and social reality. The Wang group thus concludes its 2018 response to Goodkind:

> We cannot fault demographers for not being able to stop the launch of extreme policies that harmed people; that was beyond their power. However, we should ask ourselves about demography's role in policymaking. Some may hope that by producing an astonishing number of so-called births averted, one can astonish the world and showcase the cleverness and prowess of demographic methods. But such a misplaced hope, once again, became the enemy of objectivity.[270]

Again leveraging classic rhetorical tools, the Wang group seamlessly shifts from a critique of the research's impact on policies to one concerning its "objectivity," or the intrinsic quality of the work. The evident risk is to invert the order of priorities that defines science—i.e., to narrow the scope of possible research outcomes to those that fall within the realm of "morally acceptable positions," which are always historically determined, thus bringing the results far from the aspiration of relative "neutrality" of the sciences, including social sciences. This naturally reopens the question of the real possibility of "objective" science, and here the self-critical reflection that has driven Historical Sciences for at least a century is an exemplary process that perhaps other disciplines could better explore.

The debate on the actual effectiveness of the OCP has likely proceeded without

[270] Wang et al. "Is Demography Just a Numerical Exercise?", p.711.

sufficient problematization. Is it possible to answer the question of whether the "one-child policy" actually "worked"? From a historical perspective, it could be argued that the question itself is misleading. One should start with what really has been, if it ever existed, the demographic policy more or less organically applied to the entire Chinese population over the last forty years. Beyond the discursive production surrounding it, both from Chinese and Western perspectives, this policy should therefore be outlined in its concrete characteristics and redefined based on these.

5.3- Some conclusions about the "one-child policy"

It seems essential to start from the fact that, as some researchers on the issue point out, "the autonomy of the state in policymaking should not be equated with the capacity to implement the policies themselves."[271]. On paper, the implementation of the quota and sanction system should have been enough to drastically reduce fertility rates, but as observed, this phenomenon only occurred following particularly intense political mobilization campaigns, which often led to abuses that stirred scandals due to their violation of the policy's own regulations.

> when the one-child policy finally was strongly enforced during 1983, the regime had not yet built the capacity for controlled implementation. The result was disastrous, not only for women's health and dignity, but also for political relations between the party, its community cadres, and the masses.[272]

Therefore, it can be said that the OCP "worked" only when used as a broad "political line" for intensive one-time campaigns to reduce births, and was ineffective or minimally effective during periods when attempts were made to codify and normalize it. The need for extraordinary political mobilization diminished only when the policy itself became obsolete. The attempt by the Deng government to transform birth reduction from a political issue to a legal and administrative matter thus basically failed. Why?

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[271] Huang, Yang, "Population Control and State Coercion in China", p.197.
[272] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.106.

One of the reasons behind this failure is explained by Huang and Yang, who in 2004 still note that:

> in strengthening its gynecological capacity, the Chinese government faces a critical information problem, which is how to penetrate couples' privacy to monitor reproductive behavior continuously and exhaustively. The state can resort to persuasion, propaganda, penalization, persecution, and provision of services to enforce the one-child limit, but by itself it cannot acquire the capacity for such social surveillance.[273]

Once again, mirror-image narratives about contemporary China have often depicted the Chinese state as an apparatus fully in control of its population, as one of the most complete embodiments of Foucault's Panopticon. However, it should be remembered that the modern political and administrative system in China has undergone a rapid yet still uneven and incomplete process of construction, particularly in its ability to monitor and control individuals in such a private domain as reproduction. The same researchers mentioned above, for example, point out that:

> A survey carried out in Jilin province in 1985 […] revealed that more than 66 percent of rural married women with one surviving child practiced contraception in response to the government programs.[274]

This data is cited as evidence of the OCP's impact on population habits; however, it is notable that in rural areas, one-third of married women who already had one child were *not* using any form of contraception five years *after* the launch of the "one-child policy," despite several contraceptive methods being widely available and distributed. Throughout the period when the OCP was in effect, the population's resistance to government control was strong, varied, and decidedly effective:

> many families have developed a myriad of strategies to evade state control so as to get the number and sex of children they deem desirable. They hide pregnant women, feign compliance, surreptitiously remove IUDs, conspire

[273] Huang, Yang, "Population Control and State Coercion in China", p.202.
[274] *Ivi,* p.198.

> with community leaders to conceal “excess” births from higher authorities, and even physically attack birth planning officials. The pressure to achieve population control targets has thus induced various distortions in population figures. On one hand, the attempts to conceal “excess” children have led to the significant underreporting of births, particularly of girls. The underreporting rate in some rural areas, according to the SFPC, may be as high as 30 percent. Between 1991 and 1998, the underreported population in Sichuan province alone was estimated at over 400,000, approximately the population of a midsized county.[275]

Resistance to the OCP did not only come from "below": Chinese academia and the press also criticized the program and its dysfunctions. The official newspaper of the Party, *People's Daily*, regularly published articles denouncing excesses since 1981, including interviews with representatives of the population who were openly hostile to the "one-child policy." .[276] Many of the most striking cases of abuse cited by the press outside China emerged from the widespread *internal* dissemination of such news, which was often followed by interventions from the authorities to penalize the guilty officials, also aiming to calm the reaction of Chinese public opinion.[277] Even from the early stages of its implementation, government-commissioned reports did not hide the problems of the "one-child policy," including the excessively coercive dimension it took in some regions and the gap between the policy and the aspirations and needs of the masses.[278] But internal dissent within the political system itself also played a key role in creating obstacles to the normalization of the OCP, as we have seen in Chapter 3.

It is therefore evident that the dysfunctions of the "one-child policy" cannot be explained through the image of a simple hierarchical "tree," where a firm implementation promoted by the "trunk" or the "center" weakens proportionally with distance from this "center." The inconsistencies, failures in achieving global objectives, as well as the excesses recorded in numerous local or regional cases, find their underlying reason in the mechanical application of tools and methods that are

[275] Huang, Yang, "Population Control and State Coercion in China", p.218.
[276] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.221-223.
[277] Wang et al., "Population, Policy, and Politics”, p.127 (nota).
[278] Banister, "Population Policy and Trends in China", p.724.

ill-suited to the *entire* command and control structure that must use them. Between 1979 and 1983, driven by the Westernizing current at its peak, the fundamental system of evaluation and promotion of cadres underwent a profound reform, with a trend that was strongly technocratic:

> it moved in the direction of placing greater weight on the assessment of concrete achievements rather than political attitudes or work style, and it reiterated the importance of such criteria in determining material rewards and penalties as well as promotions.
>
> [...]
>
> Commentators emphasized the importance of moving away from what were seen as subjective evaluations of political attitudes toward specific, measurable, and quantifiable indicators of performance.[279]

Among these performance indicators were, of course, those related to "family planning," which were translated through various forms of implementing decrees into the famous "quotas." This was an application of models inspired by Western business management, which, when applied to the complex demographic dynamics of China, showed evident weaknesses. First and foremost, the introduction of quantifiable indicators in place of previous political assessments pushed the system towards the development of what Mark Fisher has termed the "audit culture": work became oriented towards producing and manipulating indicators, rather than being equipped for achieving real objectives. The natural reaction of officials subjected to this new type of evaluation was, therefore, to invest time, energy, and money in trying to represent an improvement in results through these indicators as quickly as possible, rather than working on creating favorable conditions for the sustainable and long-term achievement of the goals that these indicators were meant to measure. Susan Whiting, although not delving into the specifics of performance measures related to birth control, highlights the deviations that such reforms produced in China

[279] Susan H. Whiting, "The Cadre Evaluation System at the Grass Roots: The Paradox of Party Rule", in *Holding China Together: Diversity and National Integration in the Post-Deng Era*, edited by Barry Naughton and Dali L. Yang, Cambridge (United Kingdom), Cambridge University Press, 2004, p.102.

during the 1980s.[280] The manipulation of indicators by intermediate officials would explain both the excesses recorded during the campaigns of 1983 and 1990—where local leaders, driven to push fertility rates down at all costs, pursued actual reductions in completed pregnancies by any means necessary—and the fertility rebounds in the years 1985-1987, with the general failure to meet the original goals of the OCP. This latter issue often stemmed from officials who, more or less consciously, merely contributed to hiding the real data.

In summary, what is still imagined in popular culture today as a decades-long strict "one-child policy" actually reveals three major flaws:

1. It was not an organic policy implemented by a consistently neo-Malthusian leadership, but rather a disjointed collection of instructions, directives, control mechanisms, and one-off campaigns with evident contradictions and ambiguities at all hierarchical levels, including the highest.

2. It provoked a strong reaction from the population, particularly from the rural areas, which was not ignored by academia, the press, and the Chinese political system. This reaction, besides explicit criticism, also resulted in the development of a diverse set of strategies to circumvent the regulation.

3. The introduction of unsuitable control and evaluation methods contributed to the overall success of these population defense strategies; this occurred despite specific cases where these methods did effectively lower birth rates, but were accompanied by abuses that created scandals and undermined the legitimacy of the policy itself.

[280] Whiting writes: "local versions of the cadre evaluation system combined specific performance-based measures with high-powered incentives. Formal principal–agent models predict that this combination will cause severe moral hazard problems, or what Baker et al. (1988) refer to as "gaming the system"[…]. Drawing on the insights of formal principal–agent models, I argue that the nature of the cadre evaluation system in China led to certain dysfunctional aspects of policy implementation at the grass roots. […] The sheer number and variety of tasks evaluated through performance-based measures posed additional problems. Specifically, multiple indicators were not necessarily mutually compatible. For example, performance on industrial profits and public order were at times in conflict. […] The continued reliance on performance-based measures and high-powered incentives is puzzling in light of the severe moral hazard problems and multitask coordination problems encountered during the implementation of the cadre evaluation system at the local level in China."; See Whiting, "The Cadre Evaluation System at the Grass Roots", pp.112-118.

Therefore, the OCP "worked" only where social and economic conditions were already mature for reducing the number of children per woman, namely in the more urbanized and developed areas:

> In some of the largest and most advanced cities like Shanghai, sizeable proportions of couples already chose to have only one child. Both adults worked full time with long hours; the housing allocation was only 3.6 m2 per person in 1977; [...] In most families, at least one member would be employed in the state sector and susceptible to government direction. As a result, it was not long before 90% of couples in urban areas were persuaded to restrict their families to a single child.[281]

It "failed" in rural areas, where the social fabric was not ready to embrace the "one-child" family model, and where the population responded to the "Westernizing" modernization not only with evasion strategies but also with ideological tools that resulted from an apparently paradoxical blend of Maoism and traditional Chinese culture:

> The natural science that produced the new one-child norm defined social and cultural factors as irrelevant. Yet of course it was China's social structure and culture that gave local society the community reproductive norms that it would at times staunchly defend against the scientific norms of the state. The state labeled those social and cultural forces "feudal" and targeted them for eradication through "modernization." Yet they forced themselves in through the back door, impressing themselves first on informal community policies and then on formal national policy through the workings of the mass line. Social and cultural forces, in particular family socioeconomics and gender values, would come to play critical roles in the Chinese politics of population, leaving their imprint on the nature, intensity, and outcome of those negotiations and struggles.[282]

The question of whether the One-Child Policy (OCP) "worked" should thus be

[281] Penny Kane, Choi Ching Y., "China's one child family policy", *The BMJ* (formerly *The British Medical Journal*), 1999; 319, London (United Kingdom), British Medical Association, 1999, p.993.

[282] Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.215.

understood not as an attempt to determine how many births the OCP actually prevented—an endeavor that would clearly be speculative—but rather as an examination of whether, regardless of its demographic impact, the OCP functioned *in practice* as its proponents had envisioned it *ideally.* In response to this specific formulation of the question "Did the OCP work?", the answer appears much simpler and is a definitive "No." Nevertheless, we can still draw a more detailed assessment.

In its actual implementation, if the Chinese demographic policy from the 1980s to 2013 must be summarized as a single comprehensive approach, it cannot be defined as a "One-Child Policy" but rather as a "One-Child-and-a-Half Policy." This expression, in our view, encapsulates both the coercive and the lenient aspects, highlights the inherent ambiguity of the policy, and is naturally more faithful to the real numbers reflected in the statistics:

> the One-Child Policy at no time required all Chinese citizens to have only one child. Even in the early 1980s, when official zeal concerning the implementation of fertility limits ran the highest, members of China's 55 ethnic minority groups (who represented about eight percent of the total population) were exempt from birth planning limits. Starting in 1984, after official acknowledgment that China was home to a category of people whose 'practical difficulties' rendered it unrealistic for them to have only one child, there has been a varied patchwork of shifting exceptions over time.
>
> Indeed, some have estimated that *by 2000, less than half of Chinese couples were required to limit themselves to one child*, and these were largely urban people on China's eastern seaboard.[283]

Huang and Yang note that in the early 1990s, only five highly urbanized provinces (Beijing, Tianjin, Shanghai, Jiangsu, and Sichuan) can be considered as practicing a "demographic radicalism" with a strong emphasis on the one-child policy for every couple. In contrast, provinces with high percentages of ethnic minorities, such as Xinjiang and Tibet, effectively do not enforce limits on the number of children, while the majority of the country falls into an intermediate situation between these two

[283] Rachel Riley, *The Experiment of Eight Million People: An Investigation into the Process of Designing Social Policies in China*, Brasenose College, University of Oxford, 2017, p.15. The italics are ours.

extremes.

In a field study conducted in rural Central China, Chu Junhong recorded the following data on the number of children per woman, segmented by age groups during the Spring Festival of the year 2000. The data are presented in percentages except for the last column:

Age group	0	1	2	3+	Cases
20–24	12	83	3	2	58
25–29	2	76	22	0	225
30–34	0	27	63	10	307
35–39	0	4	62	34	160
40–44	0	1	62	37	70
Total	1	38	47	14	820

Fig.5.3 – Number of children per woman by age group. Source: Chu Junhong, "Prenatal Sex Determination and Sex-Selective Abortion in Rural Central China", *Population and Development Review*, Jun. 2001, Vol. 27, No. 2, pp. 259-281, New York (USA), Population Council, 2001.

Women in the age groups 40-44 and 35-39 were born between 1956 and 1965; they were thus in their peak fertility period (i.e., ages 20 to 29) during the most intense and restrictive phase of the OCP. By 2000, a negligible minority of these women had only one child, while 62% had two children and over 30% had three or more. This is a prevalent reality in rural China, whereas in urban areas, Hsu reports that as early as 1981, when the OCP had not yet fully taken effect, "families in metropolises and cities had already effectively achieved the goal of one child per family."[284] As can also be seen from the map below, these are the same provinces that were subjected to the most stringent limits:

[284] Hsu Mei-Ling, "Growth and Control of Population in China", p.249

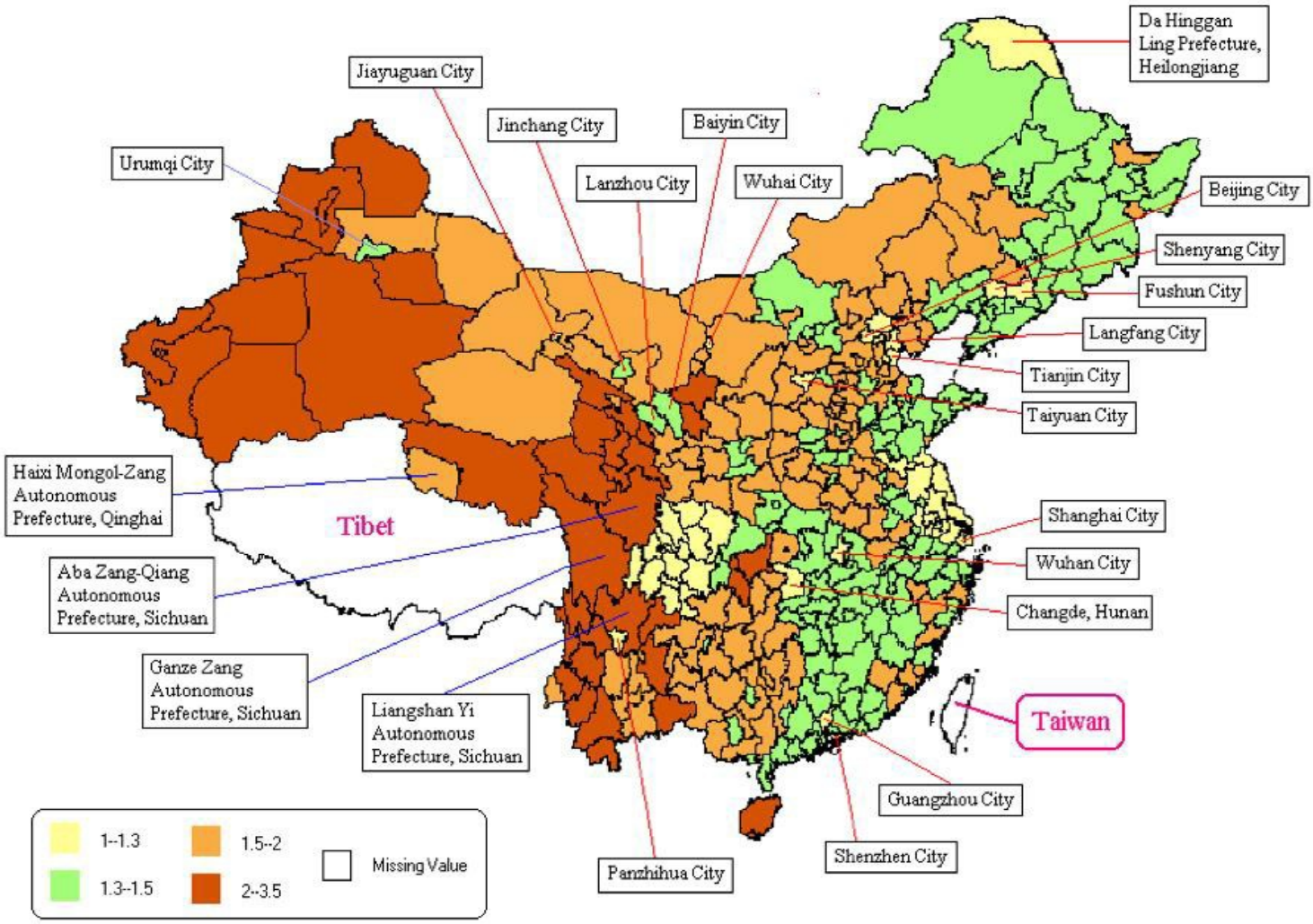

Fig.5.4 – Map of Fertility Control Policies during the First Decade of the 2000s (Official Number of Children Allowed Without Penalty). Source: Riley, *The Experiment of Eight Million People*, p.15

A "one-and-a-half-child policy", therefore, which in practice did not merely serve as a population *containment* measure but had *redistributive* effects: it acted as a relative intergenerational barrier to the migration from rural areas to cities. From this perspective, the OCP was a measure that only partially compensated for the end of the active population relocation policies from cities to rural areas that were promoted under Mao Zedong. Even the stricter restrictions imposed by the household registration system or "internal passport" (hukou) during Deng Xiaoping's era were part of a set of norms attempting to curb the uncontrolled urbanization that followed the launch of the Reform and Opening Up. Just like the issue of reducing the fertility rate, the question of internal migration went through a similar process of 1) depoliticization towards legal-administrative management, 2) increased formal restrictions, and 3) substantial failure to achieve the set objectives.[285] But the demographic redistribution promoted by the OCP did not only attempt to rebalance rural and urban populations: it also operated on an ethnic level.

Ethnic minorities were entirely exempt from the OCP until 1990, when a limit was introduced for them that was still higher than for Han families—two children in urban areas and three or four children in rural areas;[286] This policy translates over the years into an increase in the percentage relevance of these minorities within the total population. In 1979, there were approximately 40 million Chinese belonging to one of the 55 non-Han ethnic-linguistic groups, representing 6% of the total population. The most recent census conducted in 2020 reported a total of 125.47 million minority group members, which is about 9% of the entire Chinese population.[287] This is perhaps a unique case in history where an ethnic majority in power (Han) actively and directly promotes its own relative demographic reduction in favor of minorities. When the OCP was definitively abandoned in 2013 and replaced with the universal two-child policy, the complex regime of exceptions, including those concerning

[285] Yu Y.C., "The Population Policy of China", *Population Studies*,Vol. 33, No. 1 (Mar., 1979), London (United Kingdom), Taylor & Francis, 1979, pp.130-133.

[286] This limit still excluded the Tibetan ethnicity, according to the rule "No Limits for Tibetans." Also, this birth-limitation rule often remained largely theoretical, as minorities frequently resided in more remote areas of China, where it was very challenging for the government apparatus to implement effective control. See Wang et al., "Ending an Era of Population Control in China"p. 948.

[287] Hua Xia, "Ethnic minority proportion in China's population rises", *XinhuaNet*, Xinhua, <http://www.xinhuanet.com/english/2021-05/11/c_139938133.htm>, last consultation 21/04/2023.

ethnic minorities, was also discontinued.[288] It is reasonable to hypothesize that the significant increase in the number of IUD insertions and the drastic reduction in fertility rates among the Uighur ethnicity in Xinjiang can be attributed to the implementation of the Universal Two-Child Policy starting in 2013. Since this ethnic group was not previously subjected to any birth control measures, a universal policy that represented a relaxation for the majority of the Chinese population translated into a sudden and severe restriction for the Uighurs. Interestingly, the rapid decline in fertility among Uighur women primarily occurs during the years 2013-2016, a period when the provincial government had not yet enforced particularly stringent containment measures. Meanwhile, literacy rates and school enrollment at all levels had increased exponentially due to the application of a previous radical policy in this field (Xinjiang mandates 15 years of compulsory education). When, in 2016, the new governor of the province began promoting the adoption of more coercive methods, a reaction phenomenon occurred, similar to the broader context of the One-Child Policy in the 1980s, albeit on a smaller scale. This resulted in a noticeable slowdown in the decline of the fertility rate among the Uighurs. Between 2019 and 2020, with the effective abandonment of birth reduction policies in China, pressures on Uighur women in this regard also ceased. Throughout the period from the introduction of the One-Child Policy in 1980 to the present day, the fertility rate among the Uighur minority has consistently remained higher than that of the Han ethnic group, maintaining a relatively stable proportion. Therefore, the accusations of "genocide" directed at the Chinese government seem unfounded. It is noteworthy that the only study raising such accusations based on primary sources carefully avoids mentioning that the Uighurs were never subjected to the "One-Child Policy," thus omitting a crucial contextual element for understanding the phenomenon. A clearer perspective was provided in 2022 by Yi Fuxian, one of the most prominent researchers opposing direct birth control policies, in an article published in the Japan Times, from which most of the information above is drawn.[289] Yi is also the author of *Big Country with an Empty Nest*, a book initially censored in China, then authorized in 2013, the same

[288] See Adrian Zenz, *Sterilizations, IUDs, and Mandatory Birth Control: the CCP's Campaign to suppress Uyghur Birthrates in Xinjiang*, Washington DC (USA), Jamestown Foundation, 2020. We will come back on Zenz's work later.

[289] Cfr. Yi Fuxian, "Why is the Uyghur population shrinking?", *Japan Times,* 18 Luglio 2022, <https://www.japantimes.co.jp/opinion/2022/07/18/commentary/world-commentary/uyghur-birthrate-collapse>, last consultation 22 Aprile 2023.

year the formal process of abolishing the One-Child Policy began, and which became a bestseller. In the book, Yi predicts a future collapse of the Chinese population due to the demographic control policies adopted over the previous thirty years. The population decline and aging anticipated by Yi and others now appear as the new major demographic challenge that China will face for the remainder of this century.

CONCLUSION

"How will the One-Child Policy be judged by History?"

Then the king said, "Bring me a sword." So they brought a sword for the king.
He then gave an order: "Cut the living child in two and give half to one and half to the other."
The woman whose son was alive was deeply moved out of love for her son and said to the king, "Please, my lord, give her the living baby! Don't kill him!"
But the other said, "Neither I nor you shall have him. Cut him in two!"
Then the king gave his ruling: "Give the living baby to the first woman. Do not kill him; she is his mother."

1 Kings 3:24-27 - 21st Century King James Version

The reference to "one child and a half" as the title for this work is not only a choice based on the statistical data that, as we have seen, better represents the concrete reality of Chinese demographic policies between 1980 and 2015. It is also intended to provoke a slight and immediate discomfort, in the ambiguity between the concept of "1.5 children authorized per woman," which is entirely understandable but not immediately easy to visualize, and the shocking image evoked by the idea of children divided "in half." This rhetorical use of reproductive issues, since the time of the writing of the Jewish chronicles, has been mobilized for political purposes, probably less noble than those of King Solomon. The "one and a half child policy" is an important element in the construction of narratives that, as historians, we believe it is necessary to contextualize, criticize, and filter.

At the end of the historical summary of the "one-child policy" that we have addressed, revisiting the quotes with which we introduced this work, we immediately realize the issues of rhetorical—and often factual—distortion that we have raised. Currently the Wikipedia entry on the OCP states:

> After a full decade of concerted efforts, a near universal one-child limit was imposed in 1980. It was then officially written into the constitution of the People's Republic of China in 1982.[290]

The statement that "The OCP was enshrined in the Constitution in 1982" is also the first piece of information presented in white text on a black background in a recent successful documentary produced by Amazon on the subject.[291]

In light of what we have found in this research, these informational tools—the primary and often the only sources most people interested in the issue will access—are laden with gross distortions. As we have seen, for example, "the one-child policy was never enacted into law," nor was it included in the 1982 Chinese Constitution, which only mandated the adoption and implementation of a "Family Planning" policy.[292] The notions that the OCP was a "law introduced in an organic manner" or that it was "almost universal" are contradicted by the facts. Even the notorious online encyclopedia Treccani presents incorrect information when it associates the 2002 law with restrictions that were actually relaxed by the mid-1990s, or when it mentions the exclusion of "some" ethnic minorities, while in reality, *all* ethnic minorities in China enjoyed an exemption from the one-child policy and were subject to the same rules as Han only during the phase of the "universal two-child policy," which was in effect from 2015 to 2020.

An equally distorting effect is achieved by removing the historical context, particularly the origin of the OCP and the support it received in its early days in the West. It can be said that it is these omissions, rather than inaccurate information, that most distort the overall image of contemporary China.[293] Susan Greenhalgh, one of the leading global critics of the OCP, recognizes that the Western interpretation of China's demographic policy has been plagued by purely ideological biases:

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[290] "One-child policy", *Wikipedia*, Wikimedia Foundation, <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/One-child_policy>, consulted on 06/03/2023.

[291] Wang Nanfu, Zhang Jialing, *One Child Nation*, Amazon Studios, 2019.

[292] Huang, Yang, "Population Control and State Coercion in China", p.199; Cfr. Yu, "The Population Policy of China", p.128, e Wong, "Consequences of China's New Population Policy", pp.220-221

[293] Cfr. Davis, *Late Victorian Holocausts*, p.8.

> American understandings of the policy have been shaped by anticommunist strands in American political culture into a narrative of "communist coercion." Throughout the 1980s and 1990s, powerful media images of coerced abortions, family planning jails, orphanage dying rooms, and much more created an intense interest in the policy among the general public, while giving fresh life to cold war notions of China as "totalitarian Other," the foil to the "democratic West."[294]

Just a few pages earlier, however, Greenhalgh herself seems to inevitably fall into the very rhetorical trap she so skillfully delineates, reducing the entire experience of the People's Republic before the Deng era to "the horrors of Maoism."[295]; As we have seen, at least regarding women's rights battles, such a reductive judgment is not justifiable. King White and his research team argue that the same results of the OCP could have been achieved "by implementing a policy of two children spaced apart," which "would not have damaged China's international reputation so much"[296], except for then arguing that the *Wan Xi Shao* policy, which preceded the OCP and imposed no formal limits or sanctions, was still "violent" and "coercive." John Ross adopts the term used by some Chinese observers to describe this approach, namely "historical nihilism," which refers to

> the assertion that prior to accelerated economic growth after 1978 China's achievements from 1949 until that date were negligible or even negative. A similar claim is that, despite China's rapid economic growth after 1978 this was outweighed by negative trends in social, environmental or other fields.[297]

These are variations on the theme of a China that seems to always be at fault, regardless of the circumstances. A notable example in this context is the introduction of the concept of "feticide" in significant scientific publications, such as in the work of Greenhalgh and Winckler[298], without defining any meaningful difference between

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294 Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.2.
295 *Ivi*, p.xi.
296 King Whyte, "Modifying China's One-Child Policy", p.2.
297 Ross, *China's Great Road*, p.17.
298 Greenhalgh, Winckler, *Governing China's Population*, p.227.

this term and the much more neutral term "abortion." We have also observed how Aird clearly employs similar motivations when he titles his work on the OCP *The Massacre of the Innocents.*[299] While it is entirely understandable that such terms might be adopted by researchers firmly rooted in fundamentalist Christianity,[300] The spurious use of such terms as “feticide” by scholars who, in any other context, would not hesitate to defend the right to abortion seems to respond simply to the adoption of an unacceptable double standard towards Chinese women. Therefore, we believe that the question posed by the demographers of the Wang group, authors of the 2013 article “How Will History Judge China’s One-Child Policy?” should first be preceded by another question: based on what historical notions of the OCP can such a judgment be drawn? Is it really possible to produce a sufficiently objective assessment of any historical fact related to contemporary China, within a context

[299] Cfr. p.89.

[300] Perhaps the most prominent example of a researcher openly aligned with a religious fundamentalist front opposing the Chinese government is Adrian Zenz. As noted earlier, Zenz is currently the sole author of a study asserting that a genocide against the Uighur ethnic group is occurring based on primary sources (all other studies and articles we briefly reviewed seem to refer to Zenz's work). Zenz is a self-declared apocalyptic Christian fundamentalist and co-authored a book in 2012 with his father-in-law Marlon Sias, which openly predicts the imminent End of the World and the rapture of true believers while the rest of humanity is destroyed by the flames of Armageddon. In the same book, Zenz calls for "spiritual" corporal punishment of children, labels gender equality as a “satanic campaign,” and describes “tolerant” views on homosexuality as “deceptive powers of the Antichrist.” It is reasonable to question how these views might influence the work of someone affiliated with extremist evangelical movements banned by China. For example, can an outspoken advocate for the abolition of all forms of birth control on religious grounds be considered reliable when discussing campaigns of “sterilization” or “genocide” in a region where contraceptives and the right to abortion are systematically introduced for the first time under acceptable health conditions? Zenz also works at the Victims of Communism Memorial Foundation, which has added all global COVID-19 deaths to the list of “victims of communism,” blaming the Chinese Communist Party as the sole perpetrator of the pandemic. Zenz's study should nevertheless be assessed primarily based on the quality of its content. However, the weaknesses in the German researcher's approach are evident. For example, phrases are taken out of context from his sources, drastically altering their meaning. Thus, the creation of free nurseries and kindergartens for Uighur worker families, as promoted in the official documents cited by Zenz, is transformed into a "program of intergenerational separation aimed at suppressing traditional culture." Similarly, a local news report where a mother expresses gratitude for being able to work while her children are at school is interpreted as a "shocking example of [...] 'liberation' of women from their children." The birth control data presented by Zenz are sometimes so inaccurate that even media outlets that use him as a source tend to avoid citing them. For instance, the percentage of intrauterine devices (IUDs) distributed by the government in Xinjiang is reported as going from 8.7% of Zenz's primary source to "more than 80%" in the paper's text. Zenz's claim of "more than 800 IUDs inserted per capita annually" implies that every woman in Xinjiang, Uighur or not, would need to have at least four IUDs inserted daily. Even the most fervent political critic of China must acknowledge the poor quality of the material produced by the German researcher, which is published by the Jamestown Foundation, an organization outside any peer-review network. See Adrian Zenz, *Sterilizations, IUDs, and Mandatory Birth Control: the CCP's Campaign to suppress Uyghur Birthrates in Xinjiang*, Washington DC (USA), Jamestown Foundation, 2020; Adrian Zenz, Marlon L. Sias, *Worthy to Escape. Why All Believers Will Not Be Raptured Before the Tribulation*, Westbow Press, Bloomington (USA), 2012.

where every knowledge production seems to be inevitably co-opted into a binary Cold War discourse? During the research for this work, regardless of the individual authors' orientations, we consistently felt as though we were encountering narrative constructions that aligned with what Foucault describes as the “discourse-power axis,” as opposed to the “cognition-truth axis.” Depending on the goal of each analyzed work, certain aspects were emphasized while others were omitted based on what was deemed useful for producing well-regulated knowledge.[301] In this work, we have only scratched the surface of the demographic issues in contemporary China. However, by specifically examining the "one-child policy" and the science surrounding it through a genealogical approach, we can draw an important conclusion: as the available data on the "historical object OCP" increases, new layers of complexity emerge in its global analysis, almost blurring all the aspects highlighted by the most prevalent simplistic narratives—whether apologetic or violently critical. Long-term cultural and historical factors, even seemingly unrelated to population sciences, turn out to be the most determining in Chinese demographic dynamics. Consequently, even the analysis of a highly controversial issue like the "one-child policy" tends to become almost "uninteresting" outside the narrow field of sector-specific studies, because of its complexity. Thus, there is a strong temptation to extrapolate, periodize, and arbitrarily compare data and facts to support sufficiently original and stimulating arguments, especially when ideologically oriented. For the historian who wishes to address this topic, the problem raised by Carlo Ginzburg is particularly relevant:

> The quantitative and anthropocentric approach of the natural sciences since Galileo has placed the human sciences in an uncomfortable dilemma: either adopt a weak scientific status to achieve significant results, or adopt a strong scientific status to achieve results of little relevance.[302]

From the perspective of gender history, although marked by events and processes different from those experienced by women in the West, the path of Chinese women

[301] Michel Foucault, *Society Must Be Defended. Lectures at the Collège de France, 1975-76*, New York (USA), Picador, 2003, pp.178-181.
[302] Quoted in Vitali, p.24.

has often led them to confront issues very similar to those faced by women worldwide today. The challenges they have faced and continue to face certainly demonstrate that, as Margery Wolf states, "it would be unwise to assume that perfect socialism would necessarily create a feminist utopia."[303] At the same time, the international women's rights cause would gain new and important tools if the experience of Chinese women were better included in its entirety and complexity, by producing and disseminating new narratives that focus not only on the tragedies of the distant and recent past, but also on the extraordinary achievements they have attained since the foundation of the People's Republic of China.

Photo: Alberto Rotundo, September 2023.

[303] Wolf, *Revolution Postponed*, p.261.

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